

CHESS99 BOOK 1 | ELO -300 | FREE

The First Chessboard

Rules, coordinates, pieces, and the confidence to play a legal first game.

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Board Coordinates And The First Map

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Before pieces make sense, the board must become a map.

Learning objectives

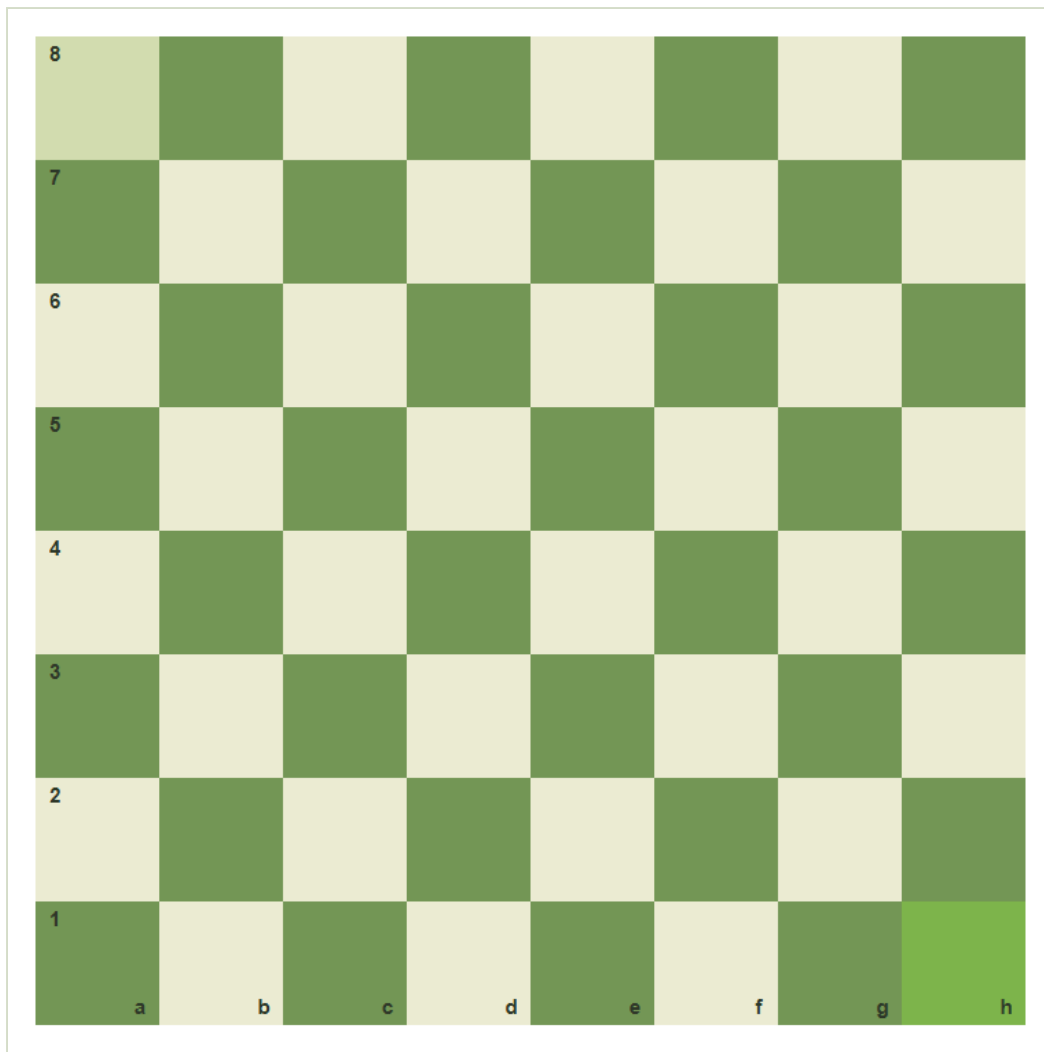
- Recognize the correct board orientation.
- Name files, ranks, and coordinates.
- Read a move as from-square to to-square.
- Play 1.e4 from the starting position.

The Board Is A Map

A chessboard is not only 64 squares. It is a map. Strong players do not say "move this pawn up two." They say **e2 to e4** because the square names let everyone see the same position in their mind.

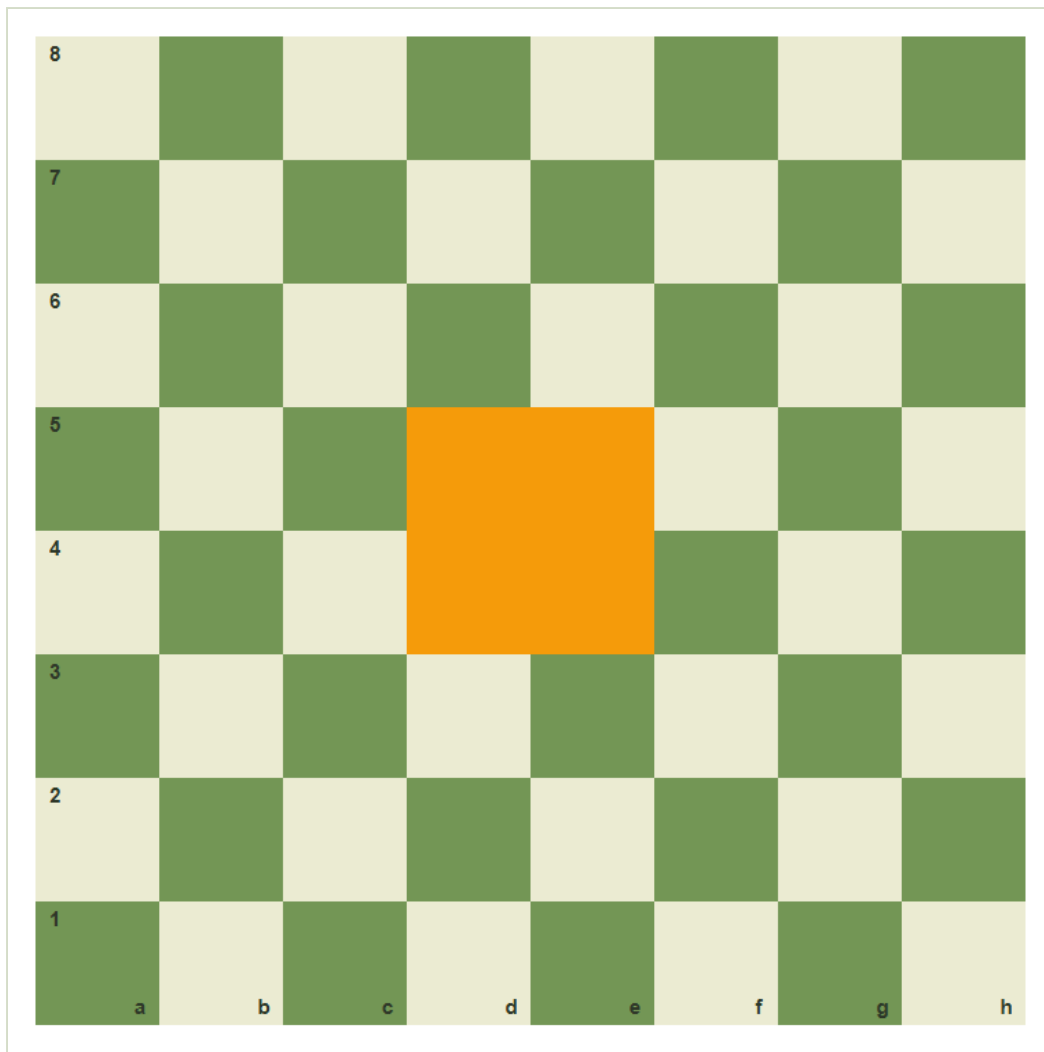
In this chapter, you will learn the board language that every later lesson will use.

The empty board



Correct setup starts with a light square on White's bottom-right corner: h1.

The four center squares



The center squares d4, e4, d5, and e5 are marked because later your pieces will fight for them.

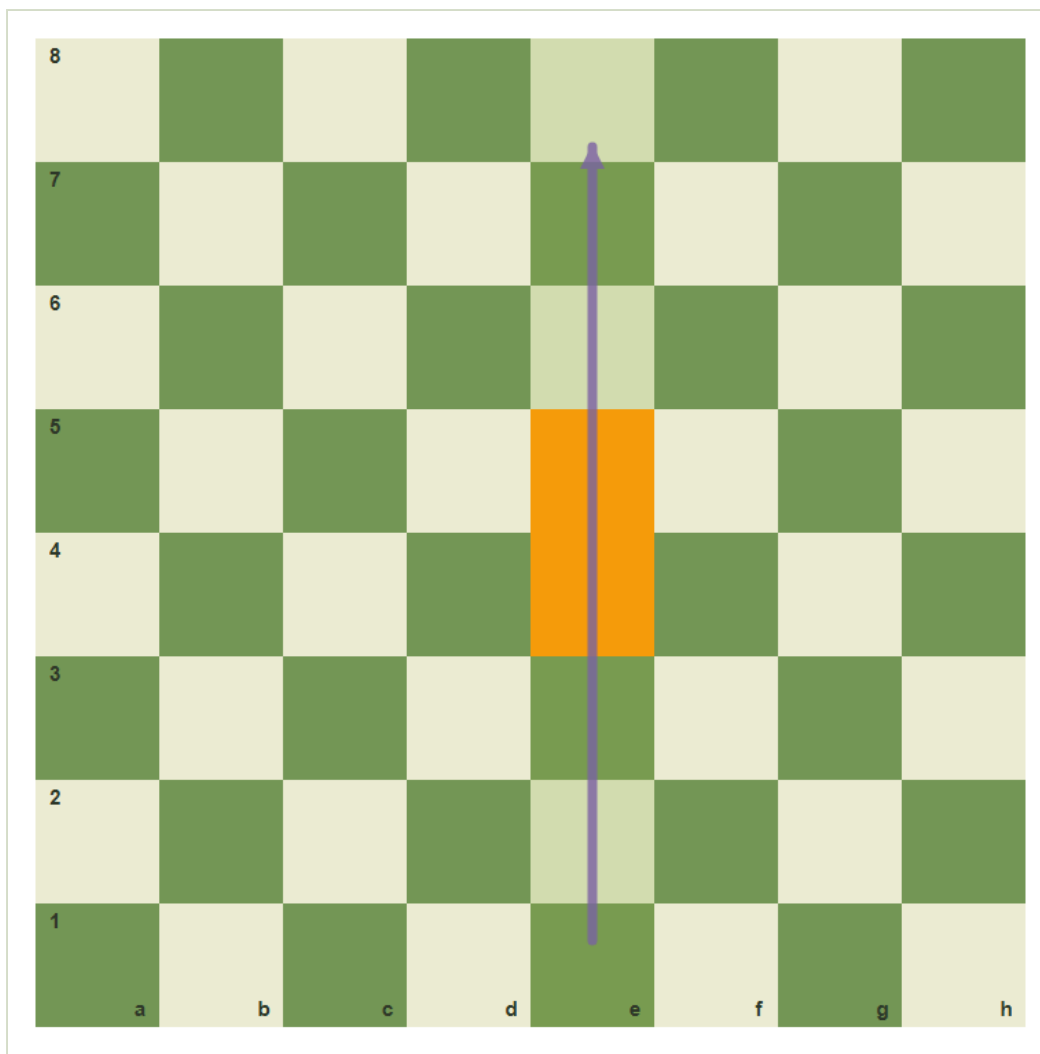
Files, Ranks, And Square Names

The vertical columns are **files**. They are named a through h from White's left to White's right.

The horizontal rows are **ranks**. They are numbered 1 through 8 from White's side toward Black's side.

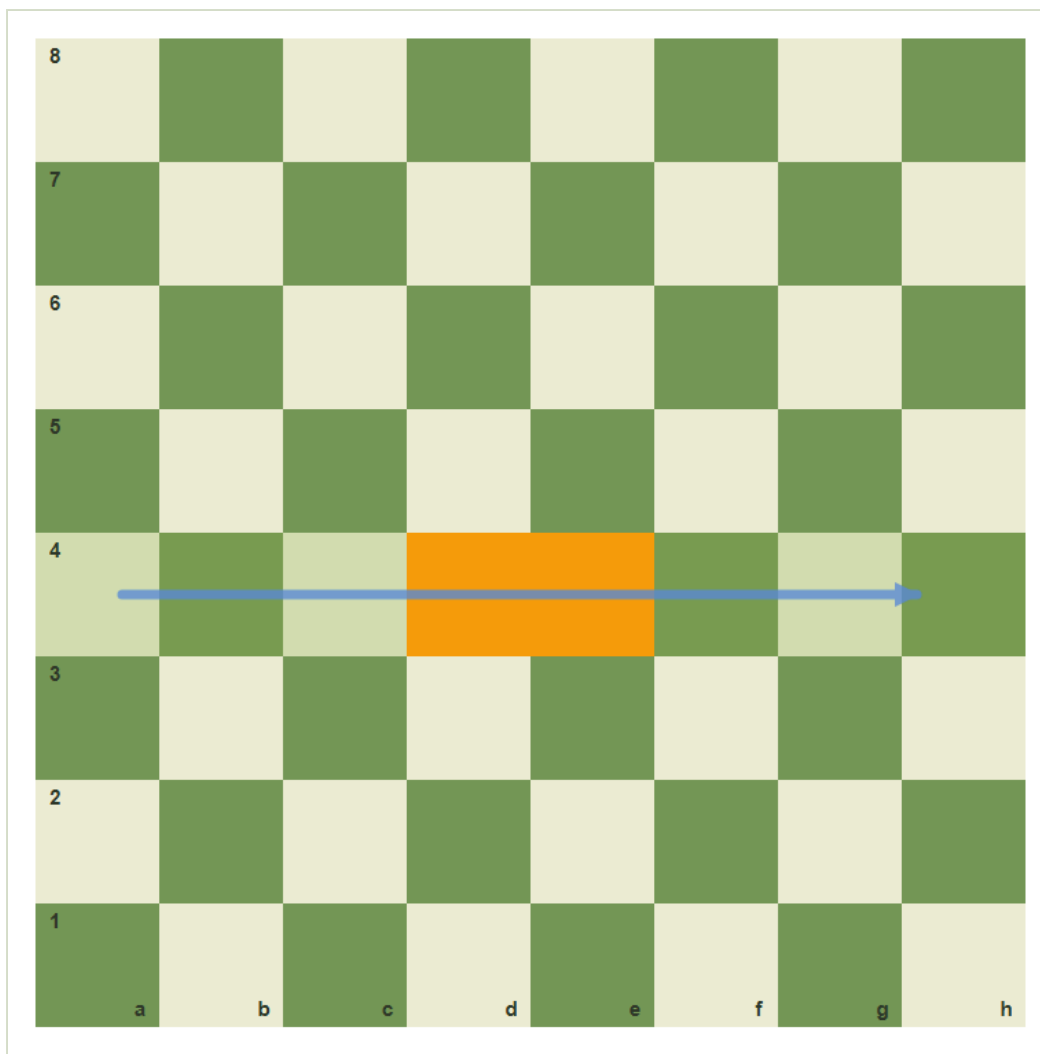
A square name is file plus rank. The square **e4** means the e-file and the 4th rank.

The e-file



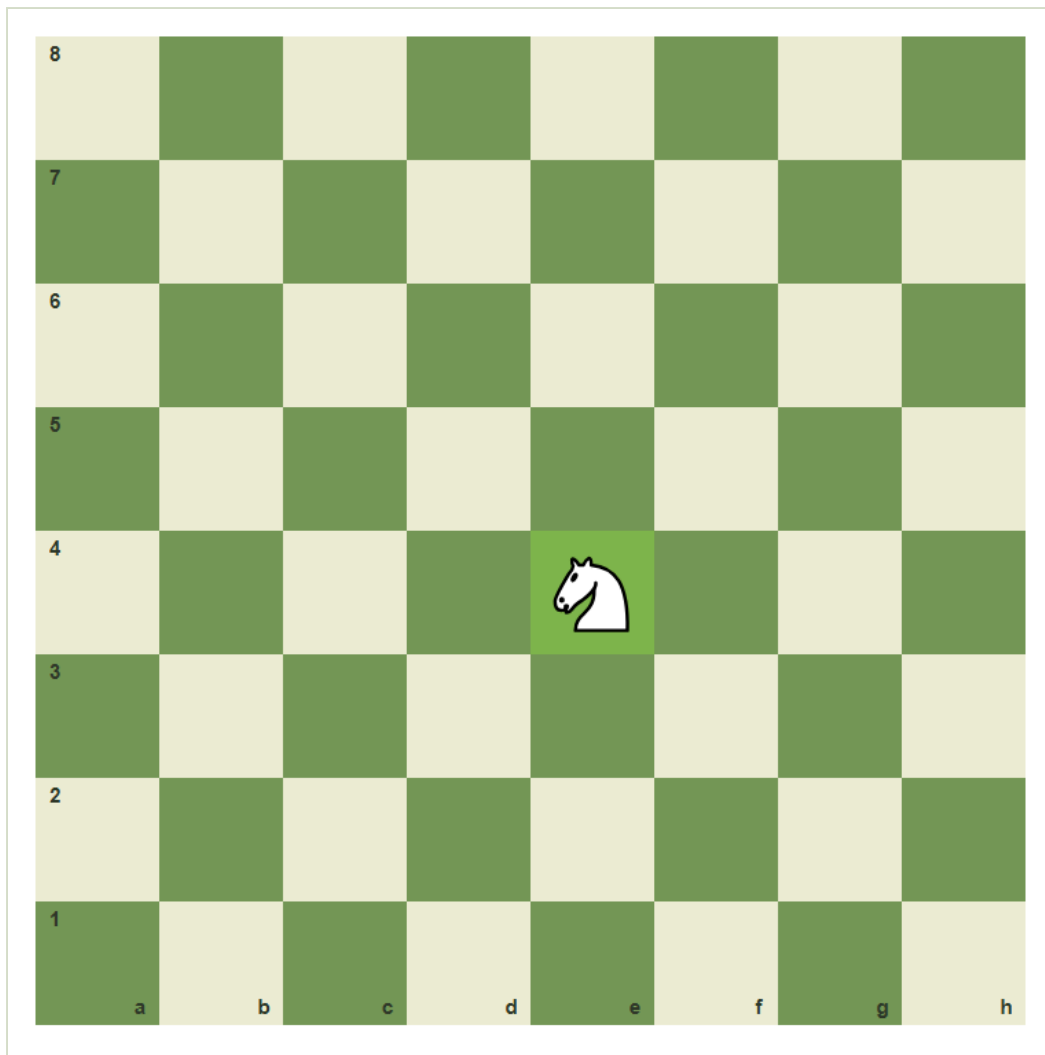
Every square in this column starts with e: e1, e2, e3, and so on.

The 4th rank



Every square in this row ends with 4: a4, b4, c4, d4, e4, f4, g4, h4.

A piece on e4



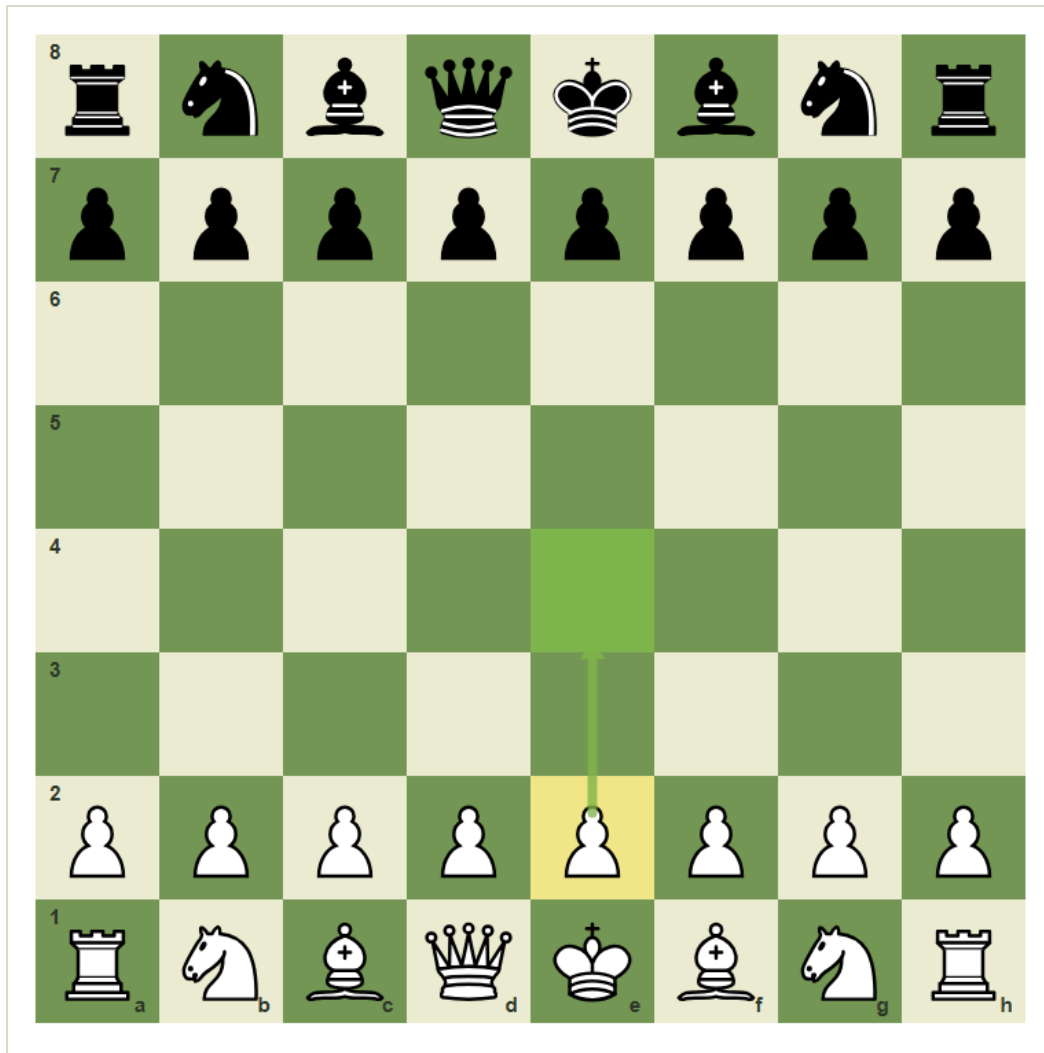
The knight is on e4: e-file, 4th rank. Say it aloud before moving on.

A Move Has Two Squares

A written move often starts with two coordinates: the square the piece leaves and the square it lands on.

For example, **e2e4** means: take the piece on e2 and move it to e4. In a normal starting position, that piece is White's king pawn.

Before 1.e4

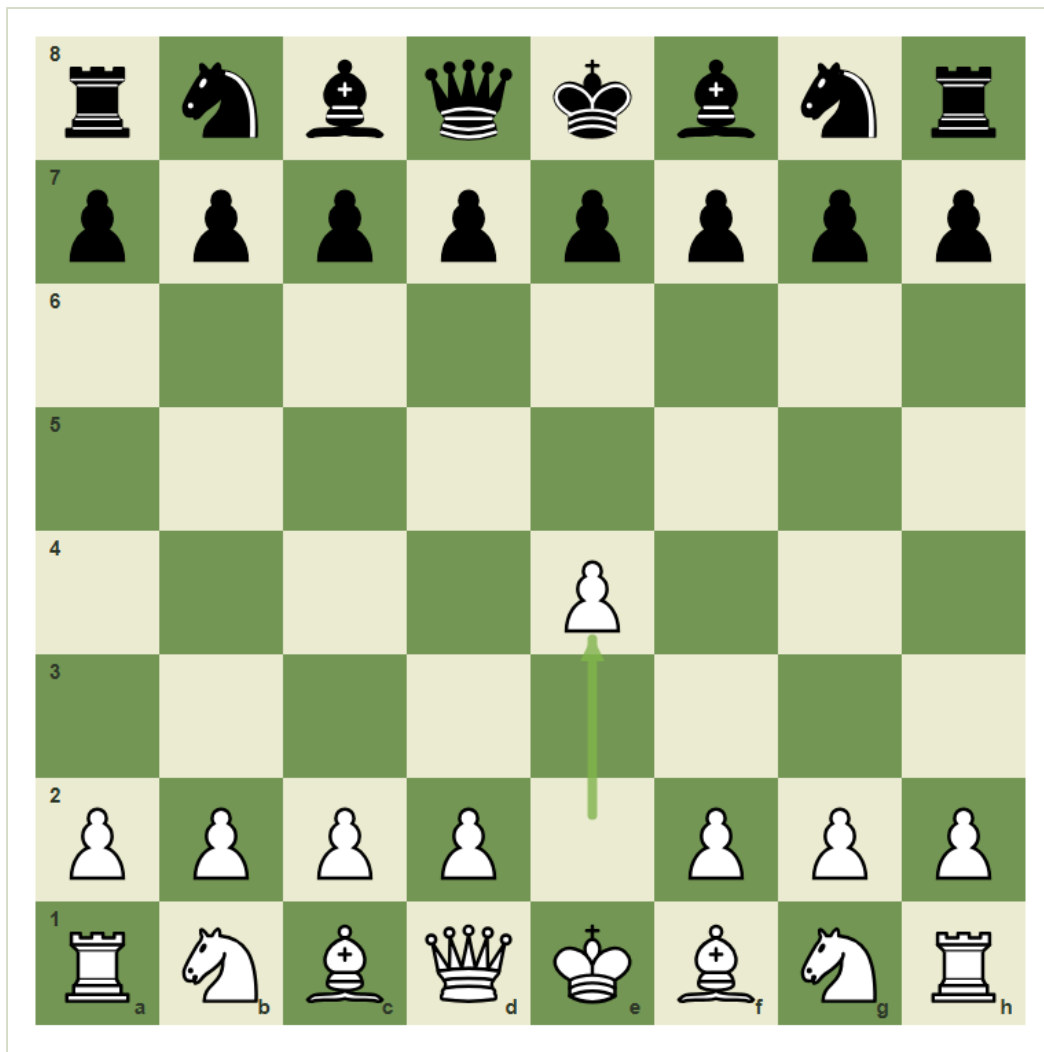


The arrow shows the pawn's first move: e2 to e4.

Play e2 to e4

Move the pawn from e2 to e4. Use the coordinates, not guesswork.

The board after 1.e4

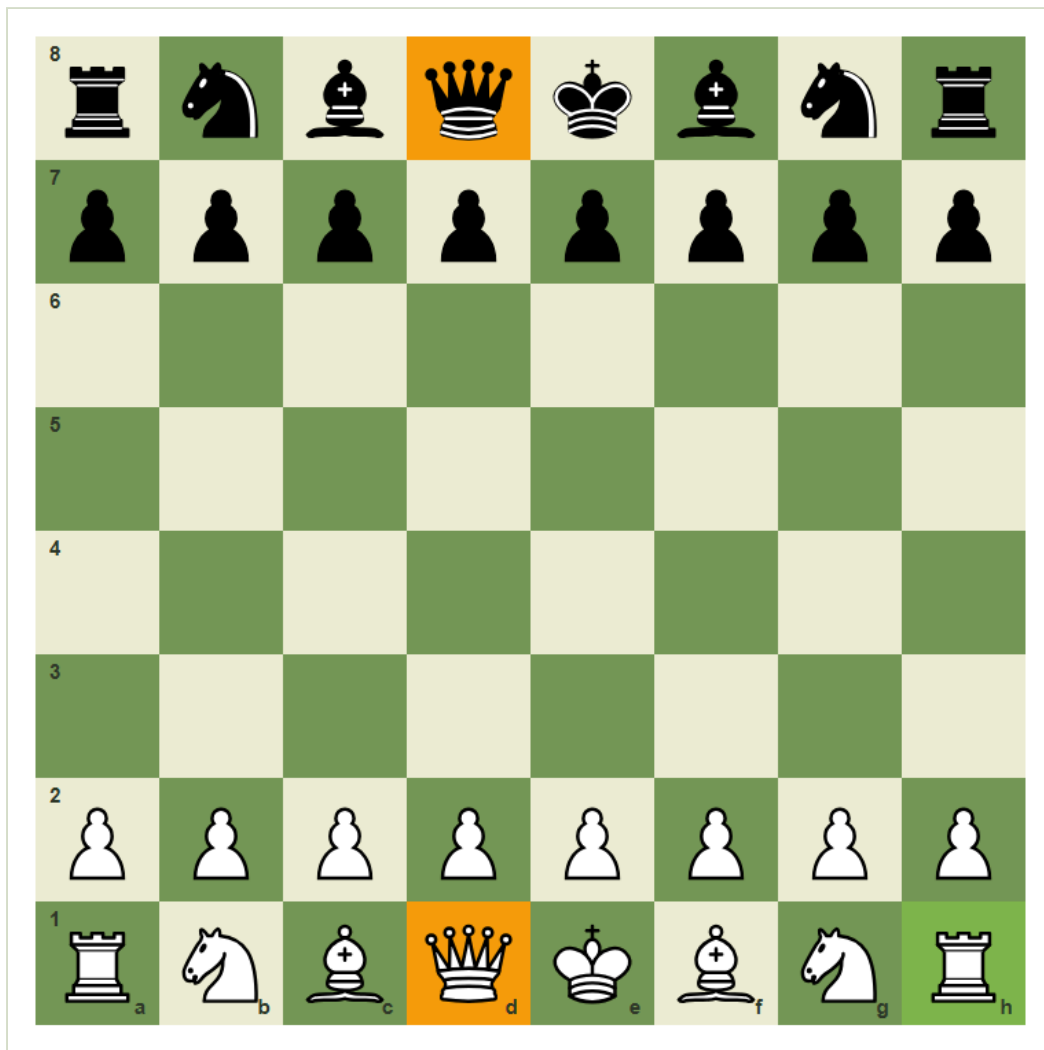


After e2e4, the pawn leaves e2 and stands on e4. The move also opens lines for White's queen and bishop.

Common Mistake: Trusting The Picture, Not The Coordinates

Wrong board orientation ruins every square name

If the board is rotated incorrectly in real life, every coordinate becomes unreliable. The simple check is: **light square on the right** for White. Then queens start on their own color: White queen on d1, Black queen on d8.



h1 is the orientation check. d1 and d8 show the queen-on-own-color rule.

Checkpoint: name the square

A knight is placed on the e-file and the 4th rank. What square is it on?

- a. d4
- b. e4
- c. 4e

Chapter Checkpoint

Which square is White's bottom-right corner?

With White at the bottom, the bottom-right corner is:

- a. a1
- b. h1
- c. h8

How do you read e2e4?

The move e2e4 means:

- a. Move from e2 to e4
- b. Move from e4 to e2
- c. Move any pawn two squares

Pieces, Values, And Setup

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The board is a map; now learn the army that lives on it.

Learning objectives

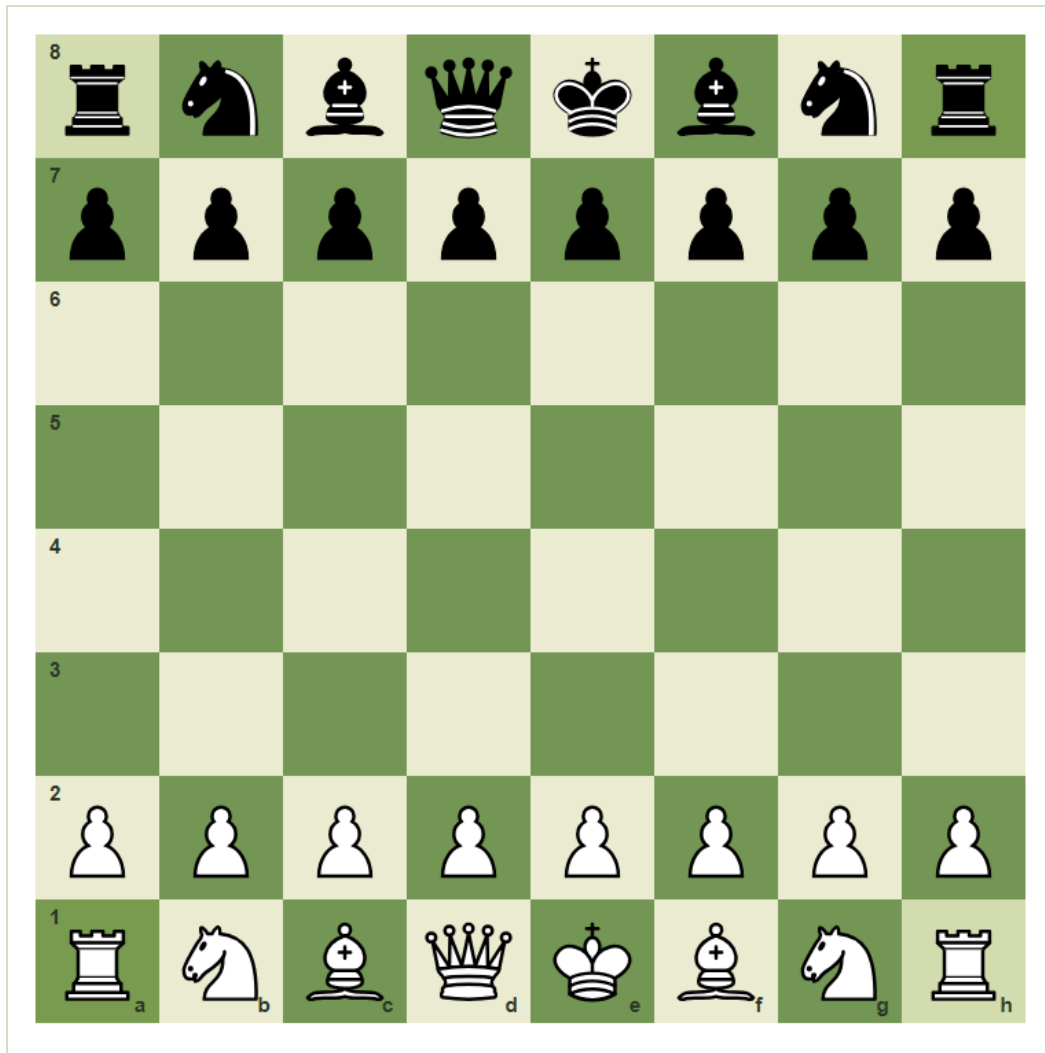
- Name all six chess pieces.
- Set up White and Black correctly from the starting position.
- Use the queen-on-own-color rule.
- Remember simple material values without pricing the king.
- Identify and move White's e-pawn from the starting position.

The Two Armies

Chess begins with two equal armies. White starts on the 1st and 2nd ranks. Black starts on the 8th and 7th ranks.

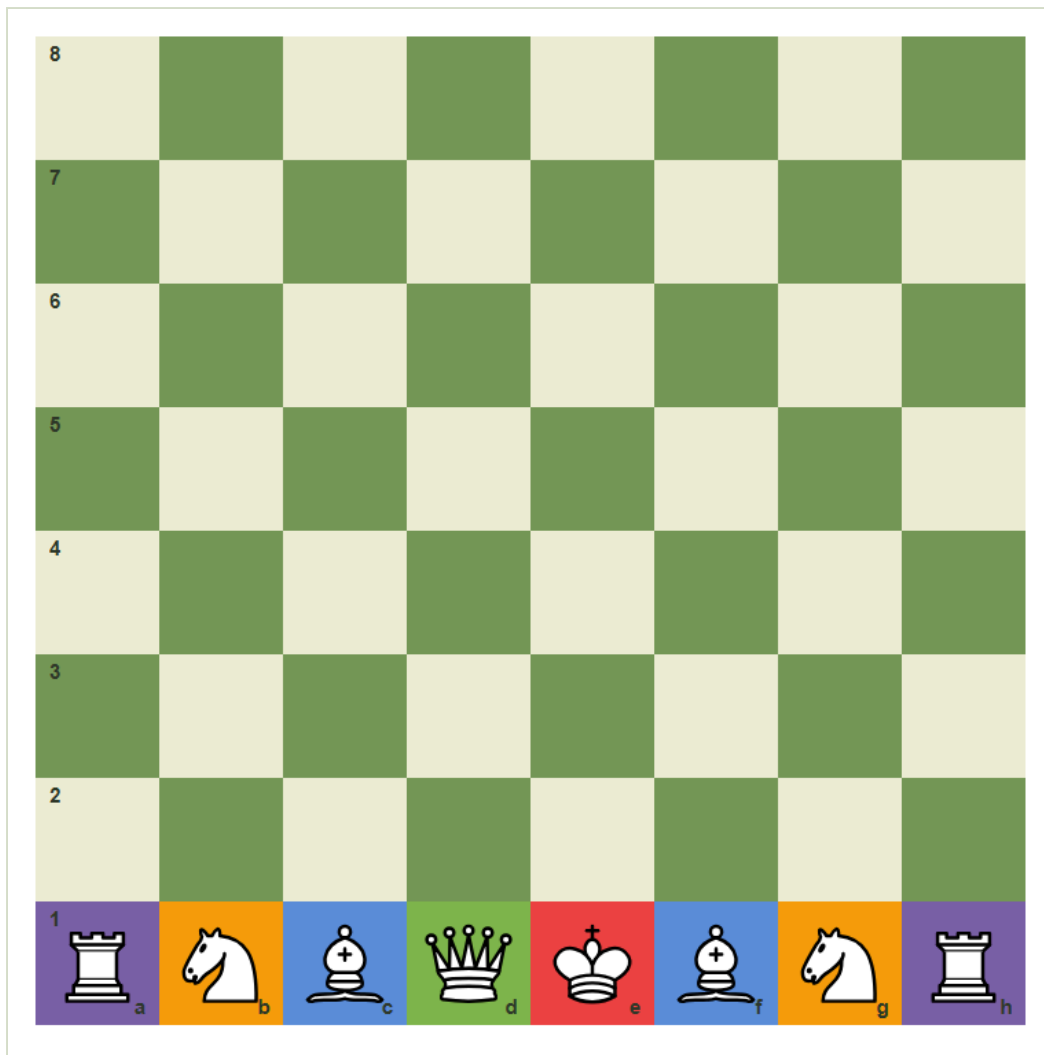
Each side has one king, one queen, two rooks, two bishops, two knights, and eight pawns.

The starting position



This is the complete starting position: White pieces on ranks 1 and 2, Black pieces on ranks 8 and 7.

White's back rank



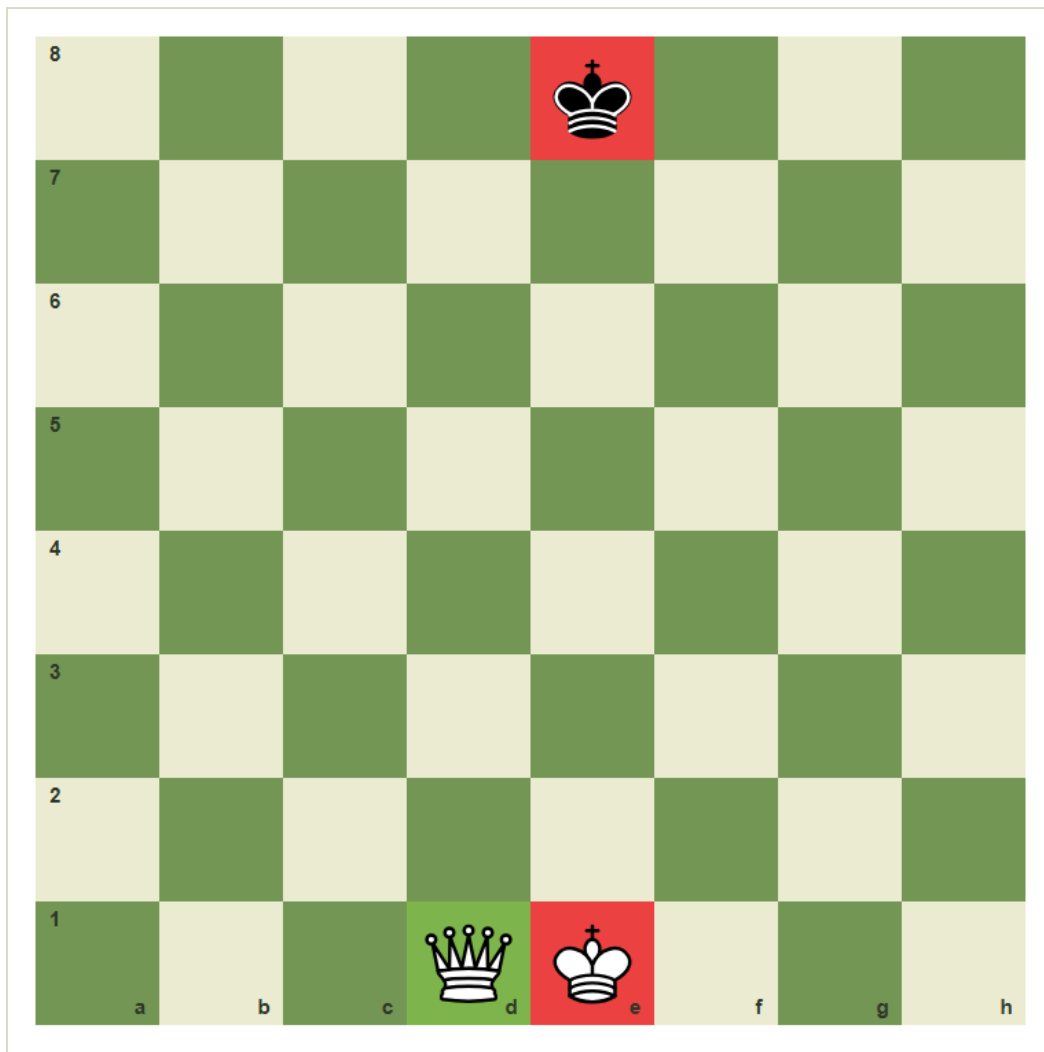
From a1 to h1: rook, knight, bishop, queen, king, bishop, knight, rook.

Piece Names And Simple Values

The king is the most important piece because losing the king means losing the game. Do not give the king a point value.

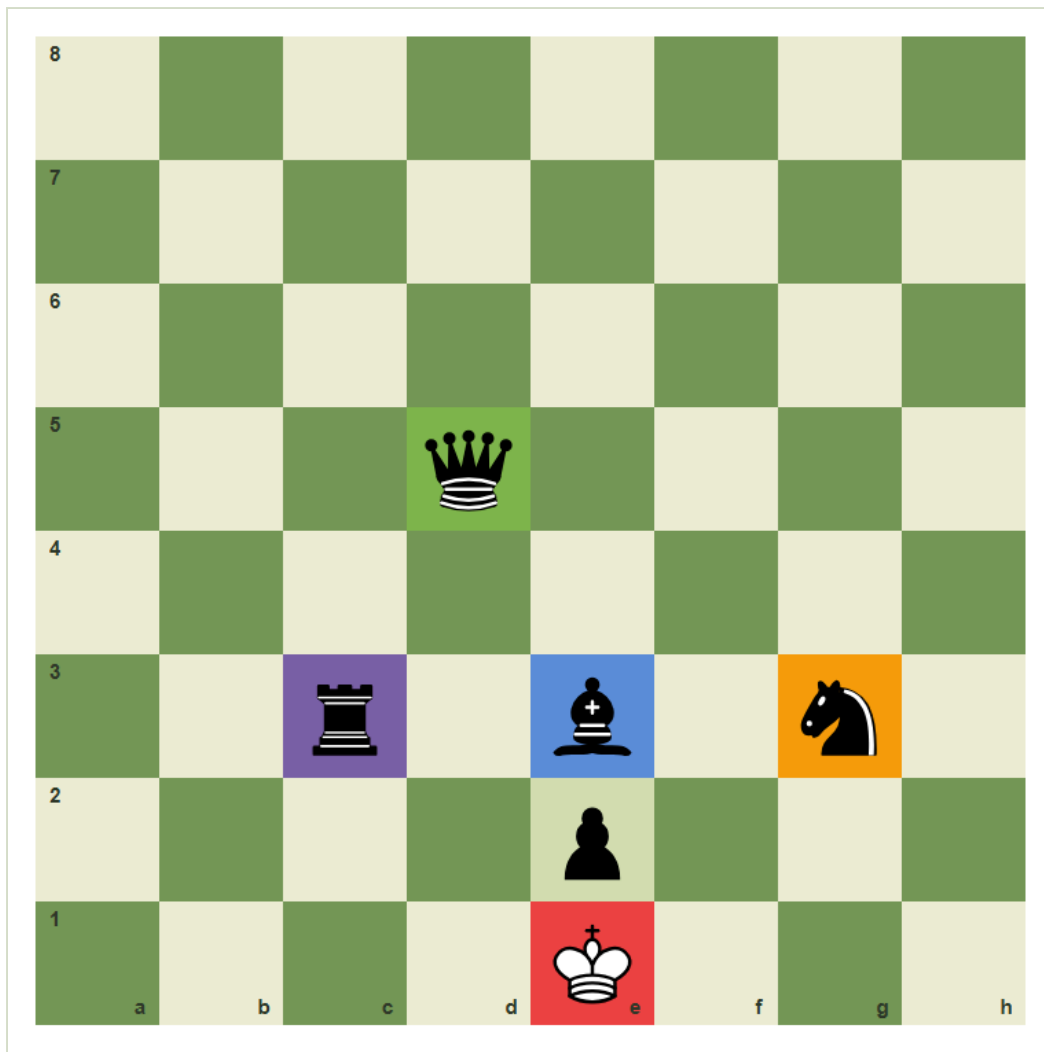
For simple counting, use this first material scale: queen 9, rook 5, bishop 3, knight 3, pawn 1. These numbers are not the whole story, but they help you notice when a trade is obviously good or bad.

The royal pieces



The kings are on e1 and e8 in a normal setup. White's queen begins on d1.

A first material scale



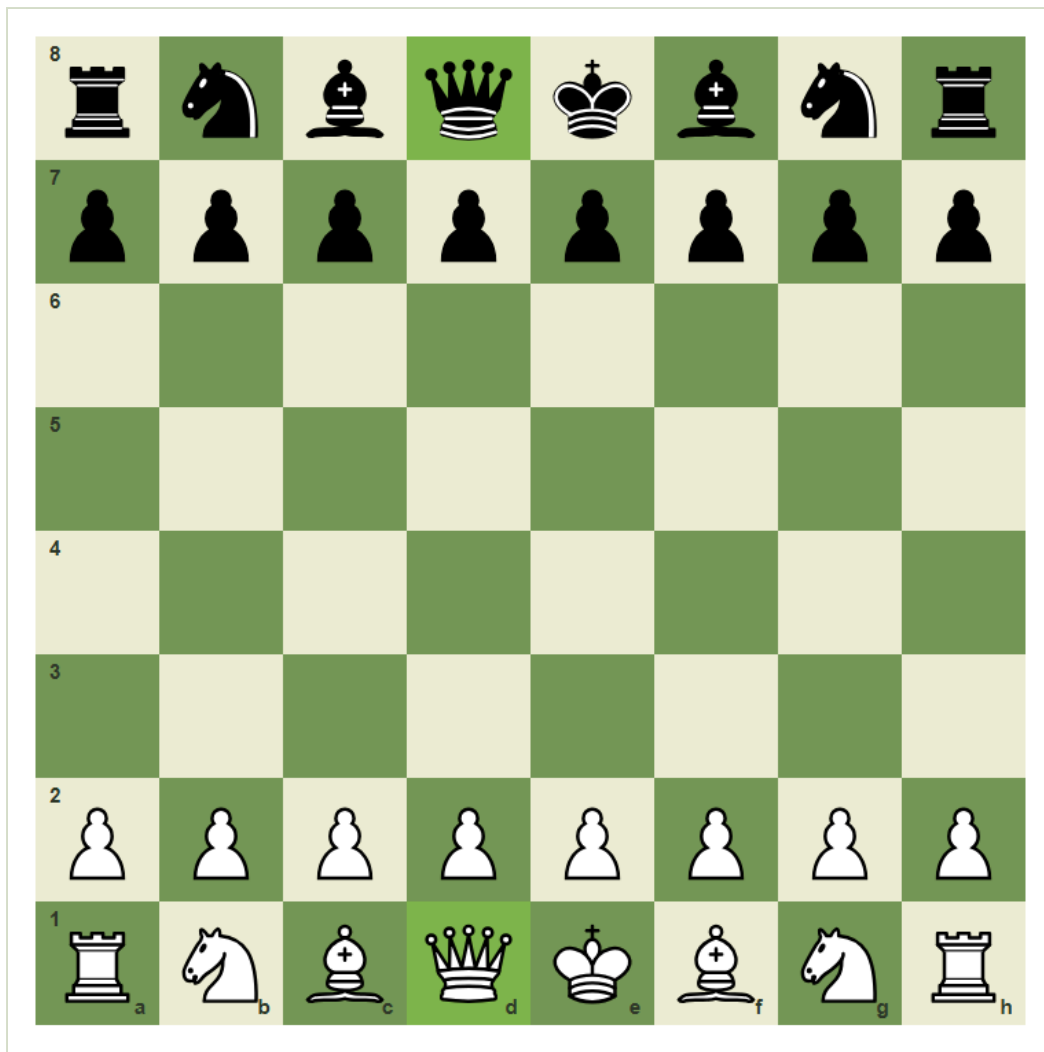
Queen on d5 is 9, rook on c3 is 5, bishop on e3 is 3, knight on g3 is 3, pawn on e2 is 1, and king on e1 is priceless.

The Setup Rules That Prevent Mistakes

The fastest setup check is the queen rule: queen on her own color. The White queen starts on the light square d1. The Black queen starts on the dark square d8.

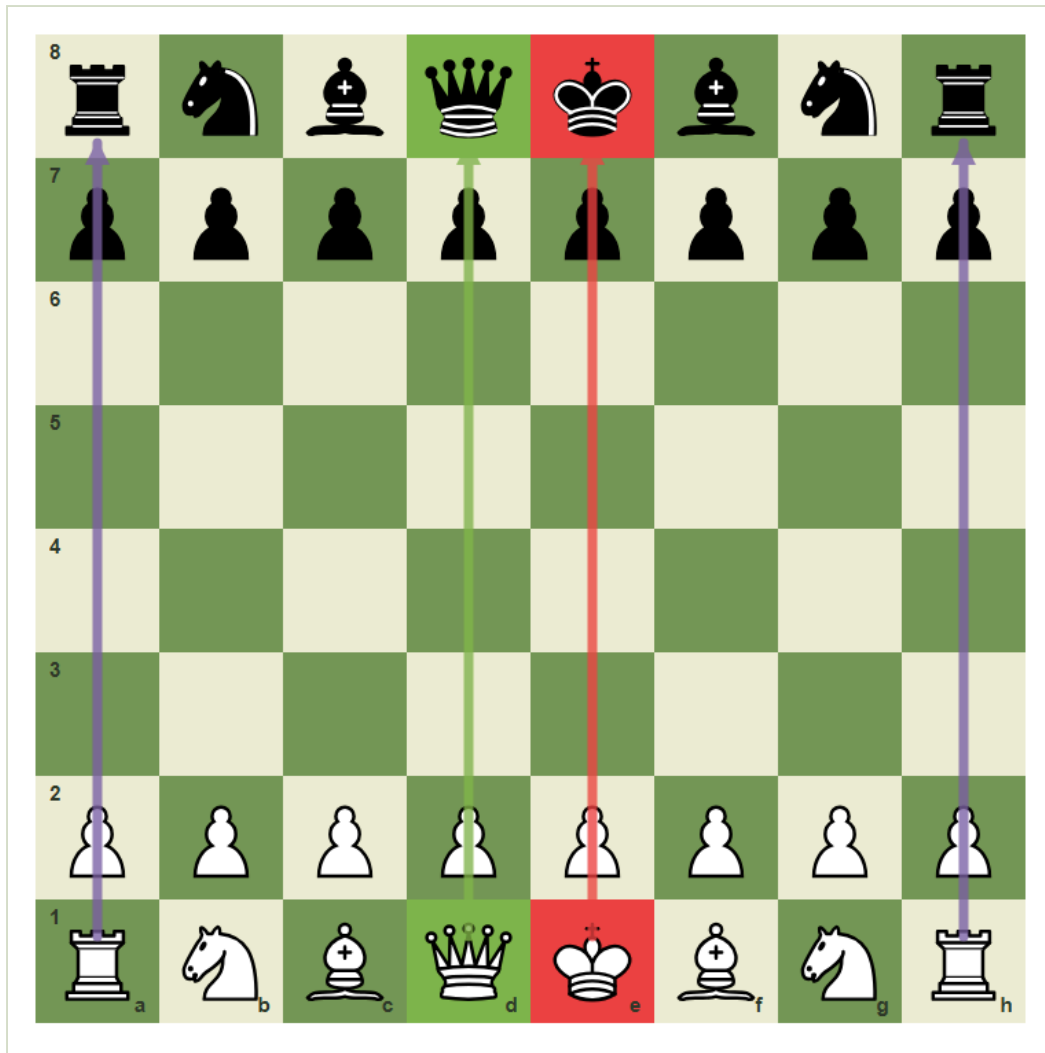
After the queen and king are correct, the bishops stand beside them, the knights stand beside the bishops, and the rooks go in the corners.

Queen on her own color



White queen on d1, Black queen on d8. Queen on her own color fixes the center of the back rank.

The armies mirror each other

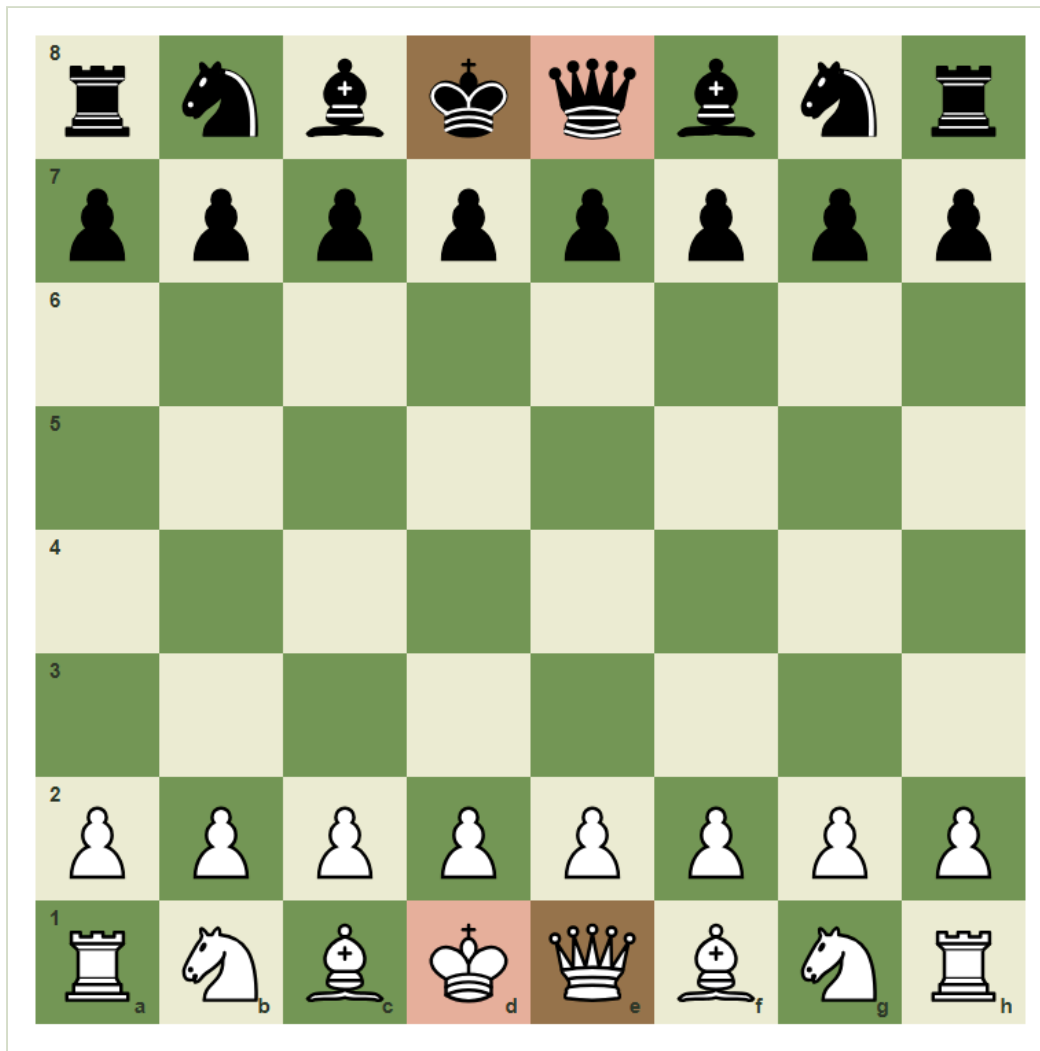


White and Black mirror each other: queens face queens on the d-file, kings face kings on the e-file, and rooks sit in the corners.

Common mistake: swapping king and queen

This setup looks close, but both queens and kings are swapped. White's queen has been put on e1 instead of d1. Black's queen has been put on e8 instead of d8.

Fix it by returning each queen to her own color.



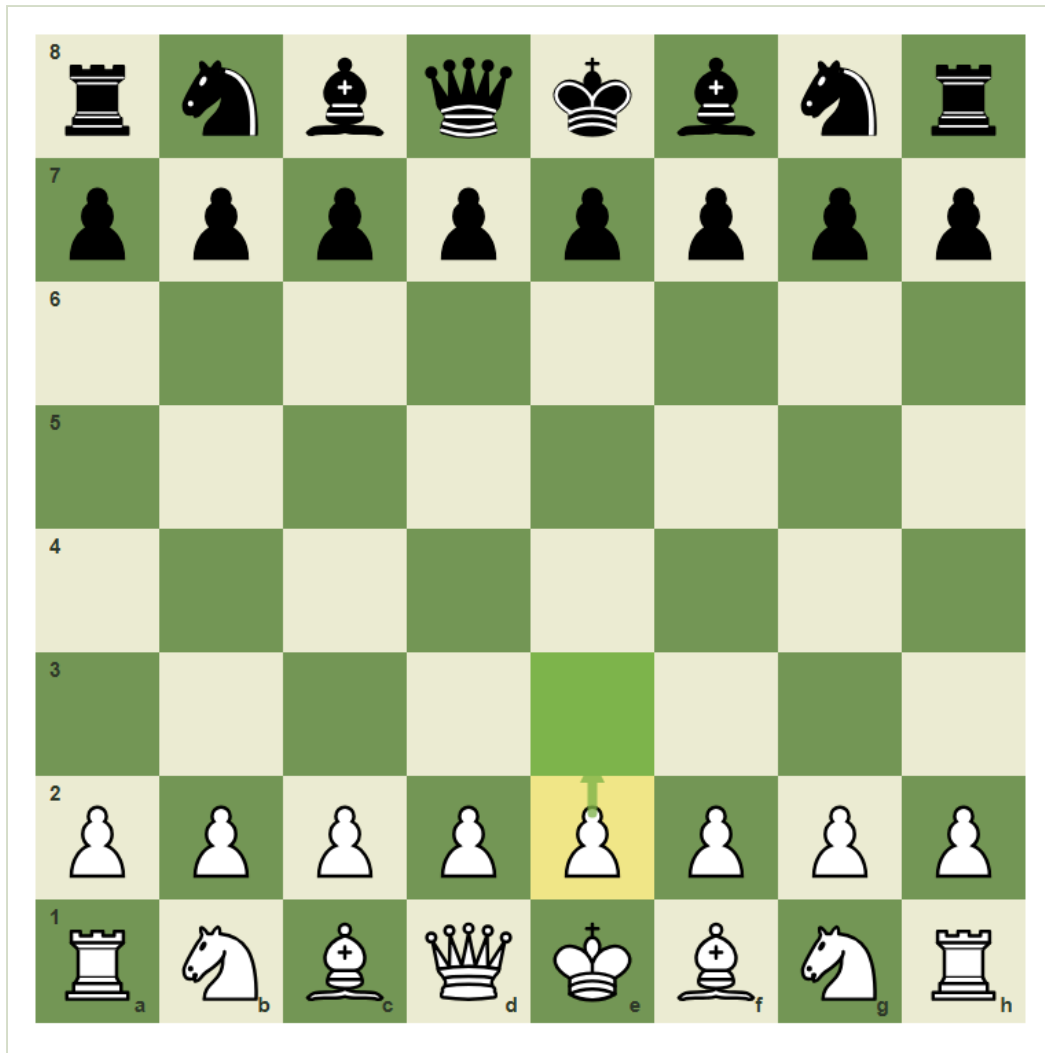
The wrong setup places White queen on e1 and Black queen on e8. Both queens should be on the d-file.

Identify A Piece, Then Move It

When you know the setup, you can name a piece by its square. The piece on e2 at the start is White's e-pawn.

In the next board, move only that pawn one square forward to e3. The goal is not speed; the goal is matching the piece name, square name, and move.

Find White's e-pawn

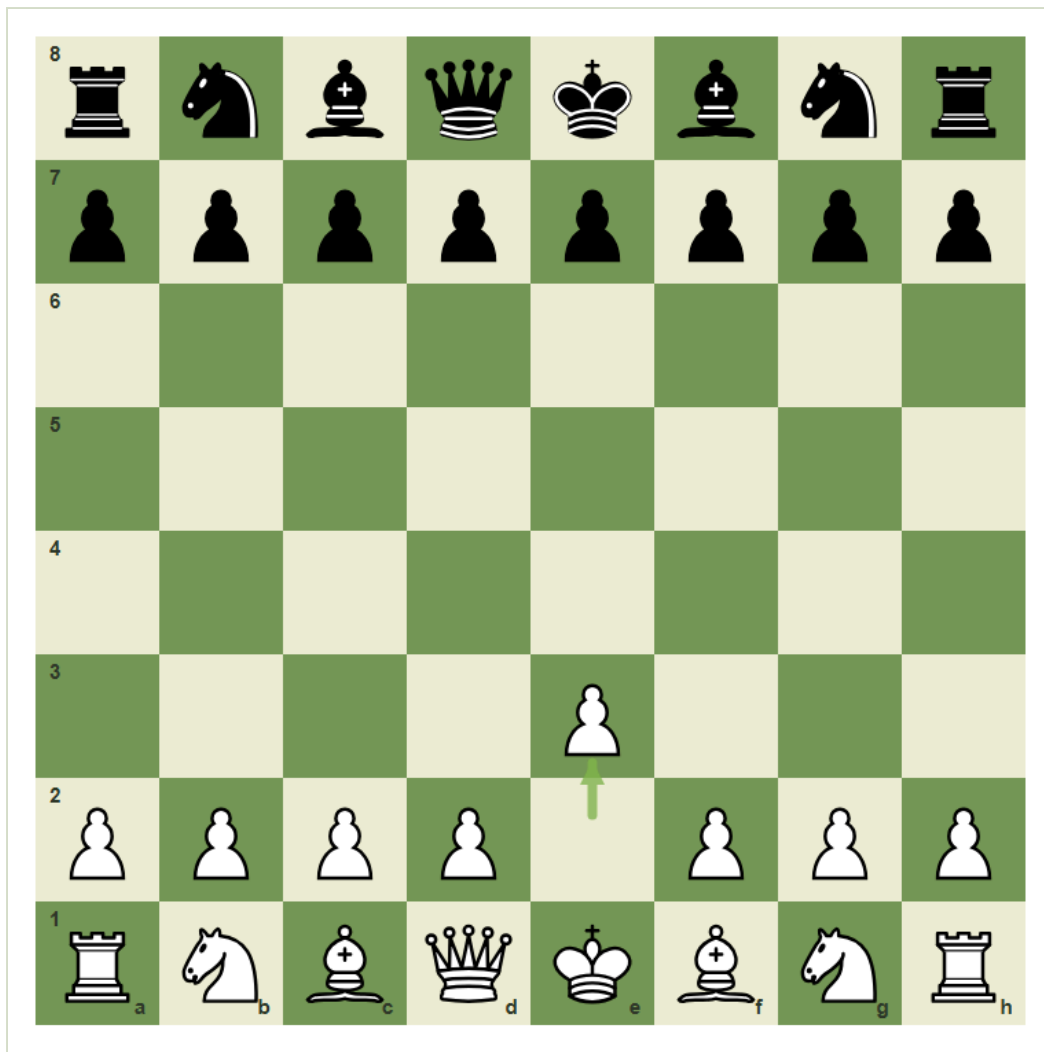


The e-pawn starts on e2. The arrow shows e2 to e3.

Move the e-pawn to e3

Move White's e-pawn from e2 to e3.

After e2 to e3



After e2e3, the pawn leaves e2 and stands on e3.

Quick check: what moved?

In the move e2e3, which piece moved?

- a. White's e-pawn
- b. White's queen
- c. Black's e-pawn

Chapter Checkpoint

Where does White's queen start?

In the correct starting setup, White's queen begins on:

- a. d1
- b. e1
- c. d8

Which piece is priceless?

Which piece should not be assigned a normal material point value?

- a. King
- b. Queen
- c. Rook

What are the corner pieces?

At the start of the game, the pieces in the four corners are:

- a. Rooks
- b. Knights
- c. Bishops

The King And The Goal

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The king moves slowly, but the whole game turns around him.

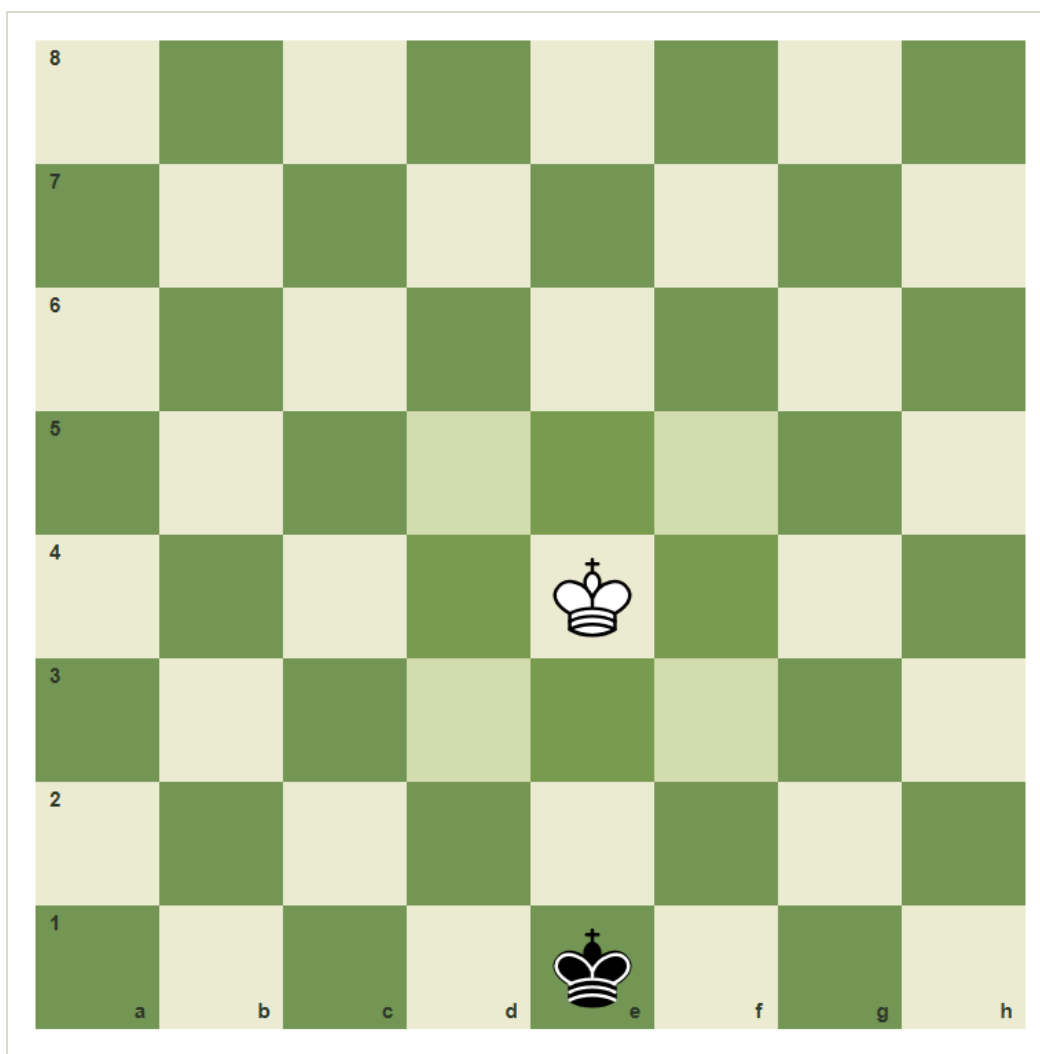
Learning objectives

- Move the king one square in any direction.
- Know that kings may never stand next to each other.
- Understand that the king may not move into danger.
- Explain why the king is never traded or captured.

The King Is The Game

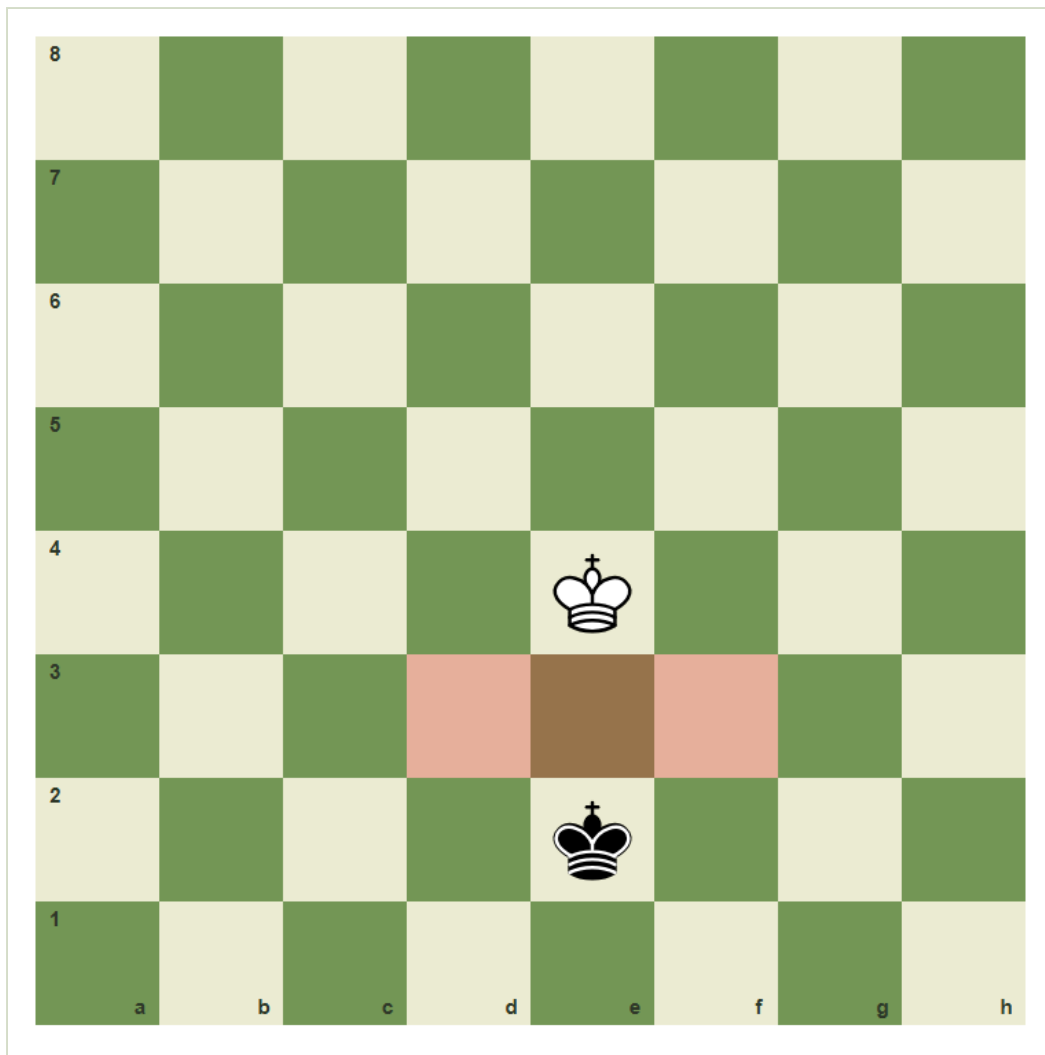
Every piece can be traded except the king. You do not win by taking the king off the board. You win by attacking the king so strongly that there is no legal escape. That final position is checkmate.

The king moves one square



From e4, the king can step to any adjacent highlighted square if that square is safe.

Kings cannot touch

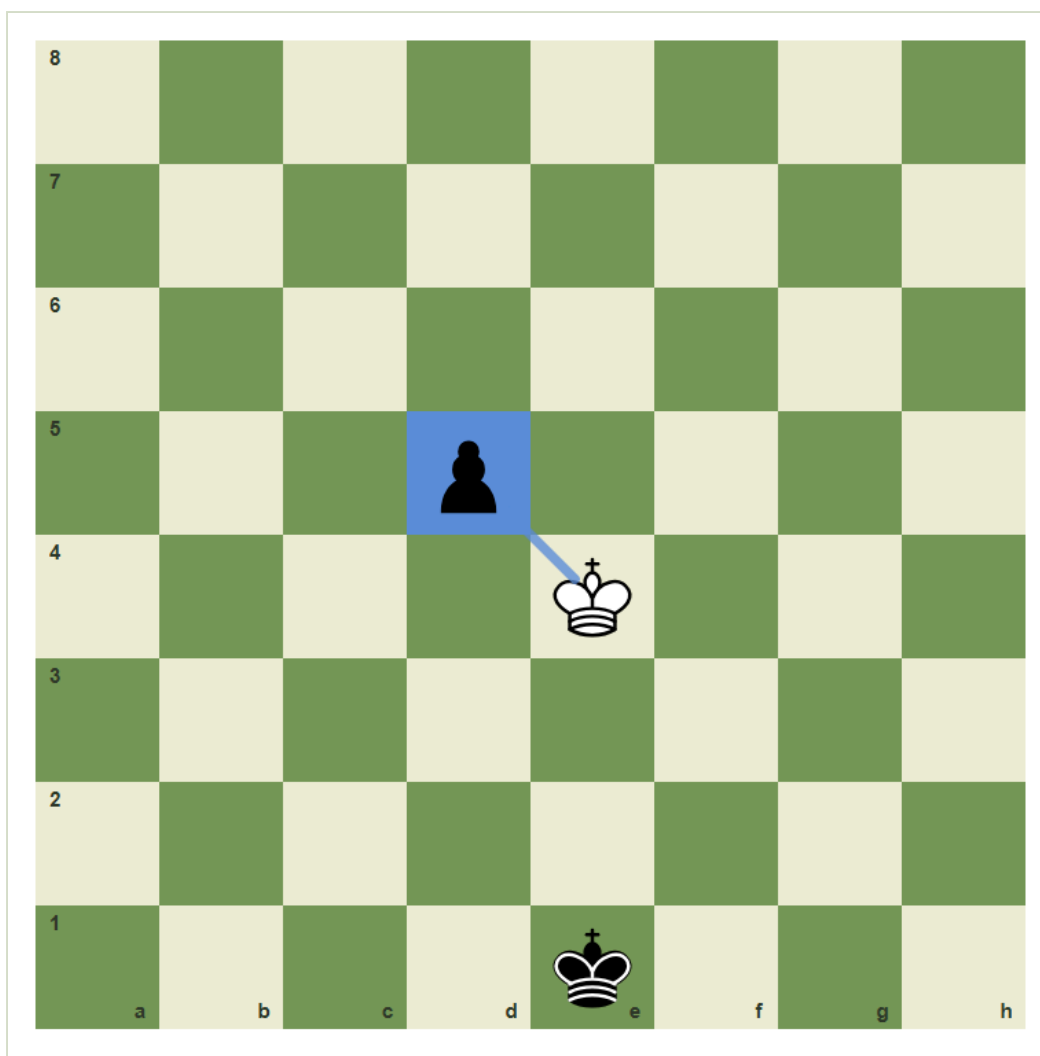


The kings control the squares beside them. White may not move next to the black king.

Safe Squares Matter

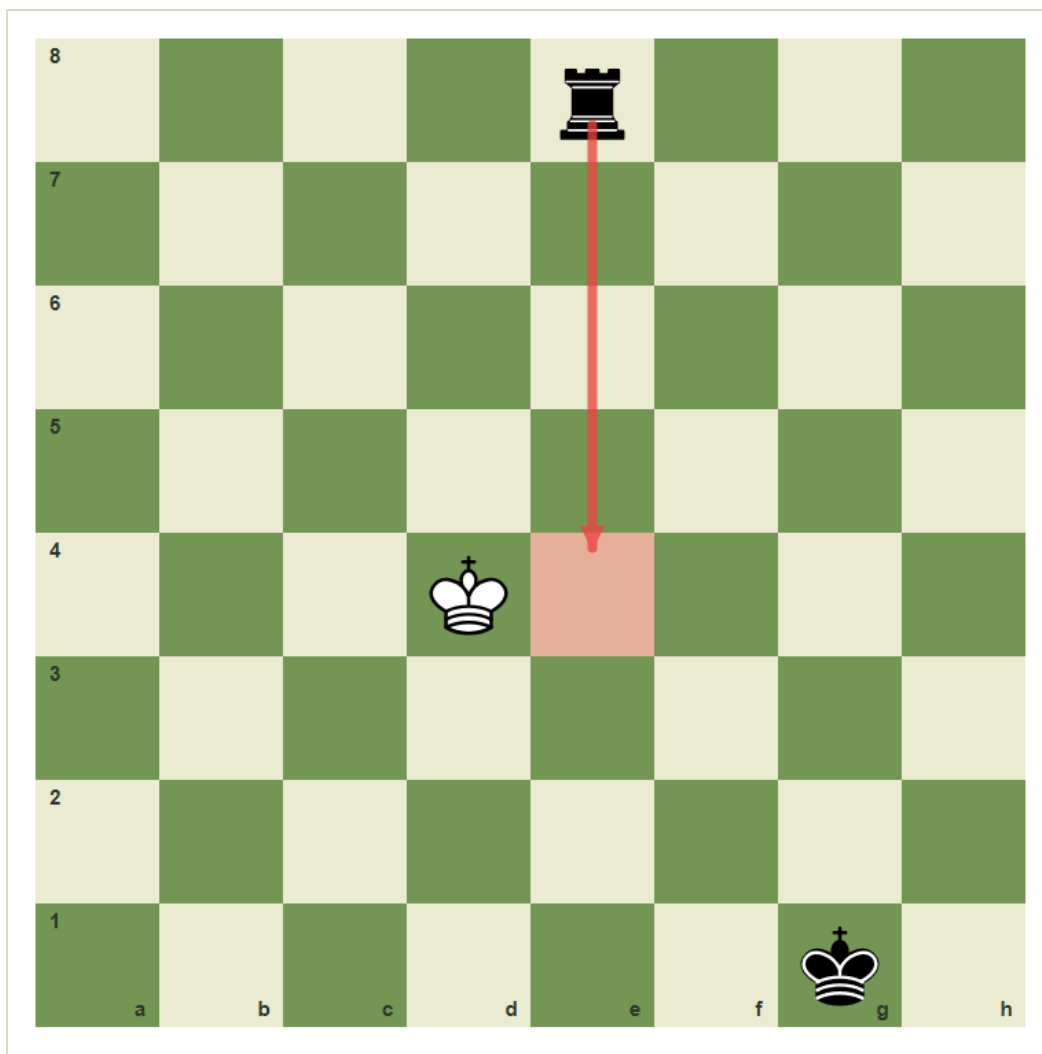
A king move has two questions. First, does the king move one square? Second, is the landing square safe? A one-square move is still illegal if the king walks into an attack.

The king can capture a loose piece



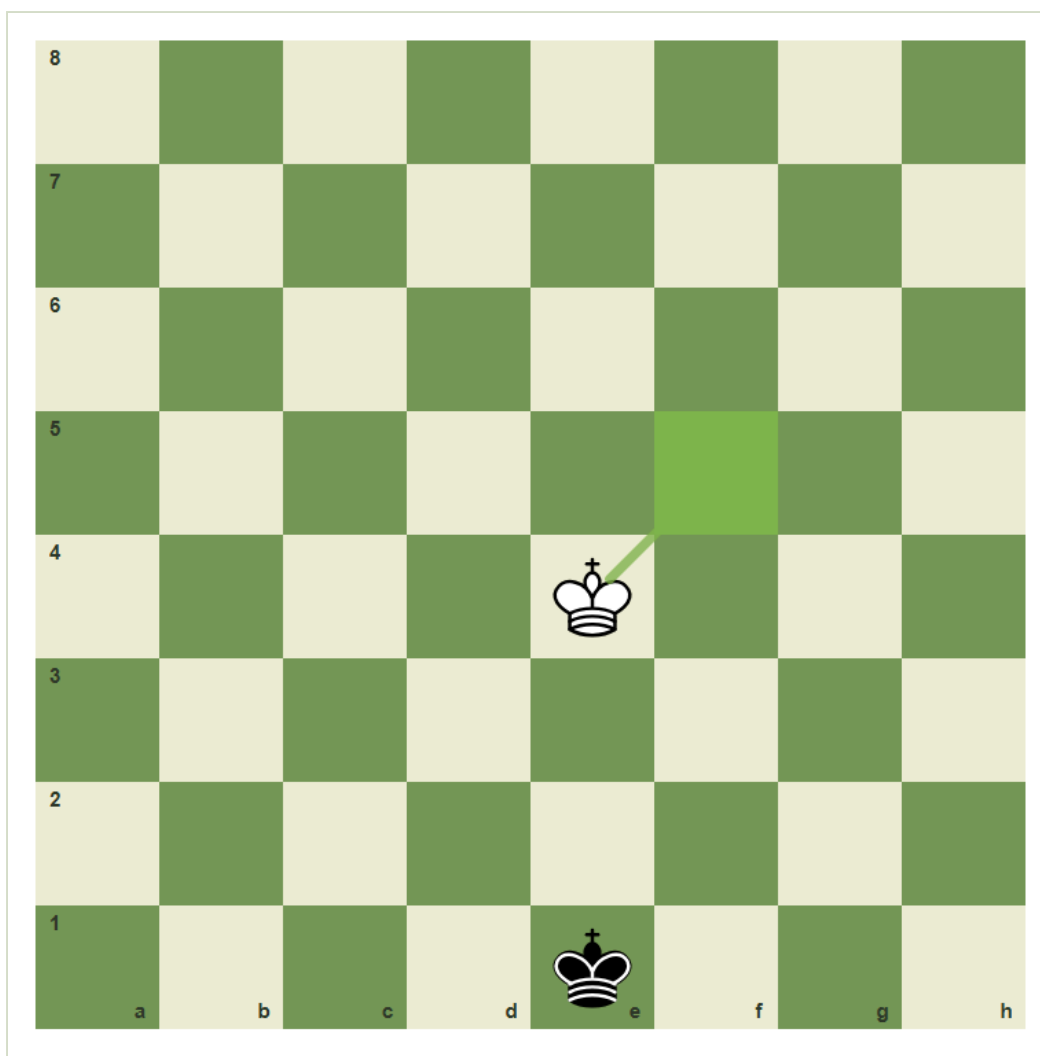
If the pawn on d5 is not protected, the king may capture it by moving one square diagonally.

A rook controls the e-file



The black rook controls e4, so the white king on d4 may not step onto e4.

A safe king step



e4 to f5 is a normal one-square king move in this position.

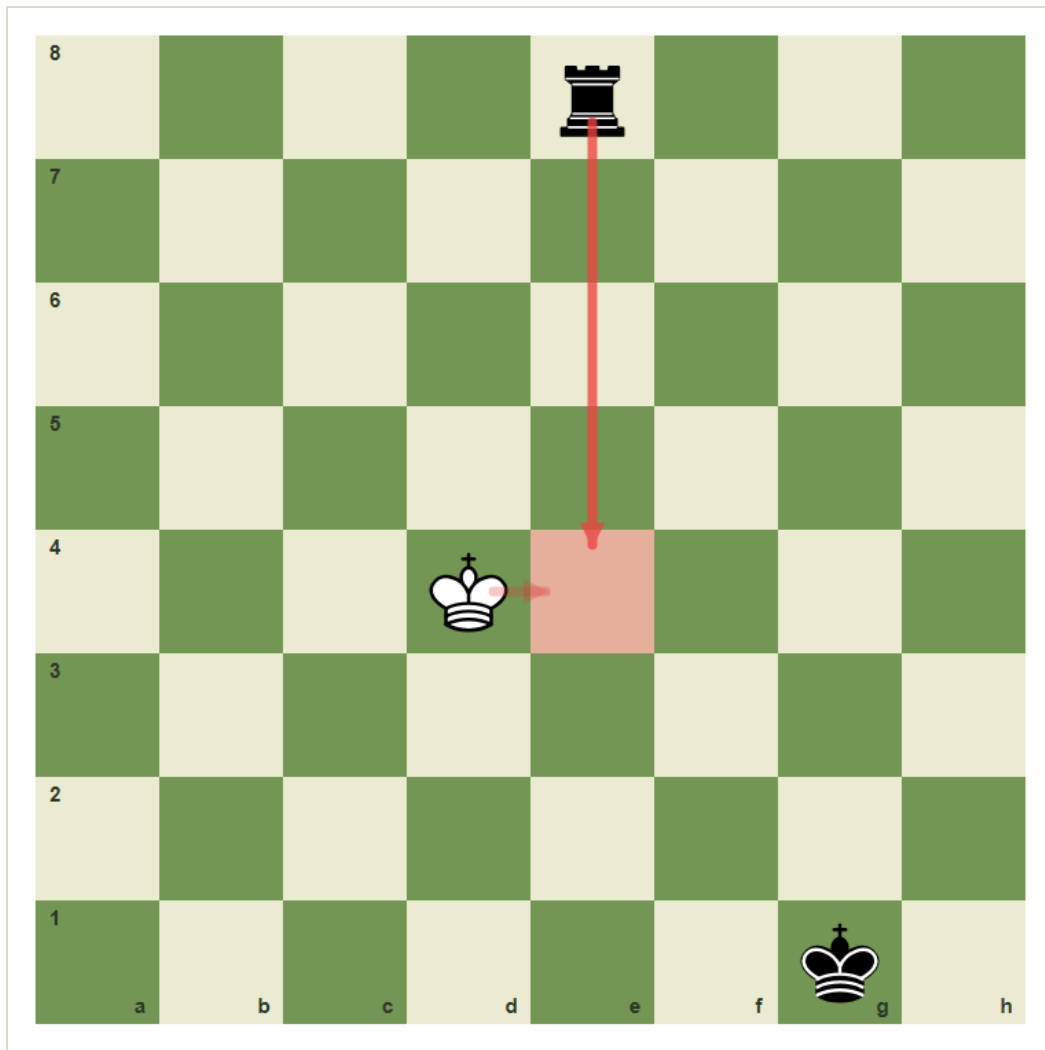
Move the king to f5

Move the white king from e4 to f5.

Common Mistake

Common mistake: walking into attack

The move from d4 to e4 looks like a legal one-square move, but e4 is controlled by the rook on e8. A king move must satisfy both rules: one square and safe.



The red square is not safe. The rook already controls it.

Chapter Checkpoint

How far does a king move?

A king normally moves:

- a. One square in any direction
- b. Any number of squares in a straight line
- c. Only forward

Can kings stand next to each other?

Two kings may stand on adjacent squares:

- a. No
- b. Yes, if no other pieces are nearby
- c. Only in the endgame

What makes a king move illegal?

A one-square king move is illegal when:

- a. The landing square is attacked
- b. The king moves diagonally
- c. The king captures a piece

Rooks And Bishops

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Straight lines and diagonals are the first long-range patterns.

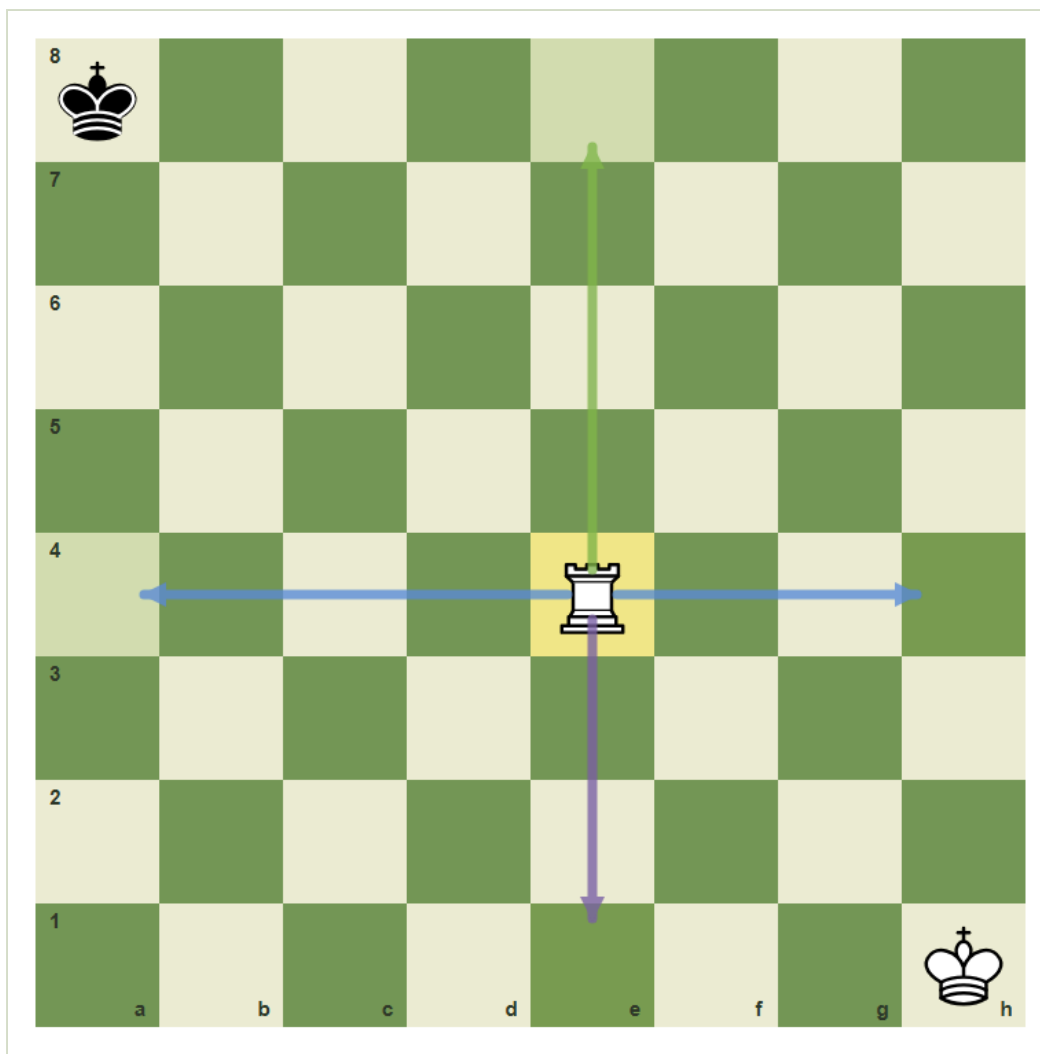
Learning objectives

- Move a rook along ranks and files.
- Move a bishop along diagonals.
- Notice when friendly pieces block long-range pieces.
- Explain why bishops stay on one color complex.

Rooks Use Files And Ranks

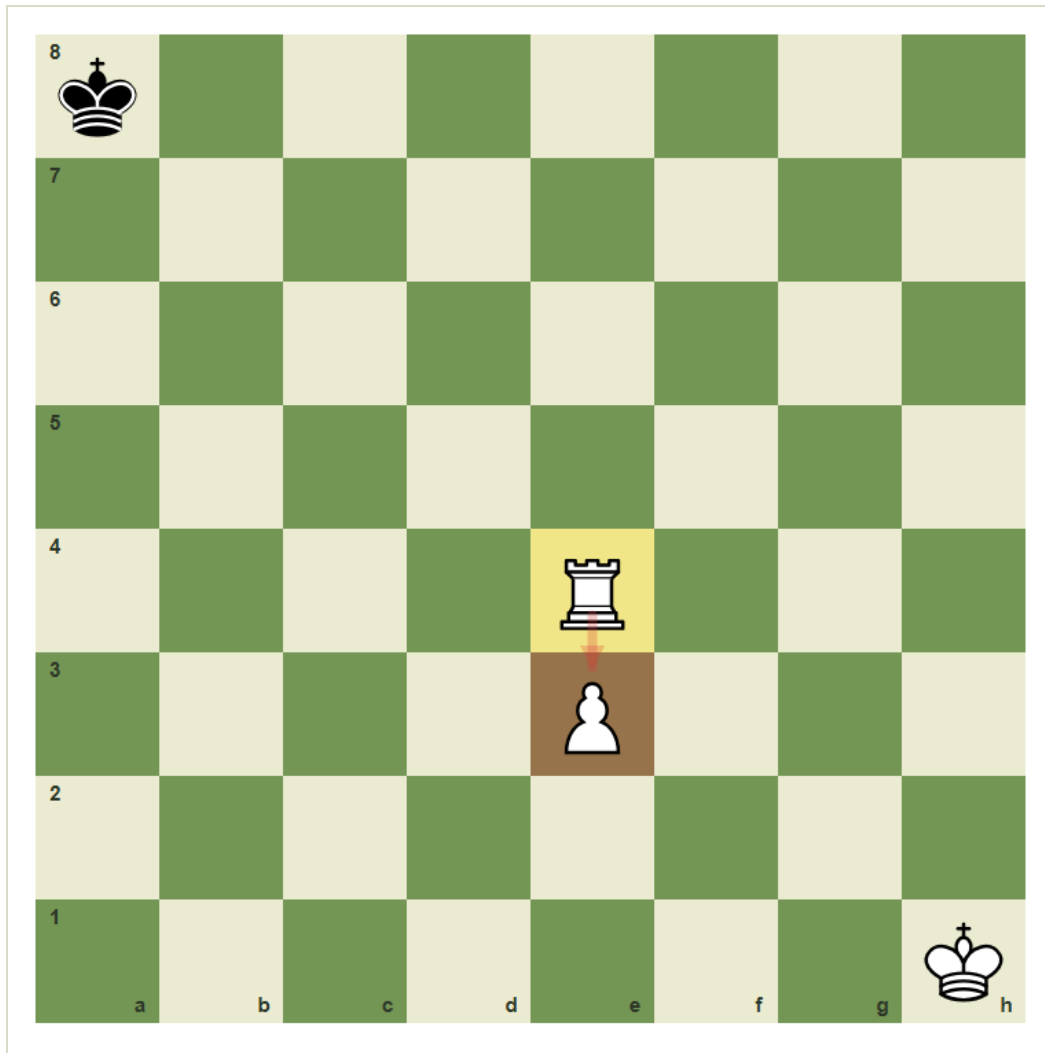
The rook is the straight-line piece. It moves up, down, left, or right as far as the path is clear. It cannot jump over pieces.

Rook lines from e4



From e4, a rook moves along the e-file or across the 4th rank.

Own pieces block rooks

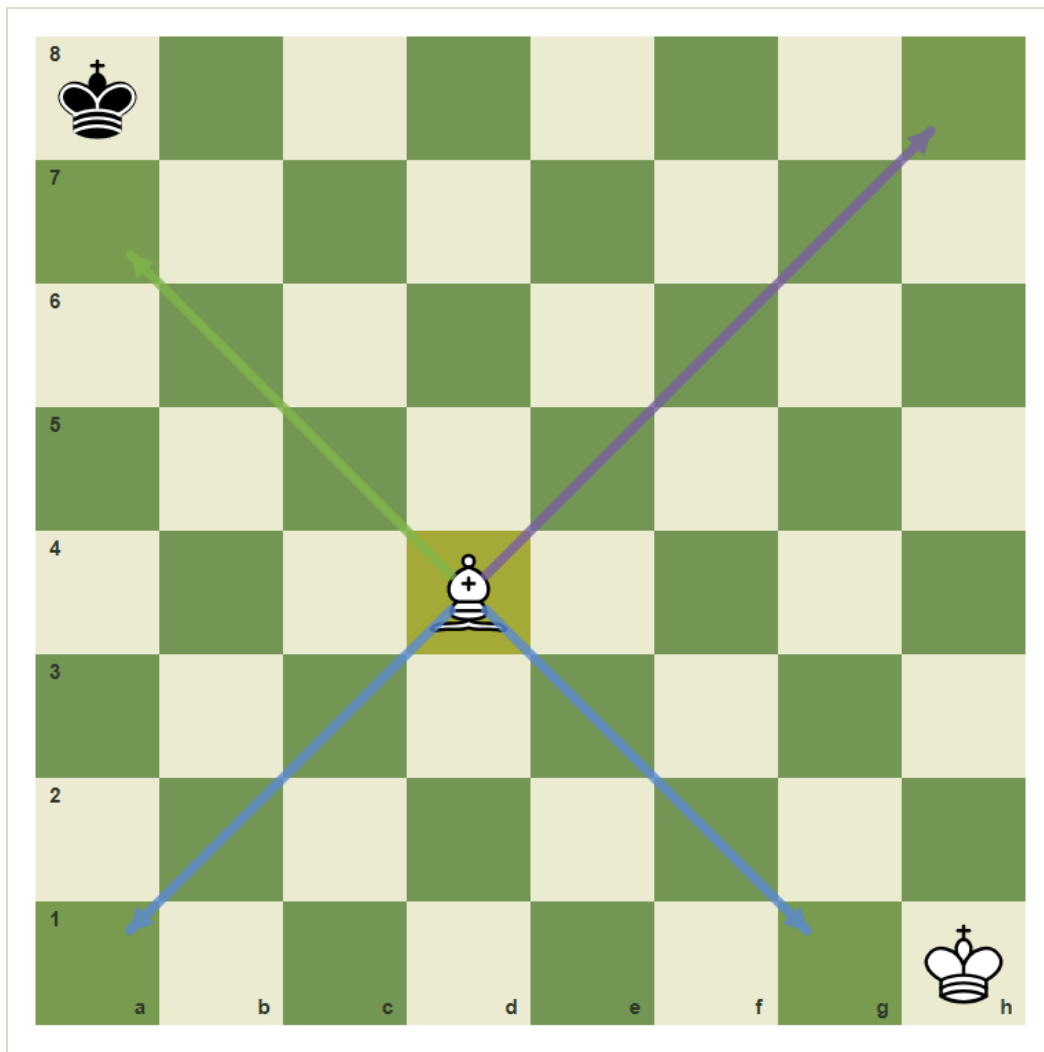


The white pawn on e3 blocks the rook. The rook cannot move through its own pawn.

Bishops Use Diagonals

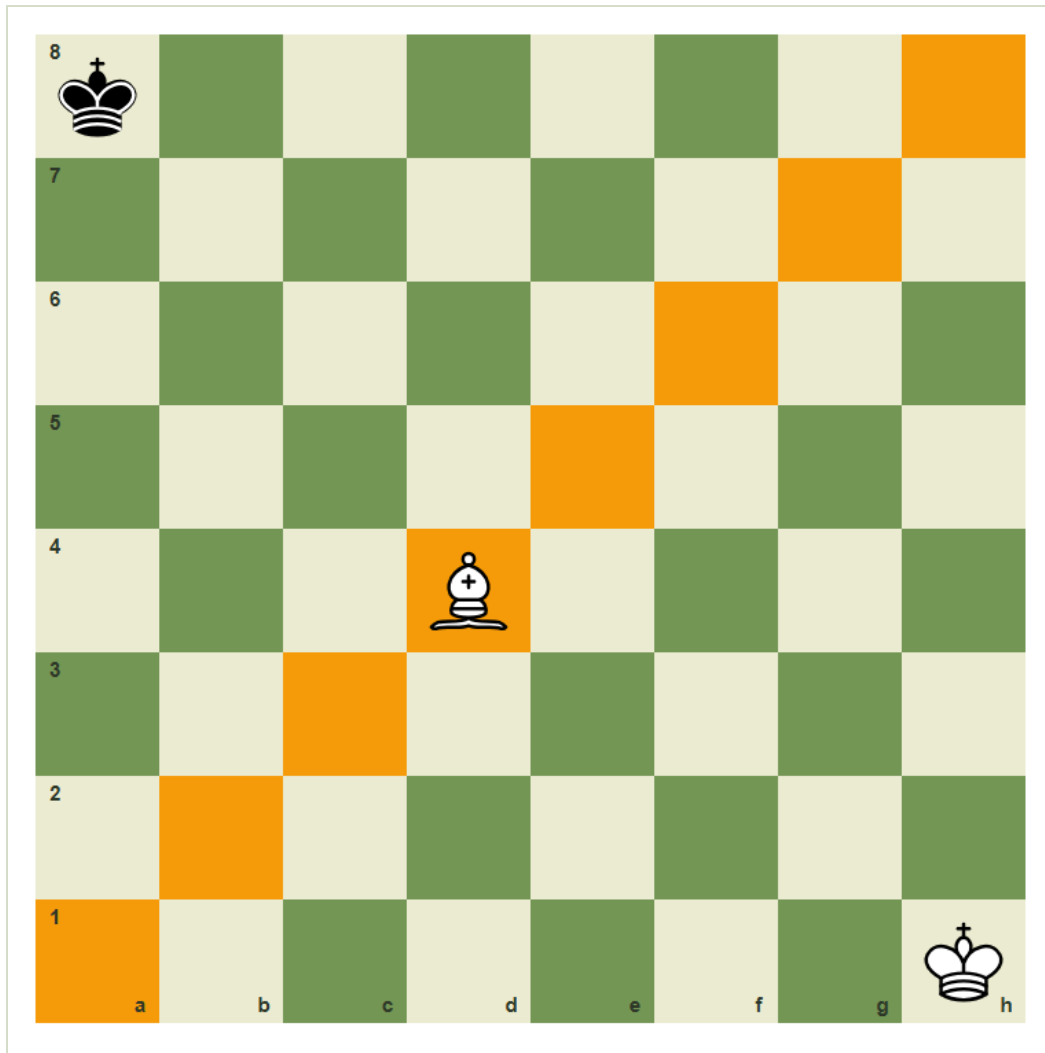
The bishop is the diagonal long-range piece. Because every diagonal keeps the same square color, a bishop that starts on a light square always stays on light squares.

Bishop diagonals from d4



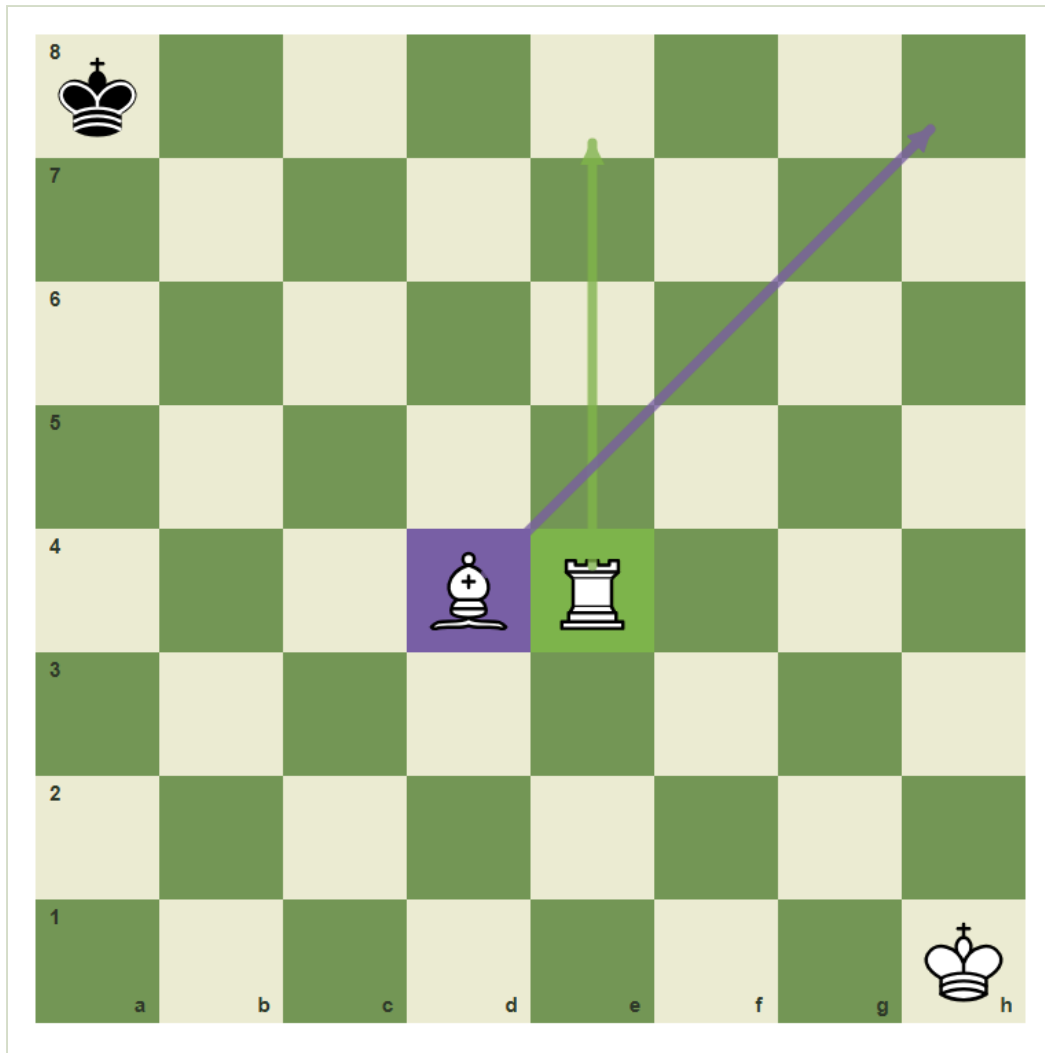
A bishop on d4 moves only on diagonals.

The bishop stays on one color



This bishop is on a dark-square diagonal. It will never land on a light square.

Rook and bishop side by side



The rook on e4 uses straight lines. The bishop on d4 uses diagonals.

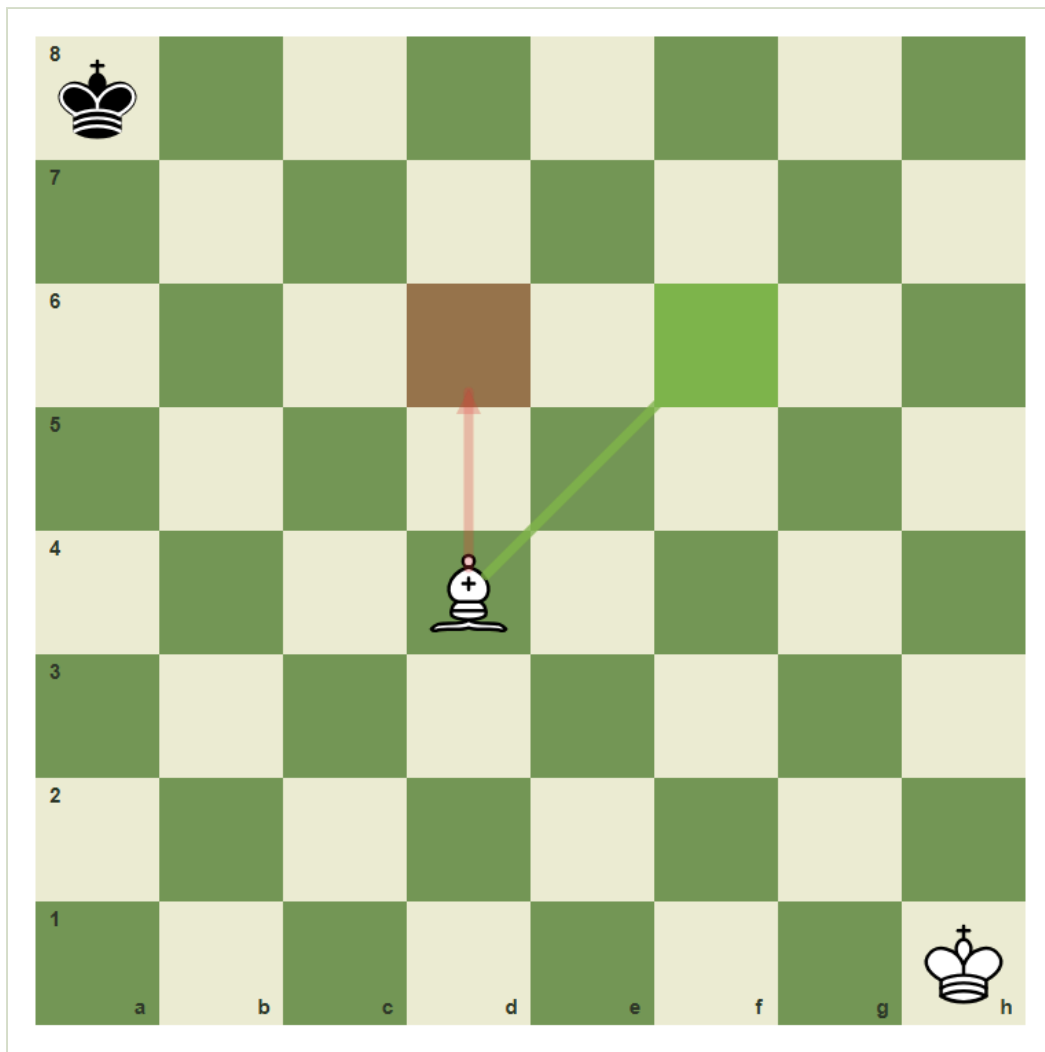
Move the rook to e8

Move the rook from e4 to e8 along the e-file.

Common Mistake

Common mistake: moving a bishop straight

A bishop on d4 cannot move to d6. That is a straight-file move, and bishops only use diagonals.



d4 to d6 is wrong. d4 to f6 is diagonal and legal if the path is clear.

Chapter Checkpoint

Which lines does a rook use?

A rook moves along:

- a. Files and ranks
- b. Only diagonals
- c. Knight jumps

Can a bishop change color?

A bishop that starts on a dark square can later land on a light square:

- a. No
- b. Yes, after a capture
- c. Only near the edge

What blocks a rook?

A rook is blocked by:

- a. Any piece on its path
- b. Only enemy pieces
- c. Only the king

The Queen And Long-Range Power

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The queen combines rook lines and bishop diagonals.

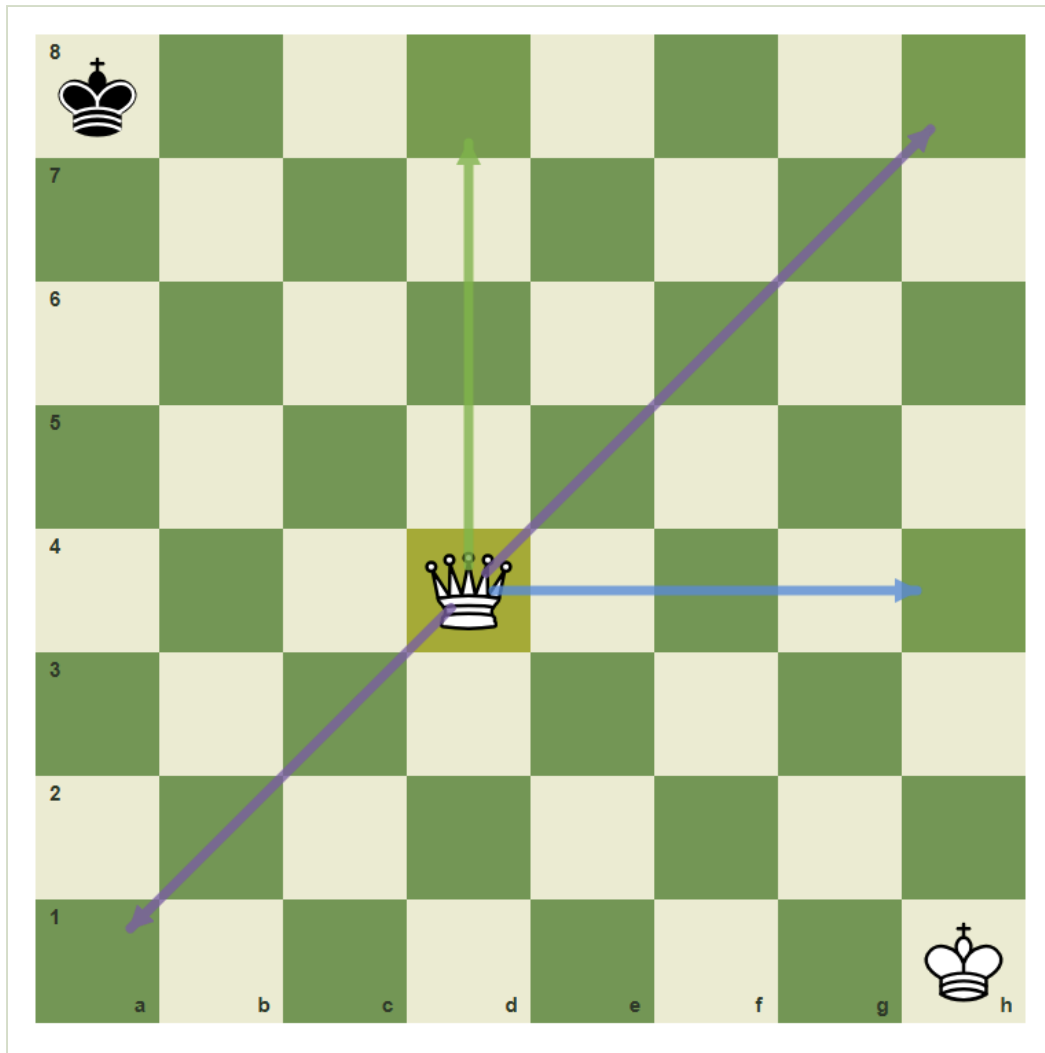
Learning objectives

- Move the queen along ranks, files, and diagonals.
- Recognize that the queen cannot jump.
- Use the queen to target weak squares.
- Avoid bringing the queen into easy attack too early.

The Queen Combines Two Pieces

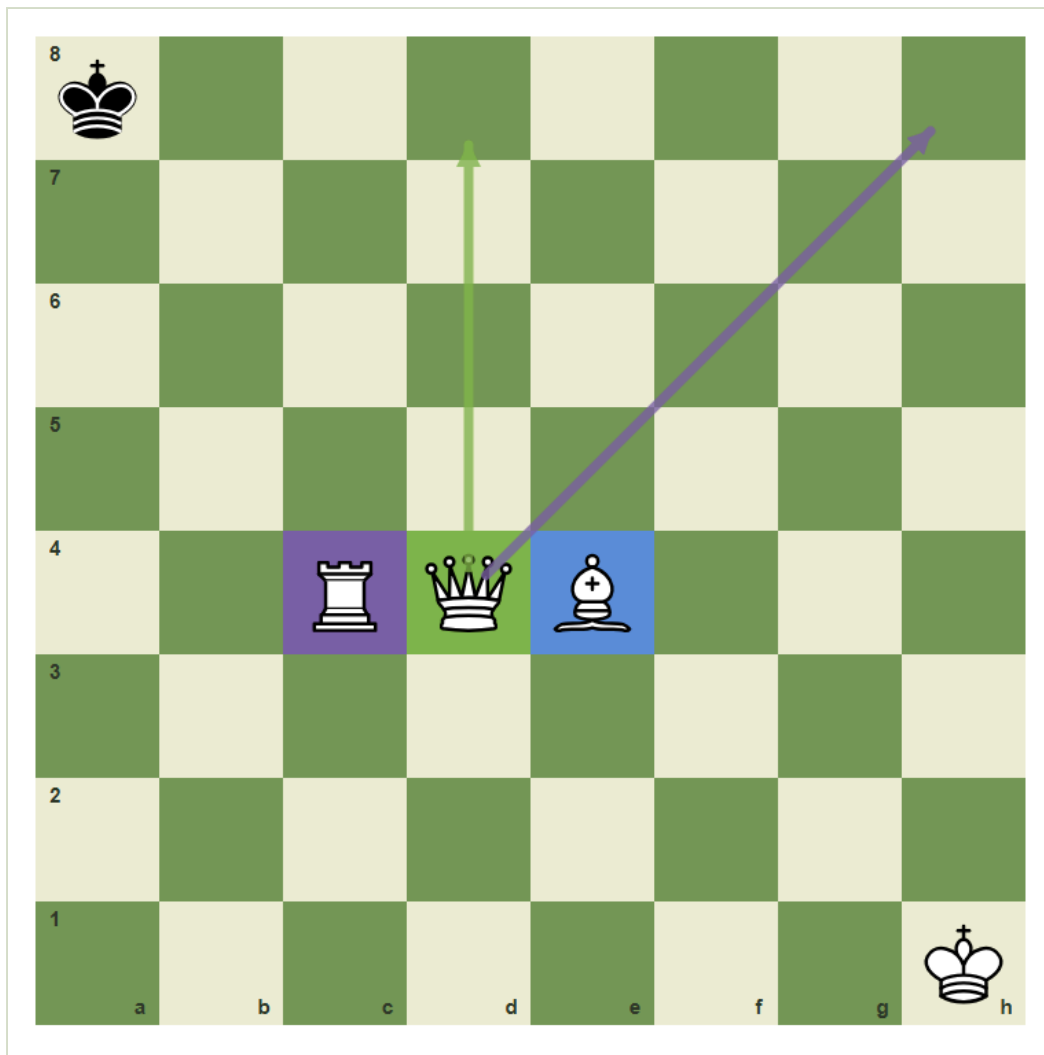
The queen is the strongest attacking piece because she moves like a rook and a bishop together. She can use files, ranks, and diagonals, but she still cannot jump.

Queen lines from d4



The queen can move vertically, horizontally, and diagonally from d4.

Queen as rook plus bishop

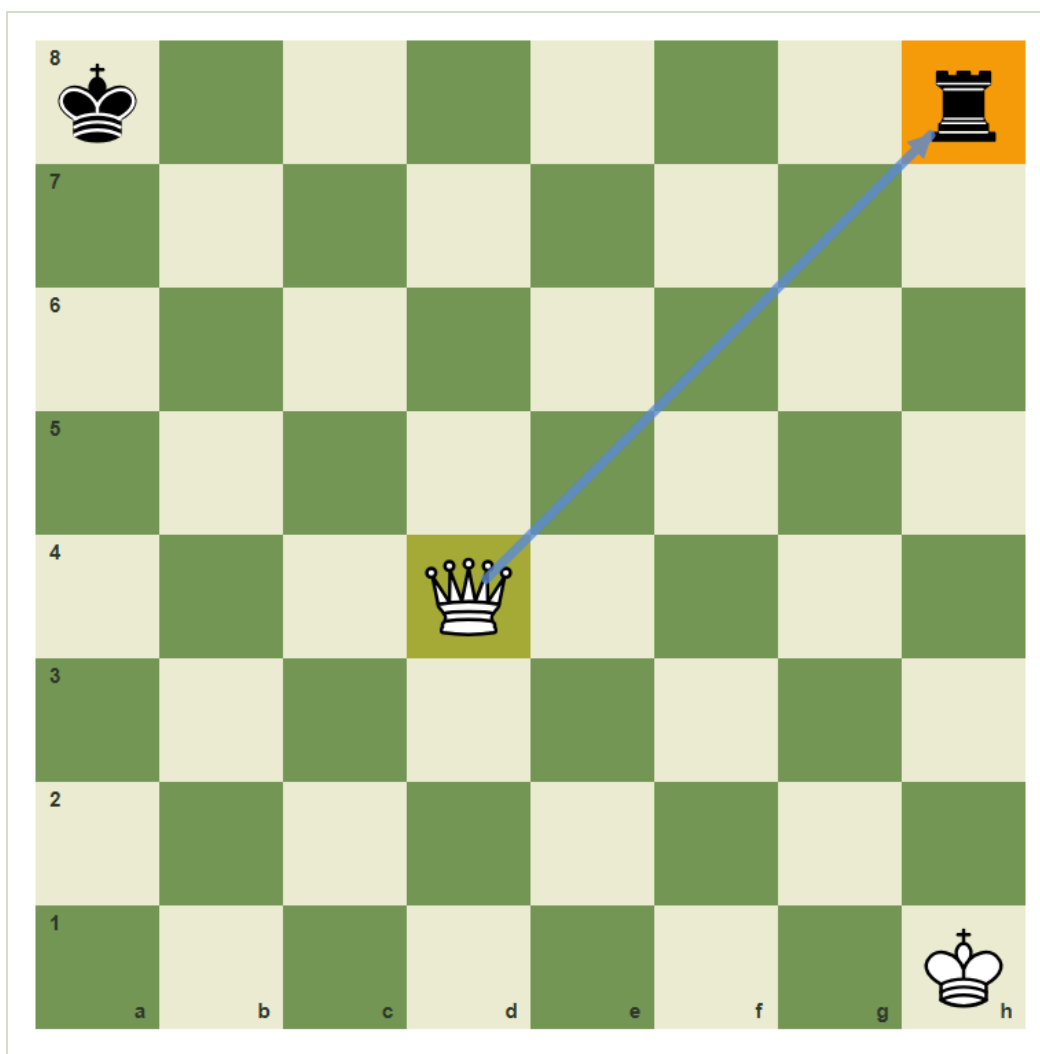


The queen on d4 shares the straight-line idea of the rook and the diagonal idea of the bishop.

Targets And Blocks

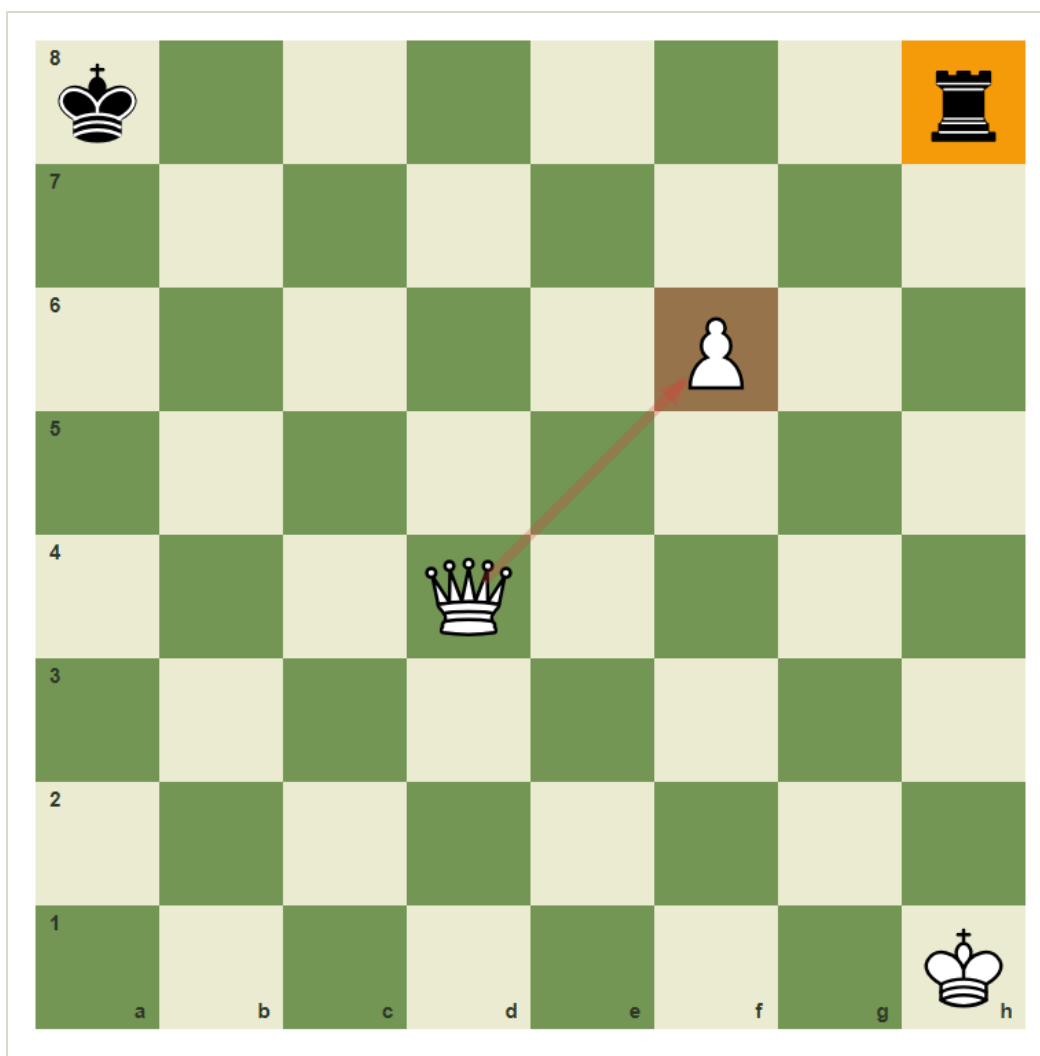
A queen becomes powerful when she attacks a clear target. But if a piece sits on the path, the queen must stop before it or capture it if it is an enemy piece.

The queen targets h8



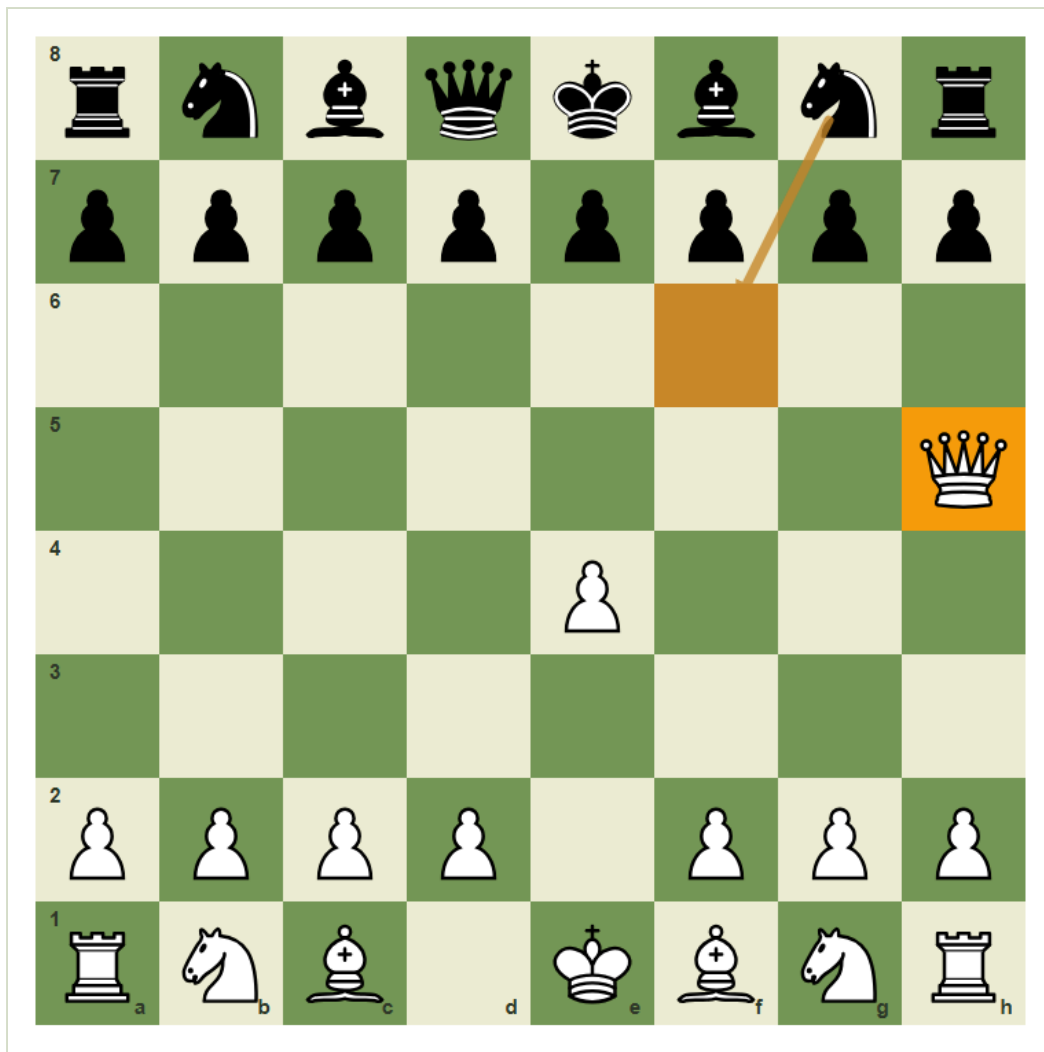
The queen on d4 attacks the rook on h8 along the diagonal.

A blocked queen line



The white pawn on f6 blocks the diagonal, so the queen no longer attacks h8.

Early queen move



A queen on h5 can be useful, but Black can gain time by attacking her with Ng8 to f6.

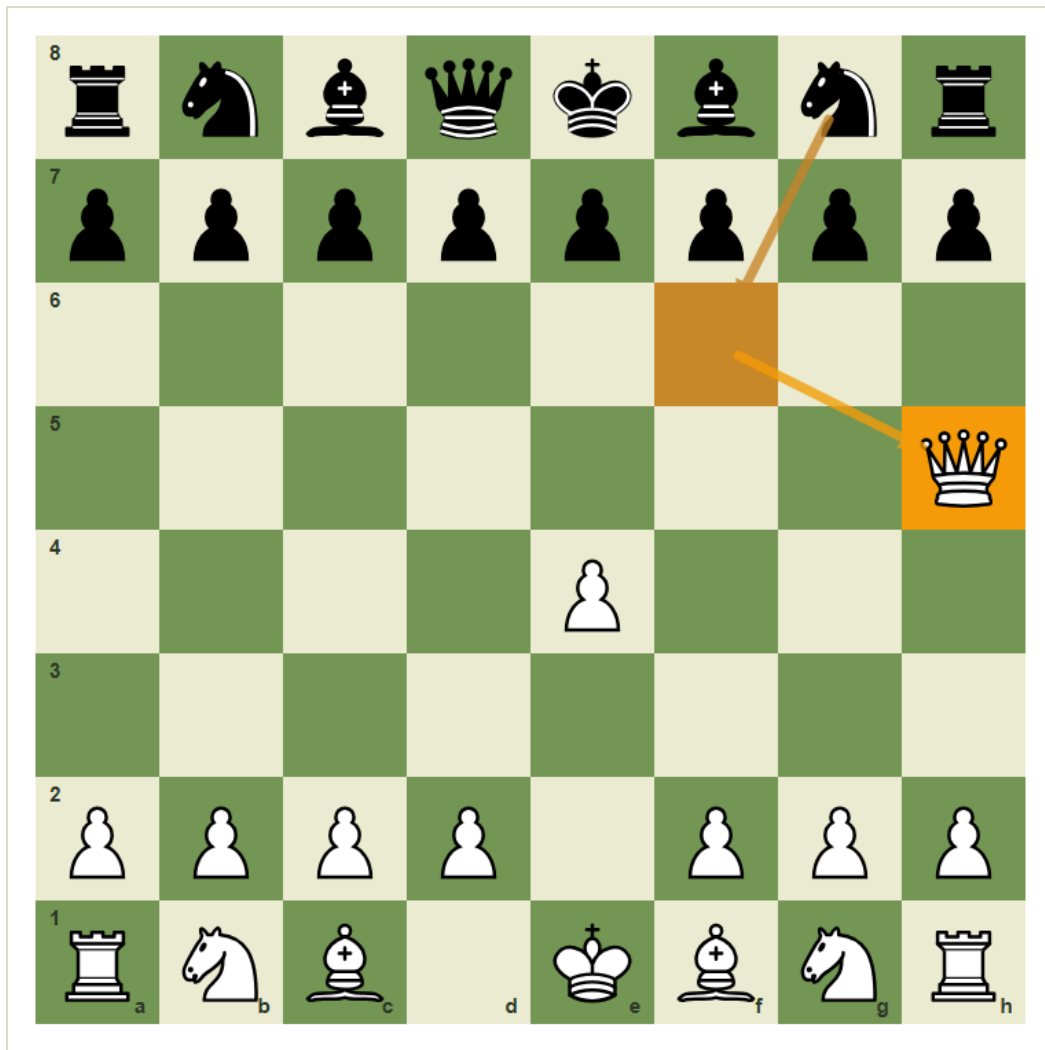
Move the queen to h5

Move the queen from d1 to h5 along the diagonal.

Common Mistake

Common mistake: ignoring attacks on the queen

Beginners often bring the queen out and forget that the opponent can attack it. Here Black can play Ng8 to f6 and make the queen move again.



The knight move attacks the queen. A queen move that loses time needs a clear reason.

Chapter Checkpoint

How does the queen move?

The queen moves like:

- a. A rook and bishop combined
- b. A knight and pawn combined
- c. Only one square

Can a queen jump?

A queen can jump over pieces:

- a. No
- b. Yes, if she captures
- c. Only diagonally

Why can early queen moves be risky?

Early queen moves can be risky because:

- a. The queen may get attacked and lose time
- b. The queen cannot capture
- c. The queen is worth only one point

The Knight And Jumps

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The knight is the only piece that jumps over blockers.

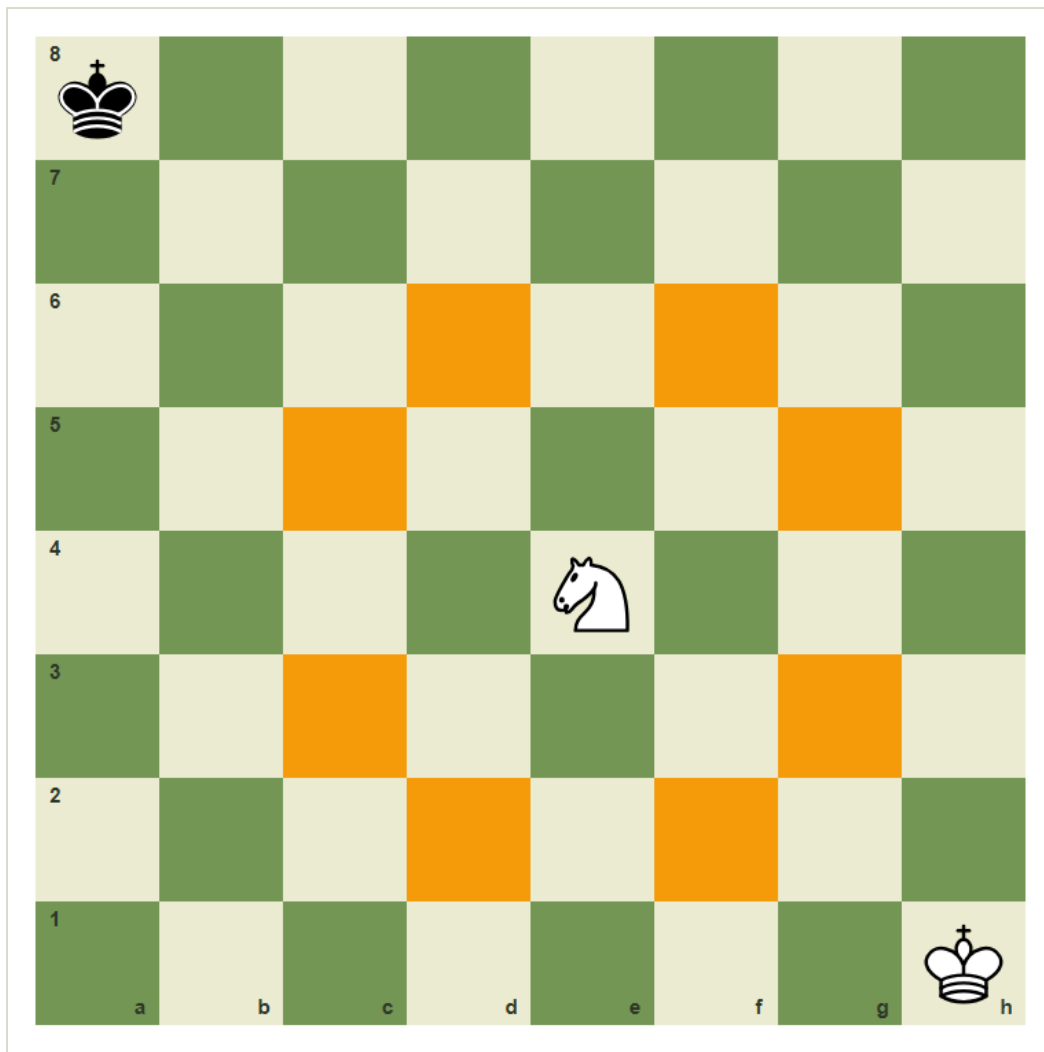
Learning objectives

- Move a knight in an L shape.
- List the knight moves from a center square.
- Understand that knights jump over pieces but cannot land on friendly pieces.
- Recognize that edge knights have fewer moves.

The L Shape

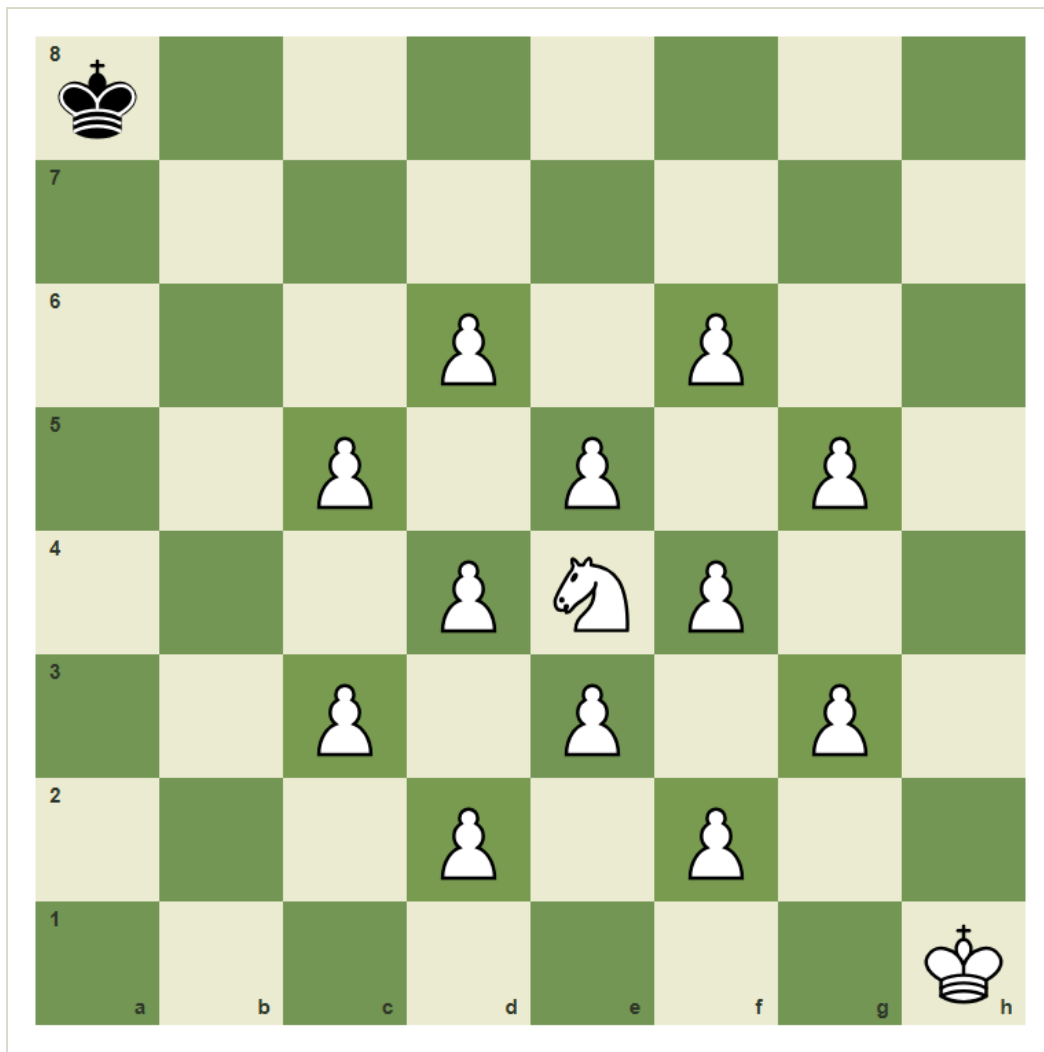
The knight moves in an L shape: two squares in one direction and one square sideways. It is the only piece that can jump over pieces.

Knight moves from e4



A knight on e4 has up to eight landing squares.

The knight jumps over blockers

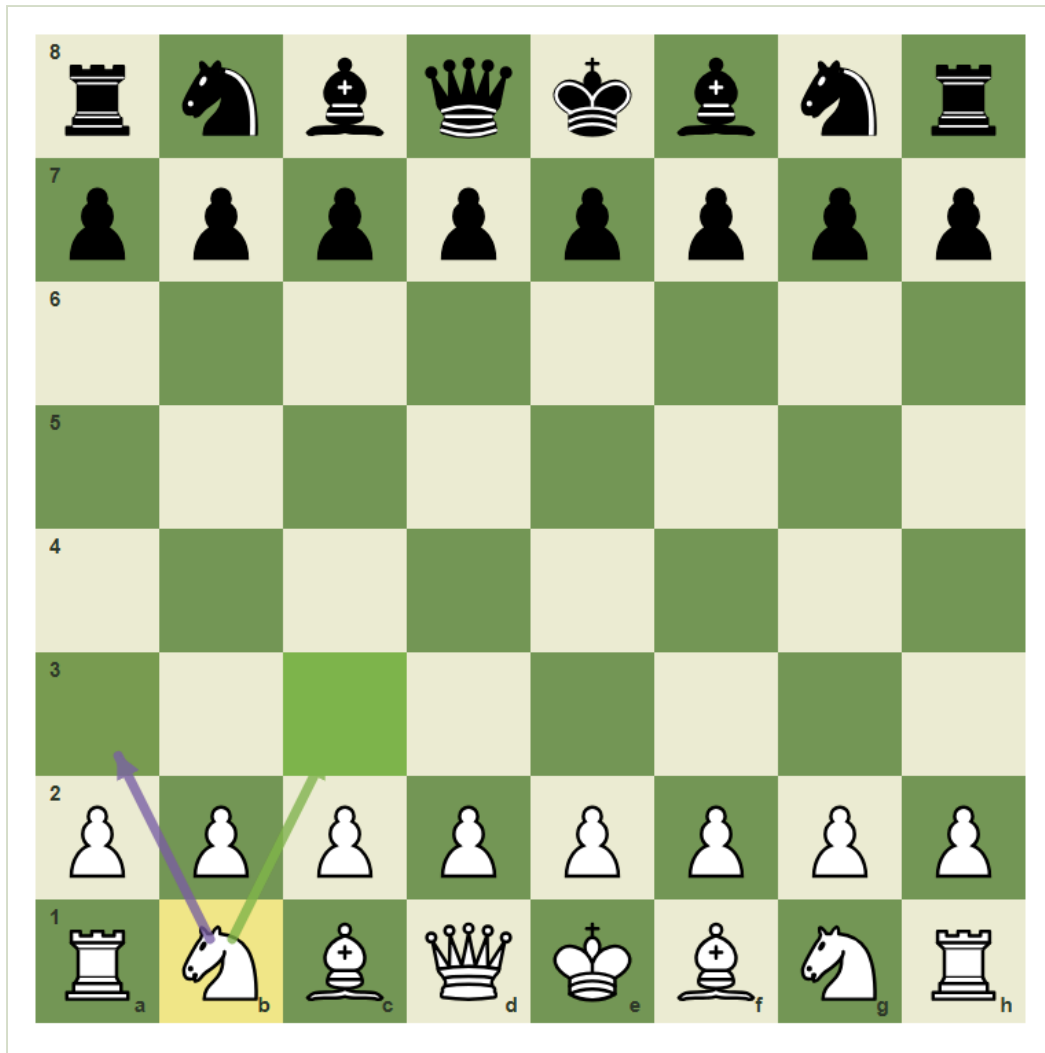


Even when surrounded, the knight on e4 can jump to its L-shaped landing squares.

Knights From The Starting Position

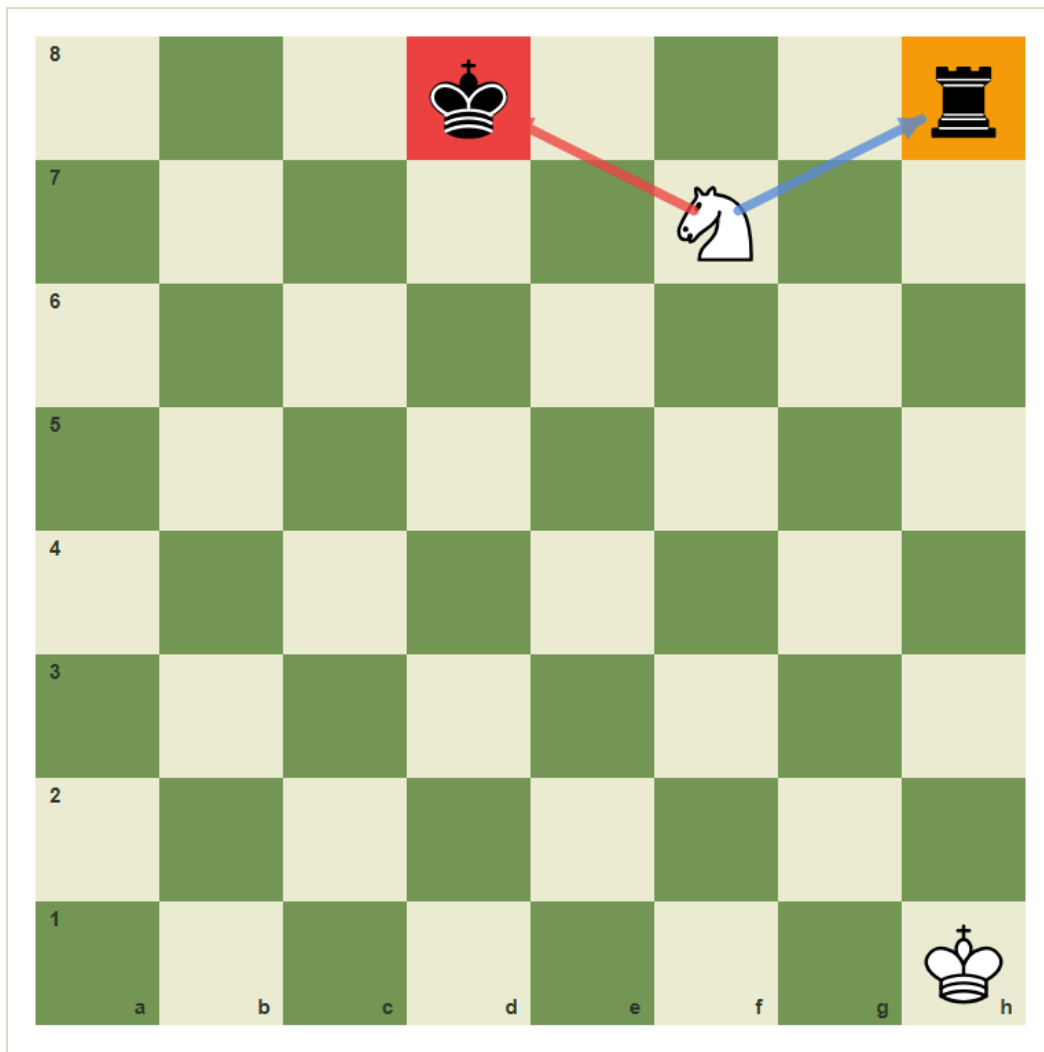
From the starting position, the knight is the first piece that can move without a pawn moving first. The knight jumps over the pawns.

The b1 knight can jump



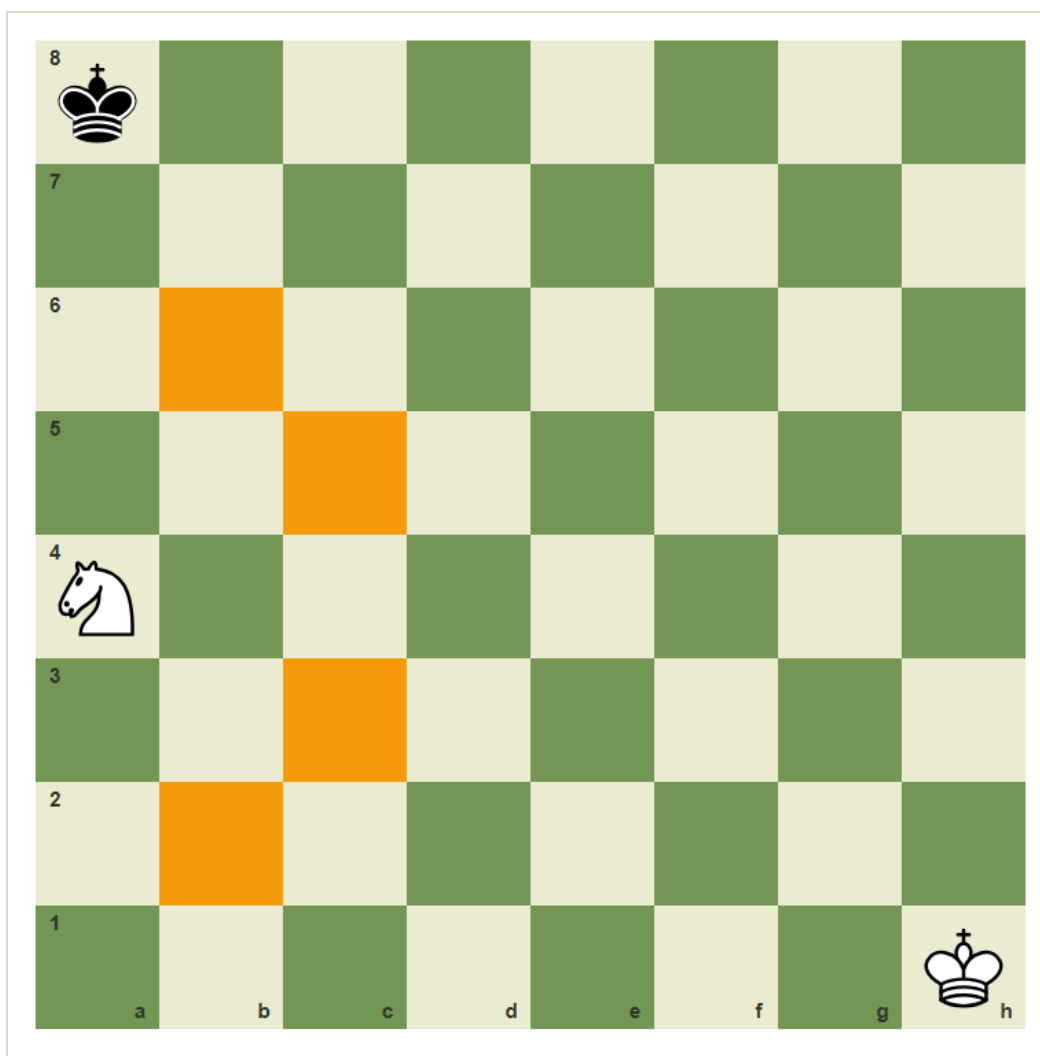
The knight on b1 can jump to a3 or c3 at the start.

A knight fork pattern



A knight on f7 attacks the king on d8 and the rook on h8 at the same time.

Edge knights have fewer moves



A knight on a4 has only four legal landing squares instead of eight.

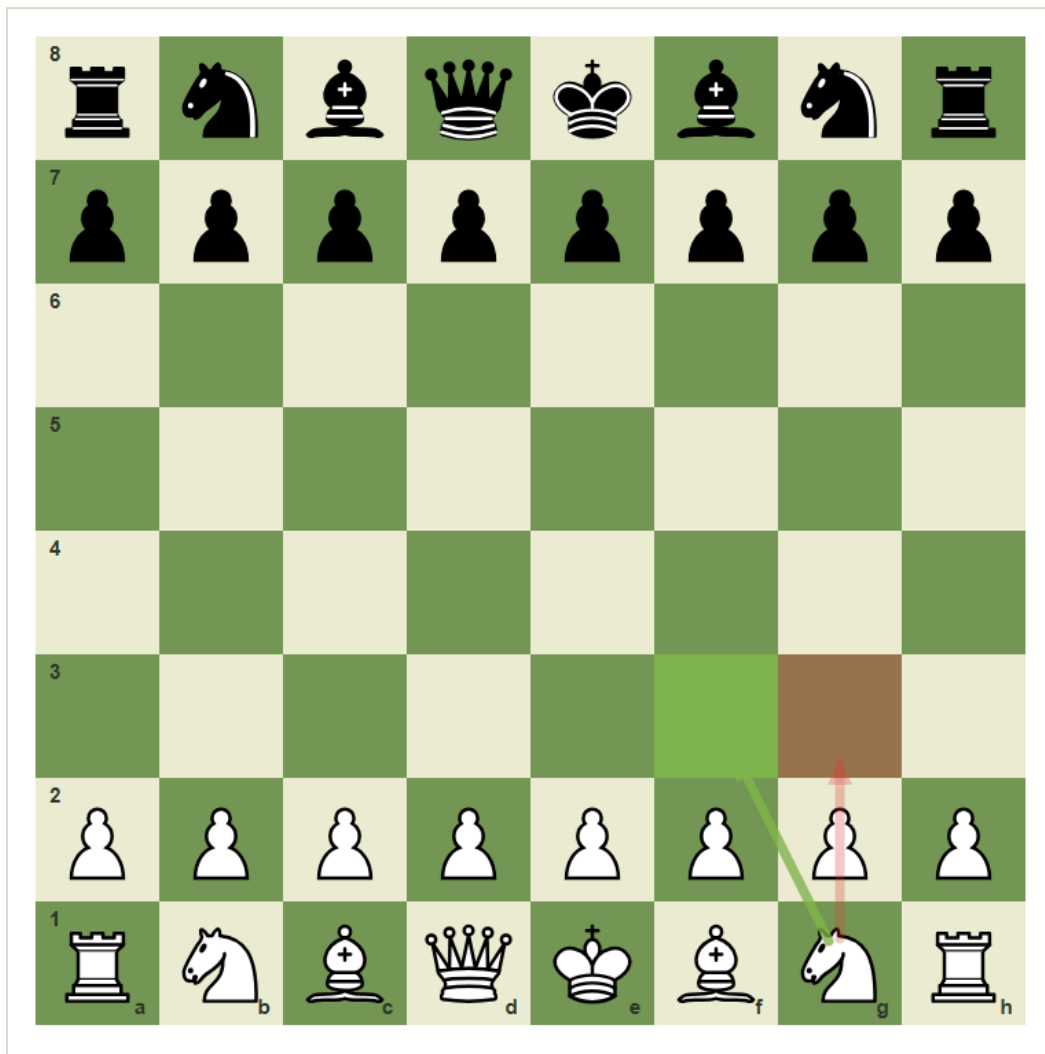
Develop the knight to f3

Move the knight from g1 to f3.

Common Mistake

Common mistake: sliding the knight

A knight on g1 cannot slide to g3. Knights do not move straight; they move in an L shape.



g1 to f3 is a knight move. g1 to g3 is not.

Chapter Checkpoint

What shape is a knight move?

A knight moves:

- a. In an L shape
- b. Only diagonally
- c. Only one square

Can knights jump?

A knight can jump over pieces:

- a. Yes
- b. No
- c. Only over pawns

Where can the g1 knight move at the start?

From the starting position, the knight on g1 can move to:

- a. f3
- b. g3
- c. g2

Pawn Moves, Captures, And Promotion

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Pawns are small pieces with the most special rules.

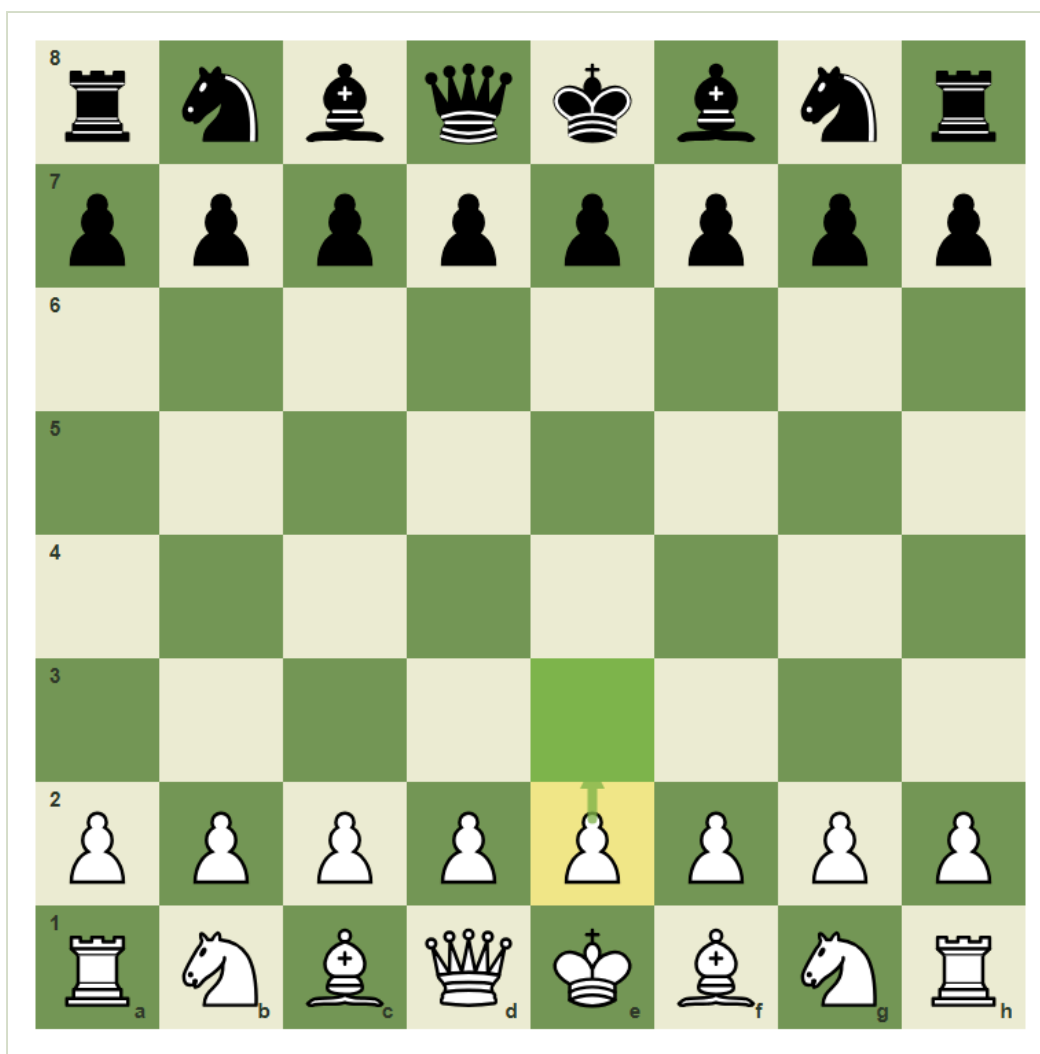
Learning objectives

- Move pawns one square forward.
- Use the two-square first move.
- Capture diagonally with pawns.
- Reject backward pawn moves.
- Understand promotion on the last rank.

Forward Movement

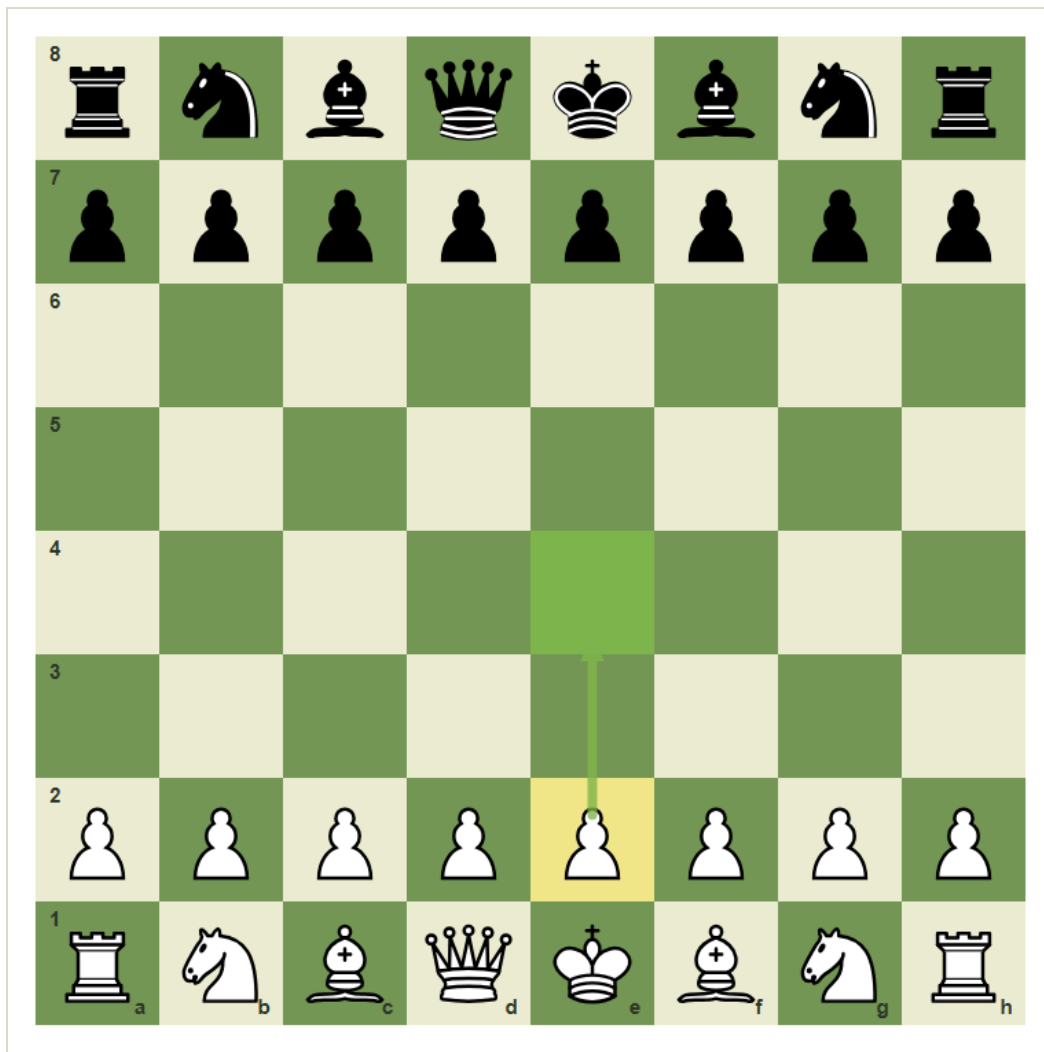
Pawns move forward, but they capture diagonally. White pawns move toward rank 8. Black pawns move toward rank 1.

White pawn one step



The white e-pawn can move one square from e2 to e3.

Two-square first move

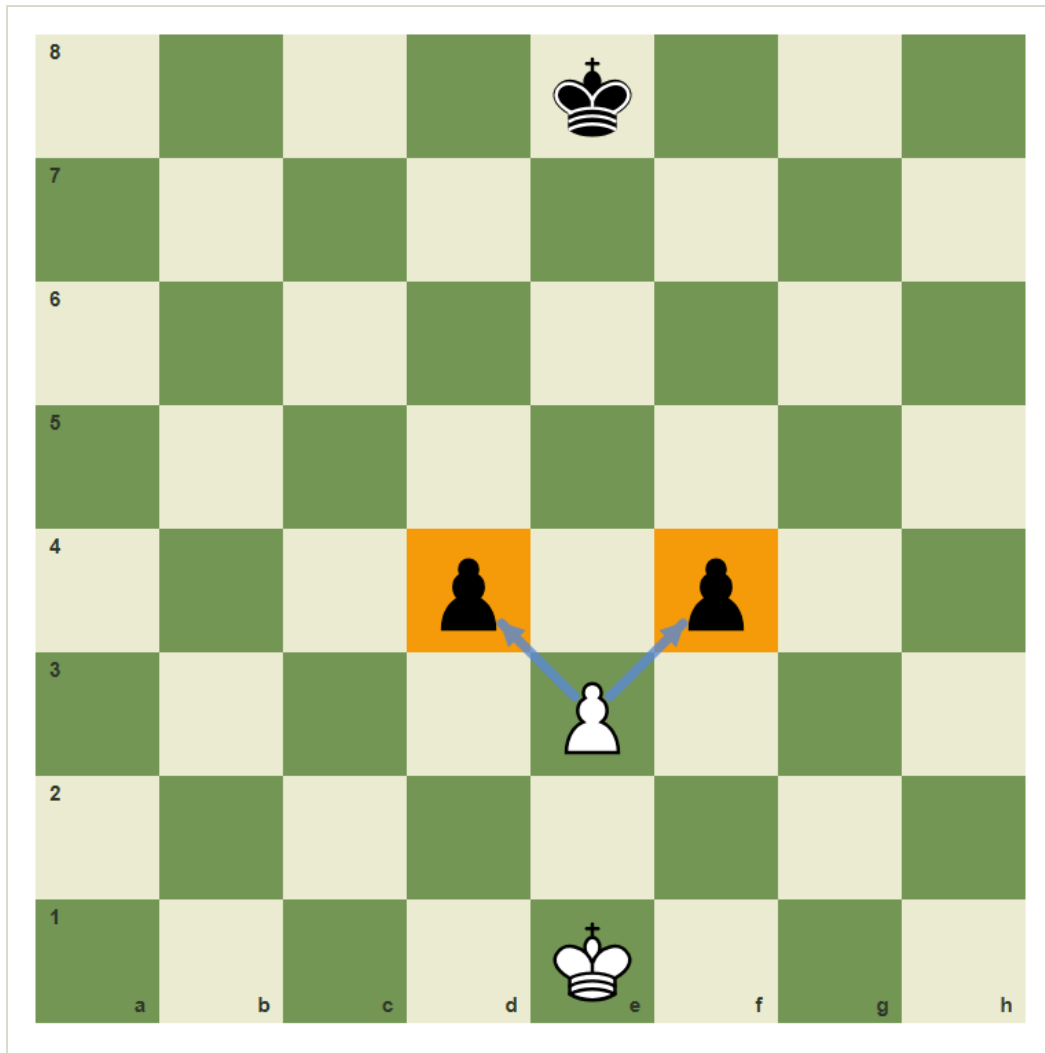


From its starting square, the e-pawn can move two squares to e4 if the path is clear.

Captures And Promotion

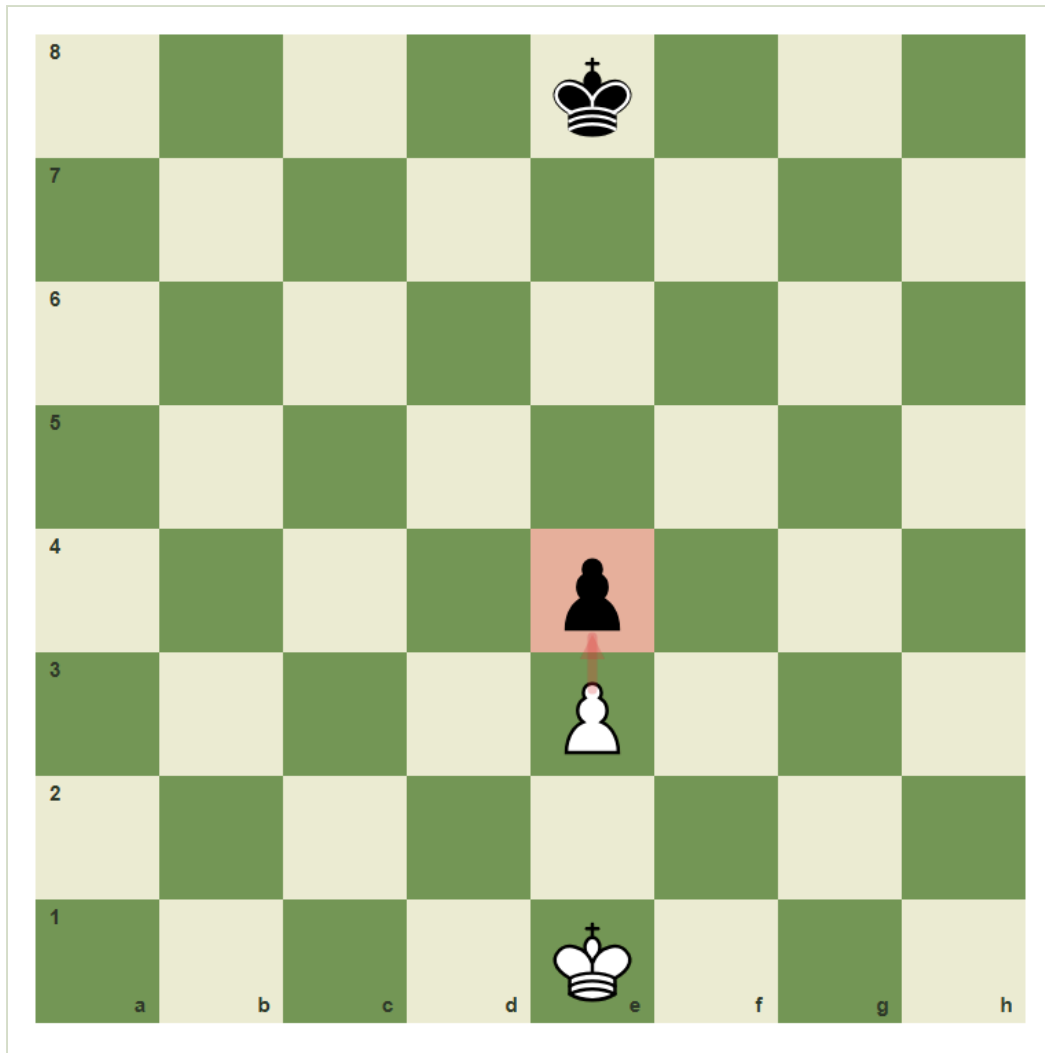
A pawn does not capture straight ahead. It captures one square diagonally forward. If a pawn reaches the last rank, it promotes, usually to a queen.

Pawn captures diagonally



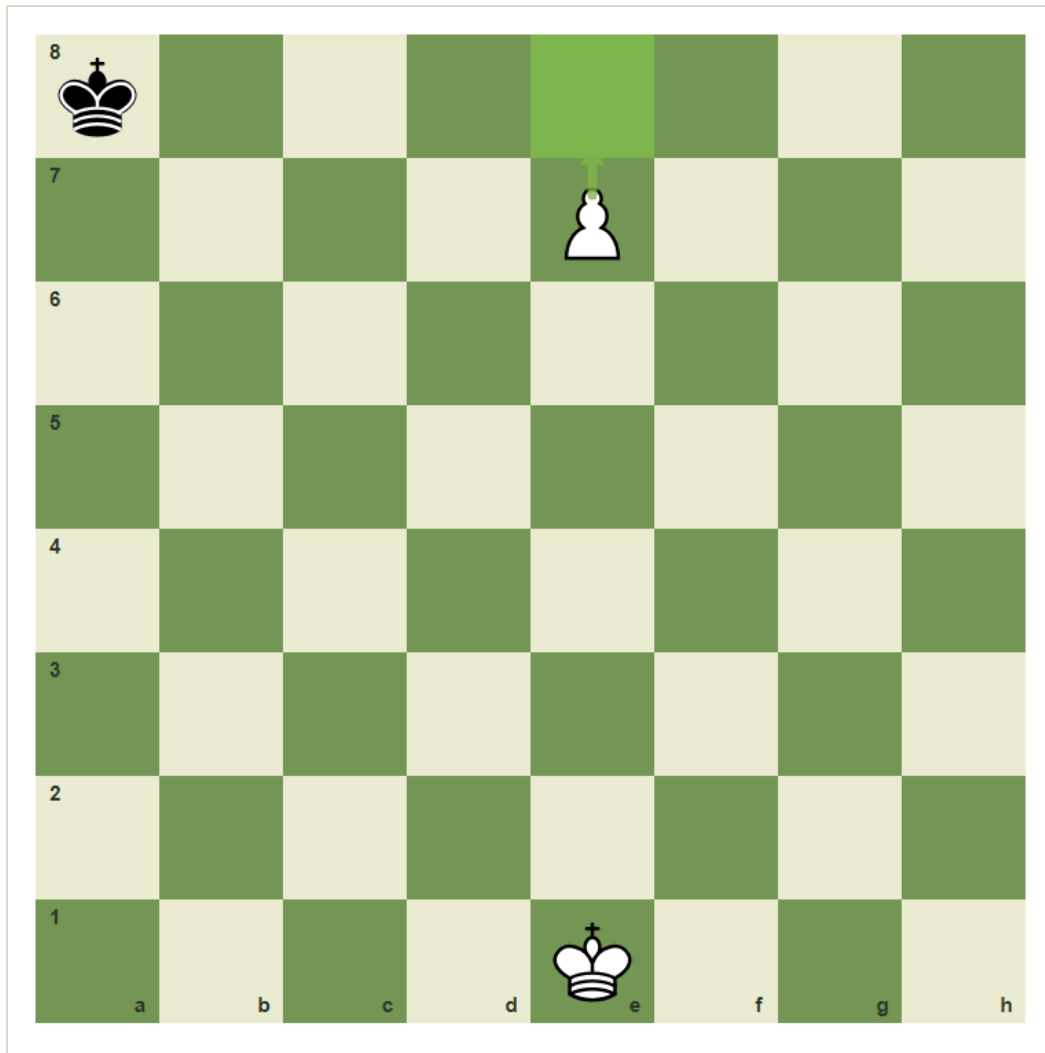
The pawn on e3 can capture the enemy pawns on d4 or f4.

Pawns do not capture forward



The pawn on e3 cannot capture the enemy pawn directly in front of it on e4.

Promotion square



When the pawn moves from e7 to e8, it promotes. The usual choice is a queen.

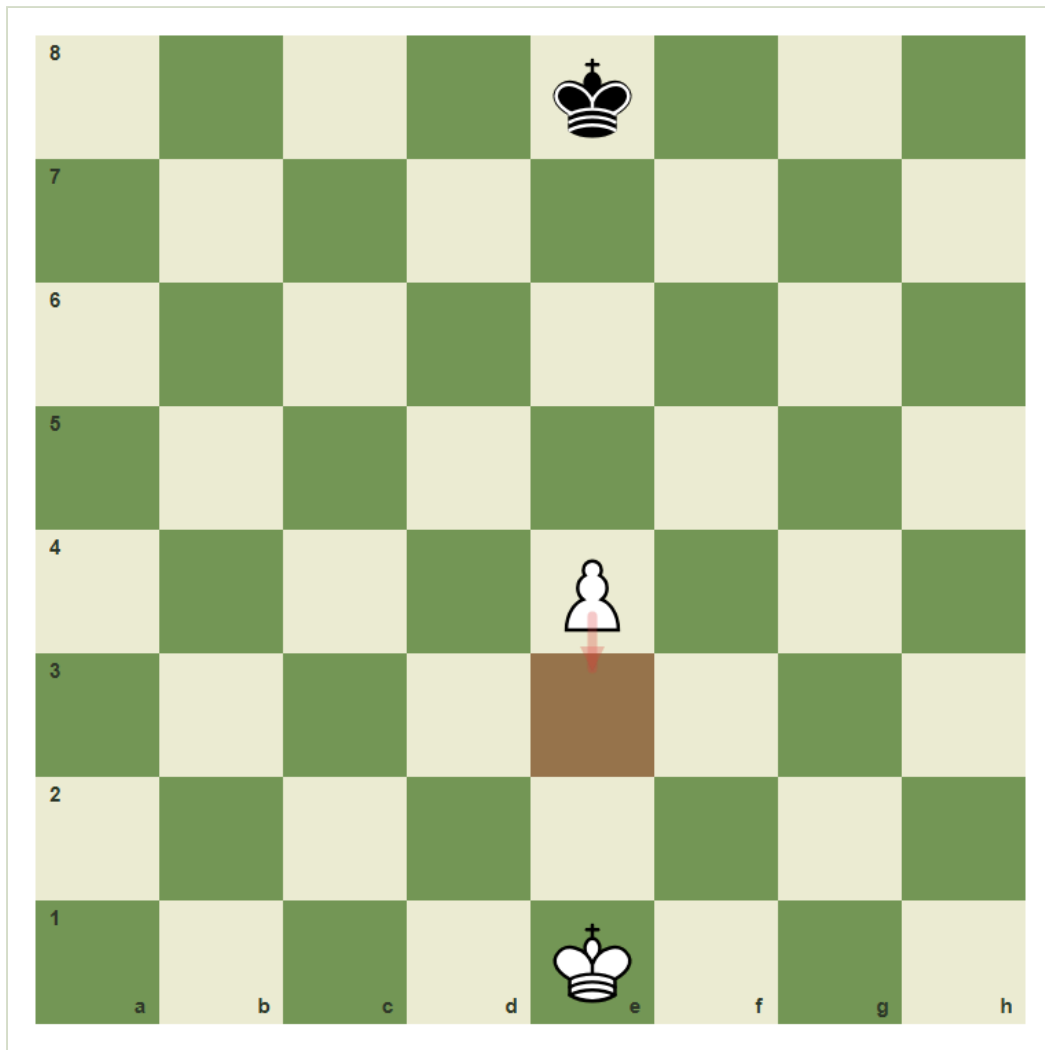
Play the two-square pawn move

Move the White e-pawn from e2 to e4.

Common Mistake

Common mistake: moving backward

A white pawn on e4 cannot move backward to e3. Pawns only move forward unless they are promoting or capturing diagonally forward.



Backward pawn moves are not legal.

Chapter Checkpoint

How does a white pawn move?

A white pawn normally moves:

- a. Toward higher ranks
- b. Backward toward rank 1
- c. Sideways

How does a pawn capture?

A pawn captures:

- a. One square diagonally forward
- b. Straight forward
- c. Like a knight

What happens on the last rank?

A pawn that reaches the last rank:

- a. Promotes
- b. Disappears
- c. Must become a king

Check And Escaping Check

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When the king is attacked, the next move must answer it.

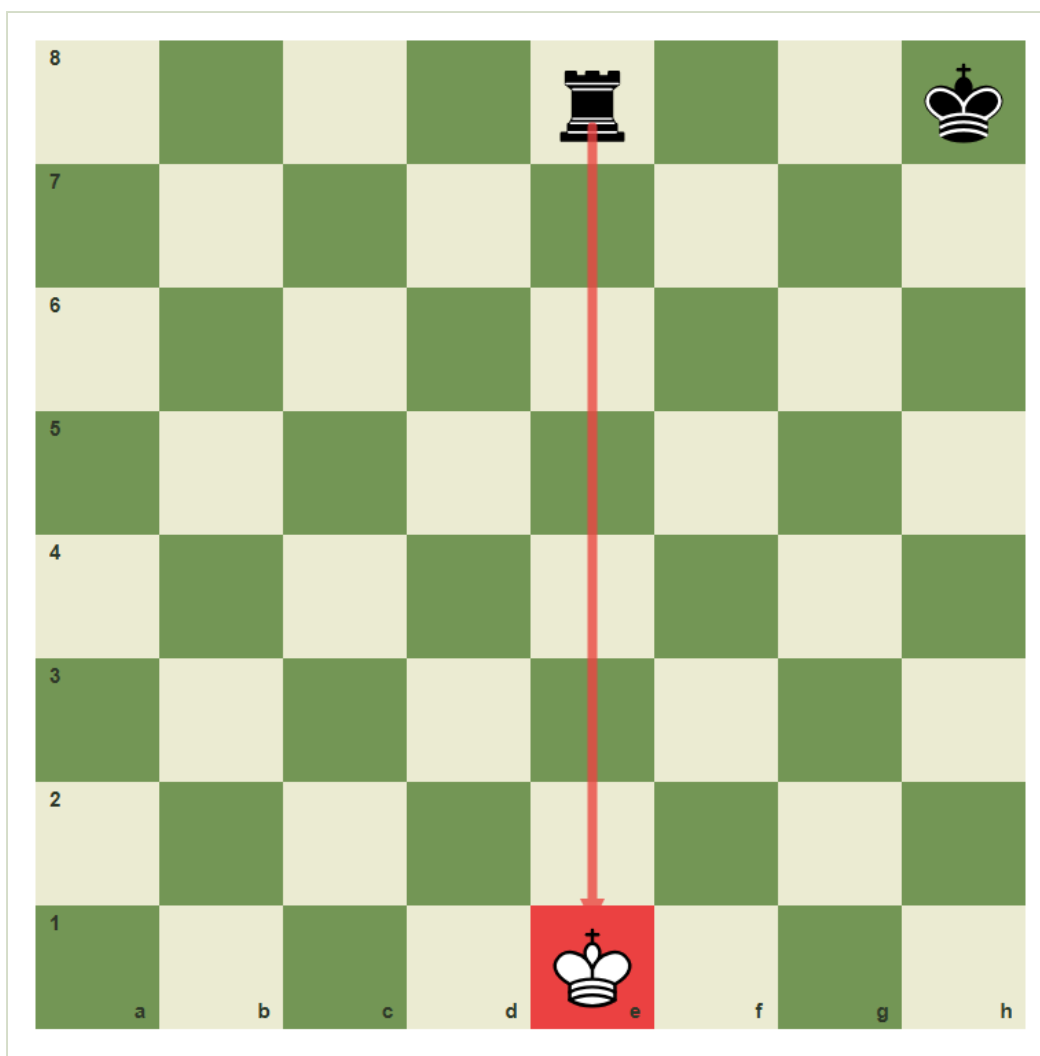
Learning objectives

- Recognize when a king is in check.
- Escape check by moving the king.
- Escape check by blocking the attack.
- Escape check by capturing the checking piece.
- Reject moves that ignore check.

A Direct Attack On The King

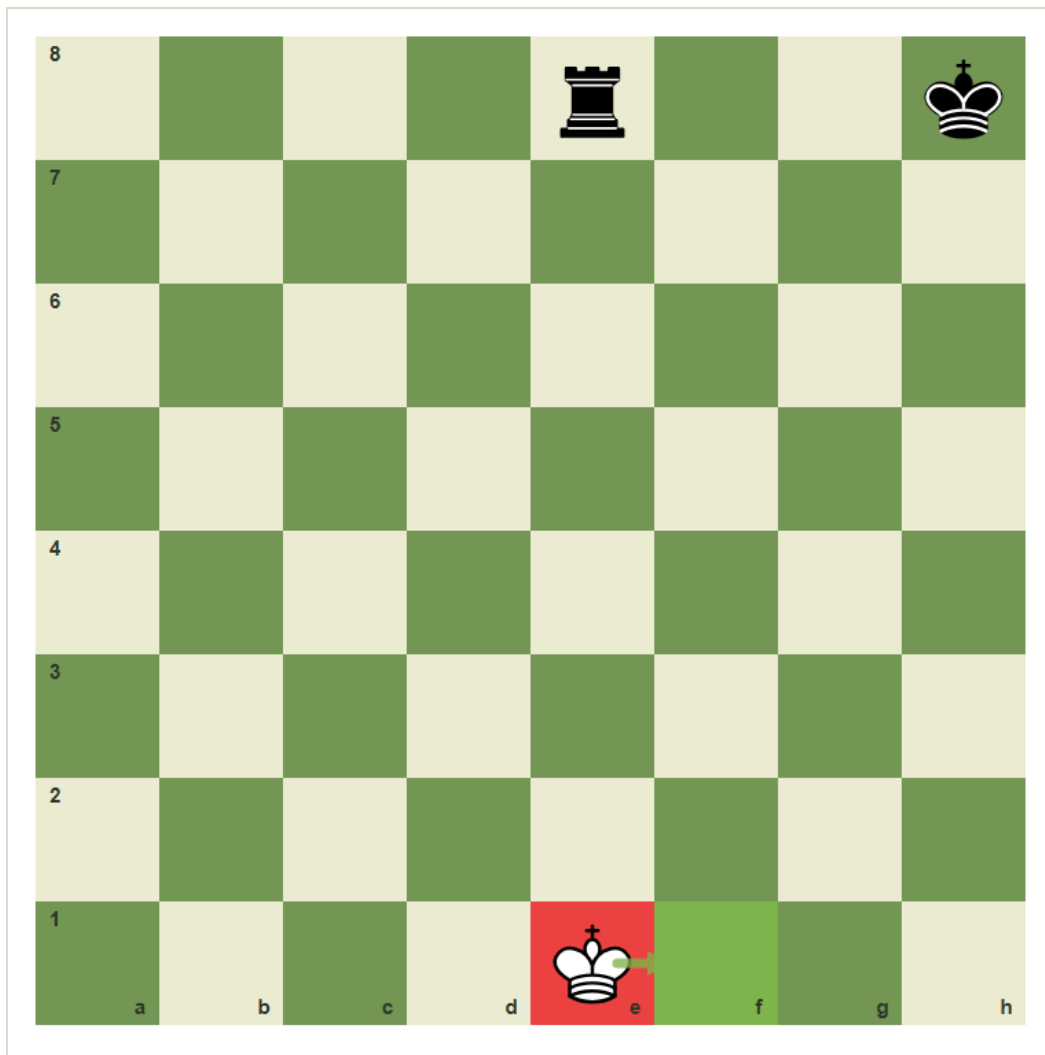
Check means the king is under attack. When your king is in check, you do not get to play any move you like. Your move must make the king safe.

The rook gives check



The rook on e8 attacks the king on e1 along the open e-file.

Escape by moving the king

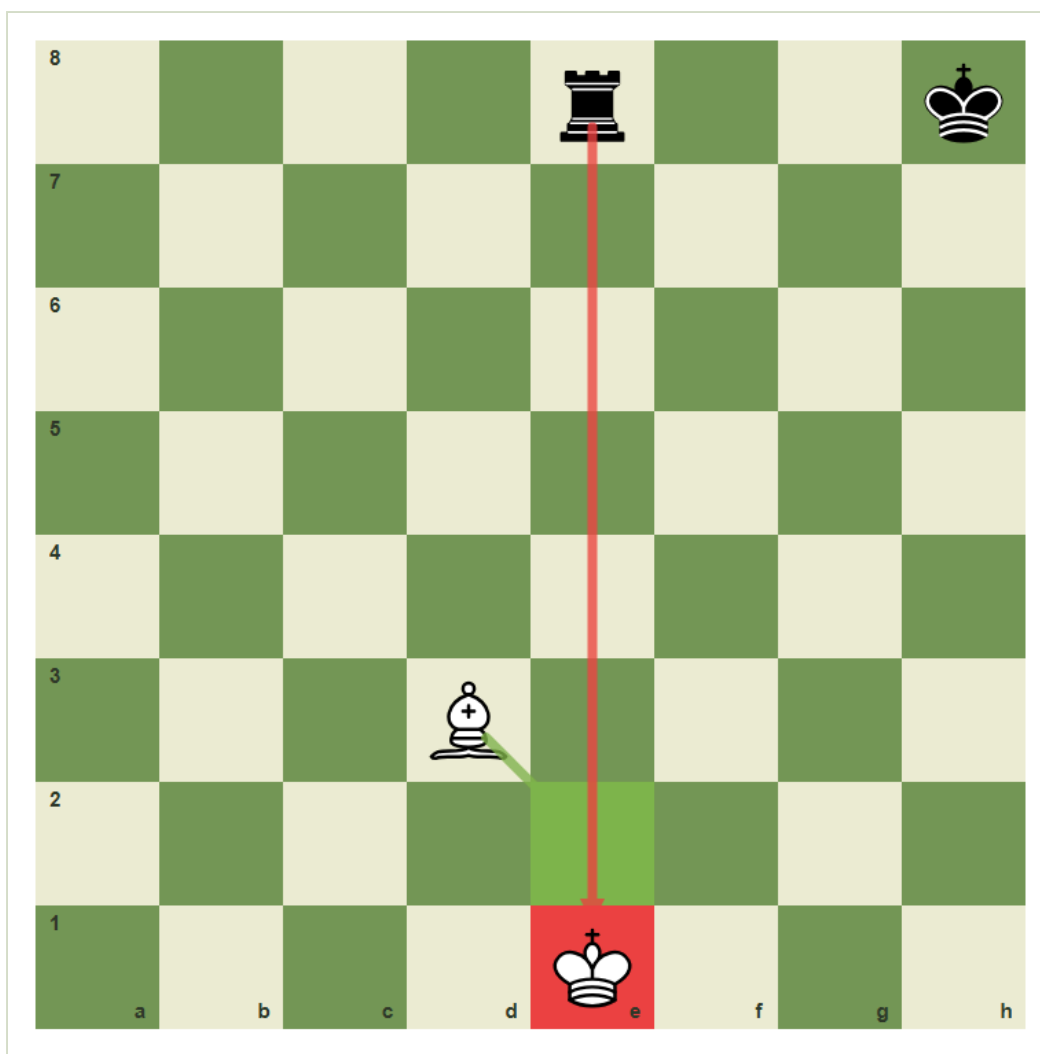


White can move the king from e1 to f1 to leave the rook line.

Three Ways To Escape

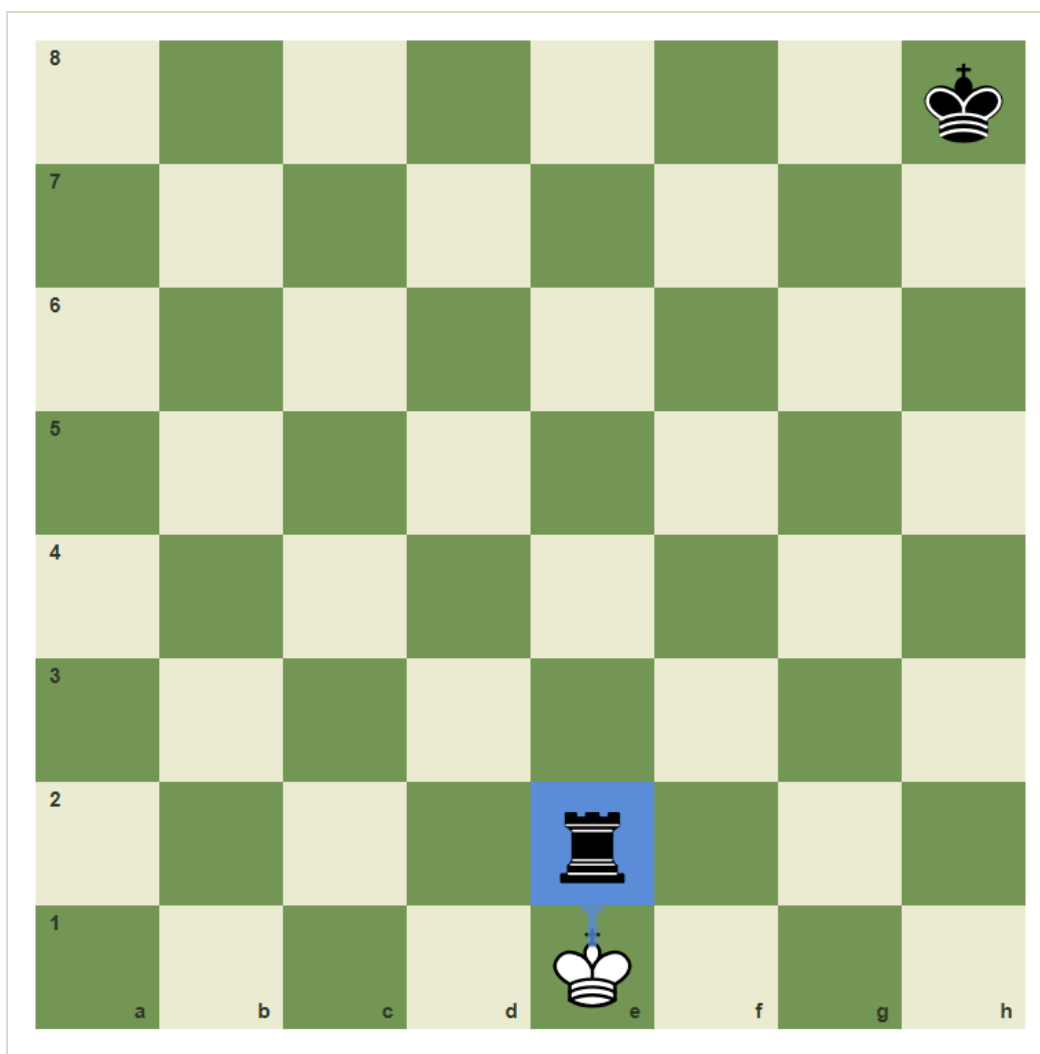
There are three normal ways to answer check: move the king, block the line, or capture the checking piece. Some checks allow only one of these.

Escape by blocking



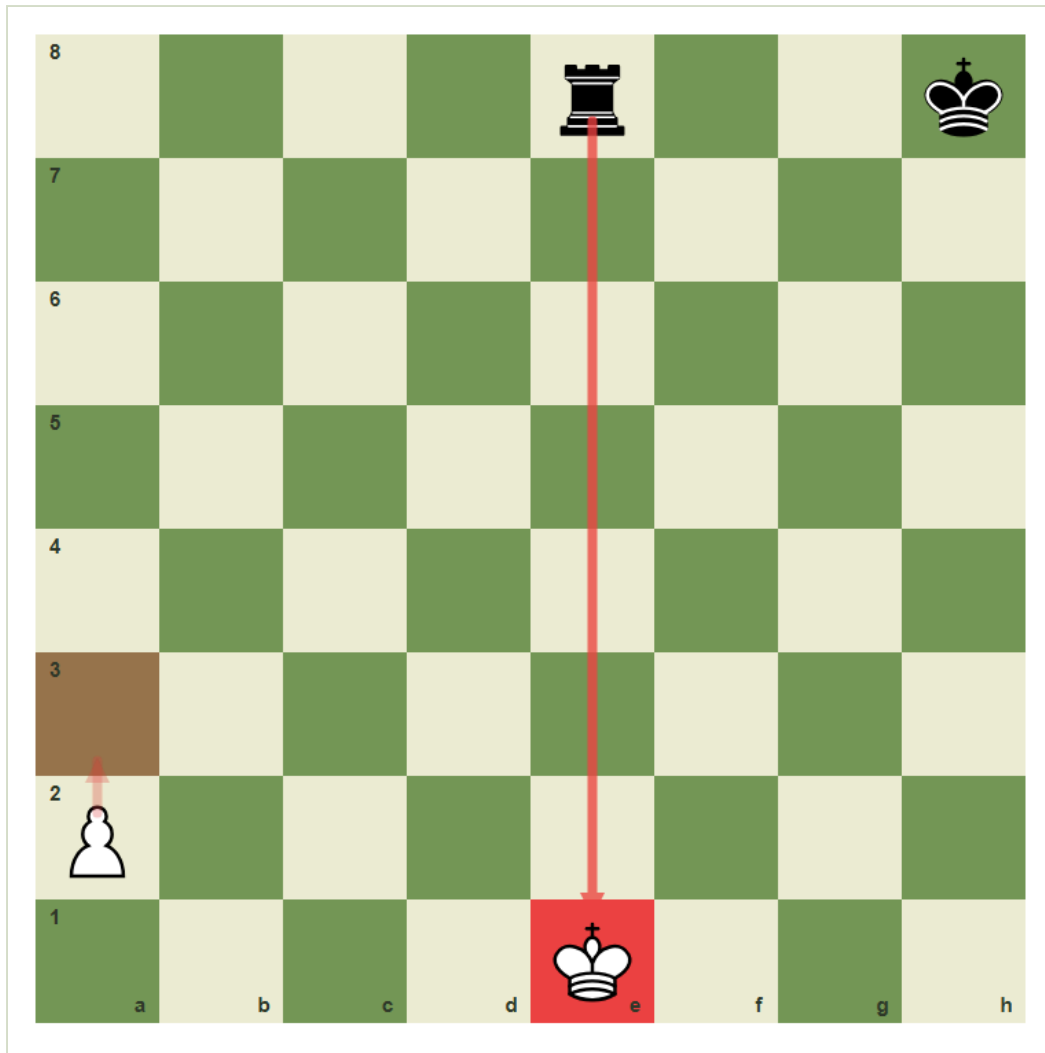
The bishop can move to e2 and block the rook line.

Escape by capturing



If the checking rook is unprotected, the king can capture it on e2.

You may not ignore check



The move a2 to a3 does not answer the check, so it is illegal here.

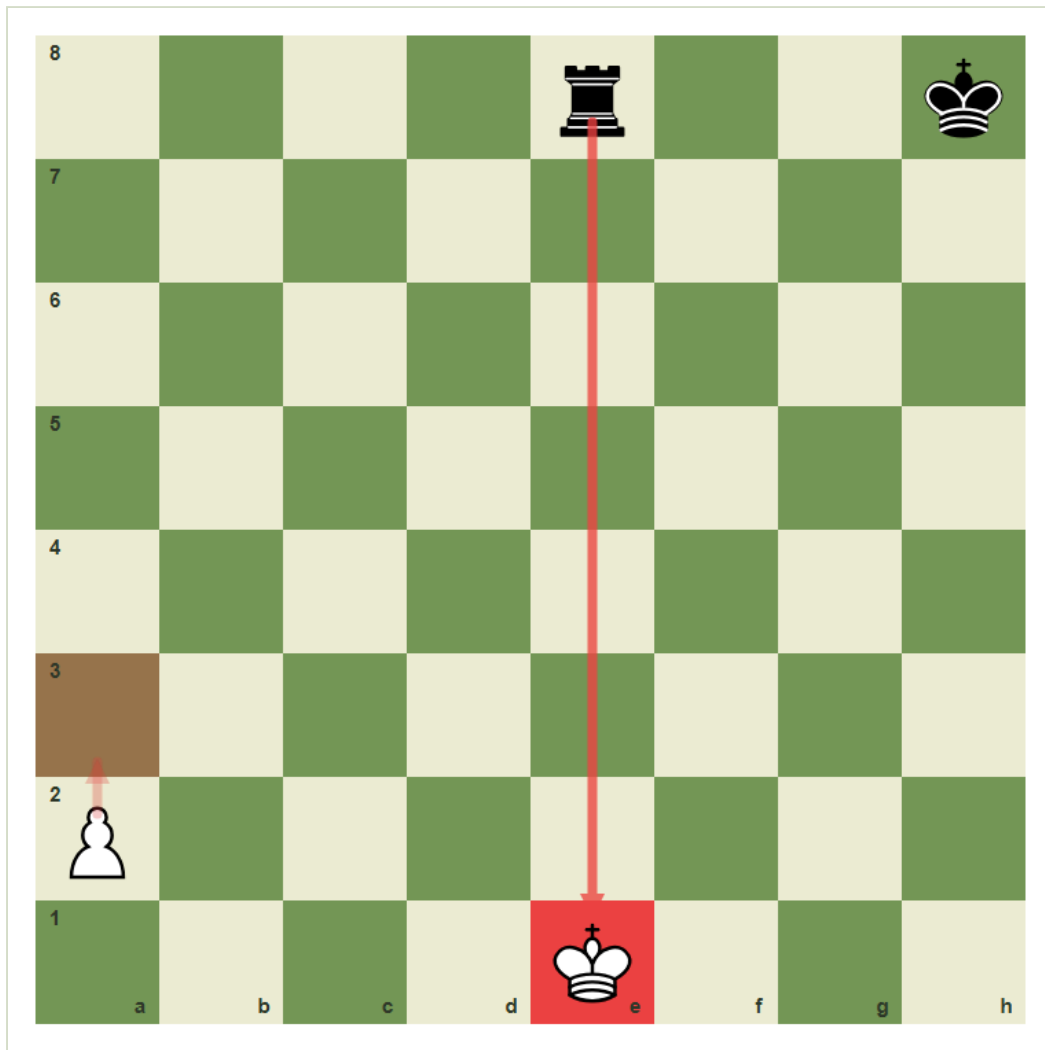
Move out of check

White is in check from the rook on e8. Move the king from e1 to f1.

Common Mistake

Common mistake: playing a normal move in check

The pawn move a2 to a3 may be legal in a quiet position, but not while the king on e1 is in check. Check must be answered immediately.



A move that ignores check is not legal.

Chapter Checkpoint

What is check?

Check means:

- a. The king is attacked
- b. A queen was captured
- c. A pawn promoted

What must you do in check?

When your king is in check, your next move must:

- a. Make the king safe
- b. Capture any piece
- c. Move a pawn

Which is not a normal escape from check?

Which answer does not normally escape check?

- a. Ignore it and attack elsewhere
- b. Move the king
- c. Block the line

Checkmate And Stalemate

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Winning requires mate, not just trapping the king.

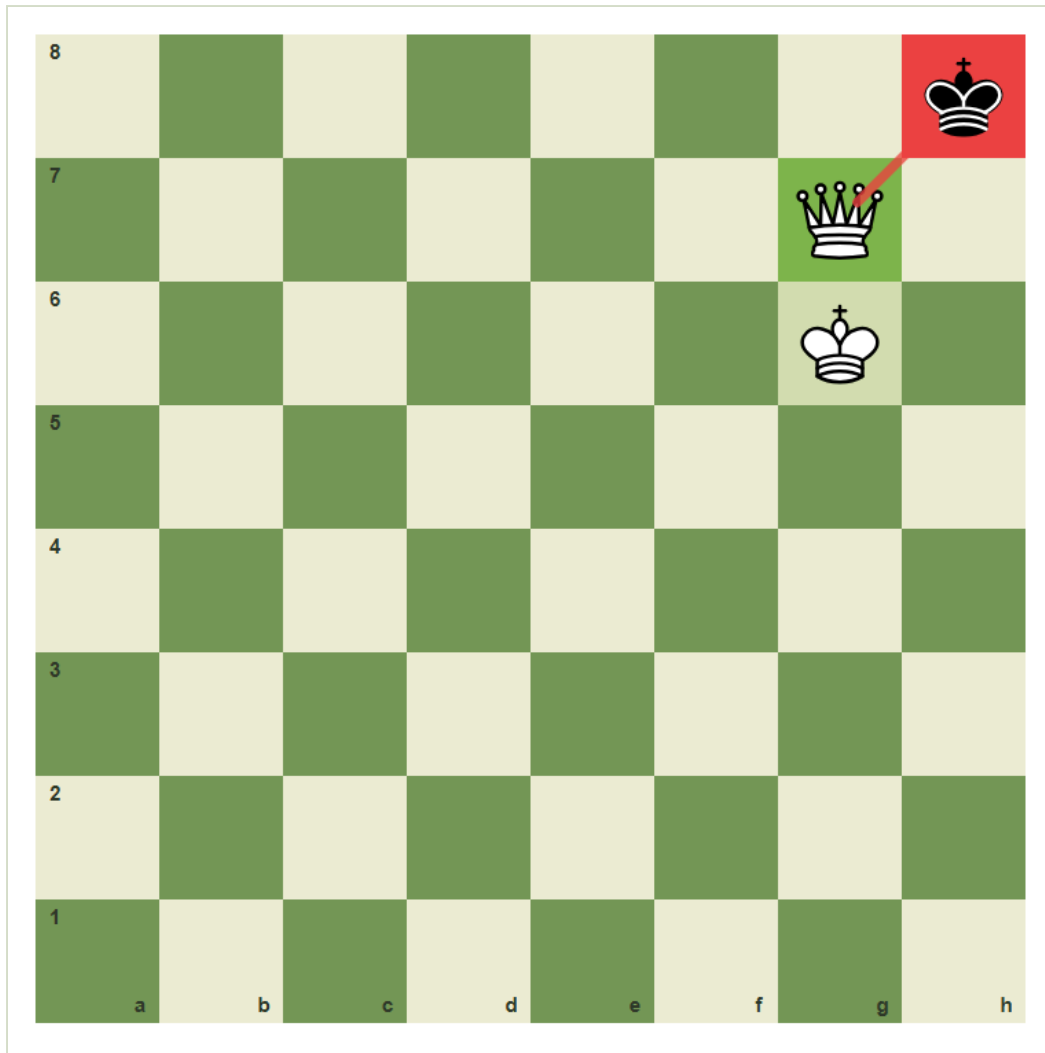
Learning objectives

- Define checkmate as check with no legal escape.
- Recognize stalemate as no legal move but no check.
- Avoid stalemating a winning position.
- Deliver a simple queen-assisted mate.

Check Plus No Escape

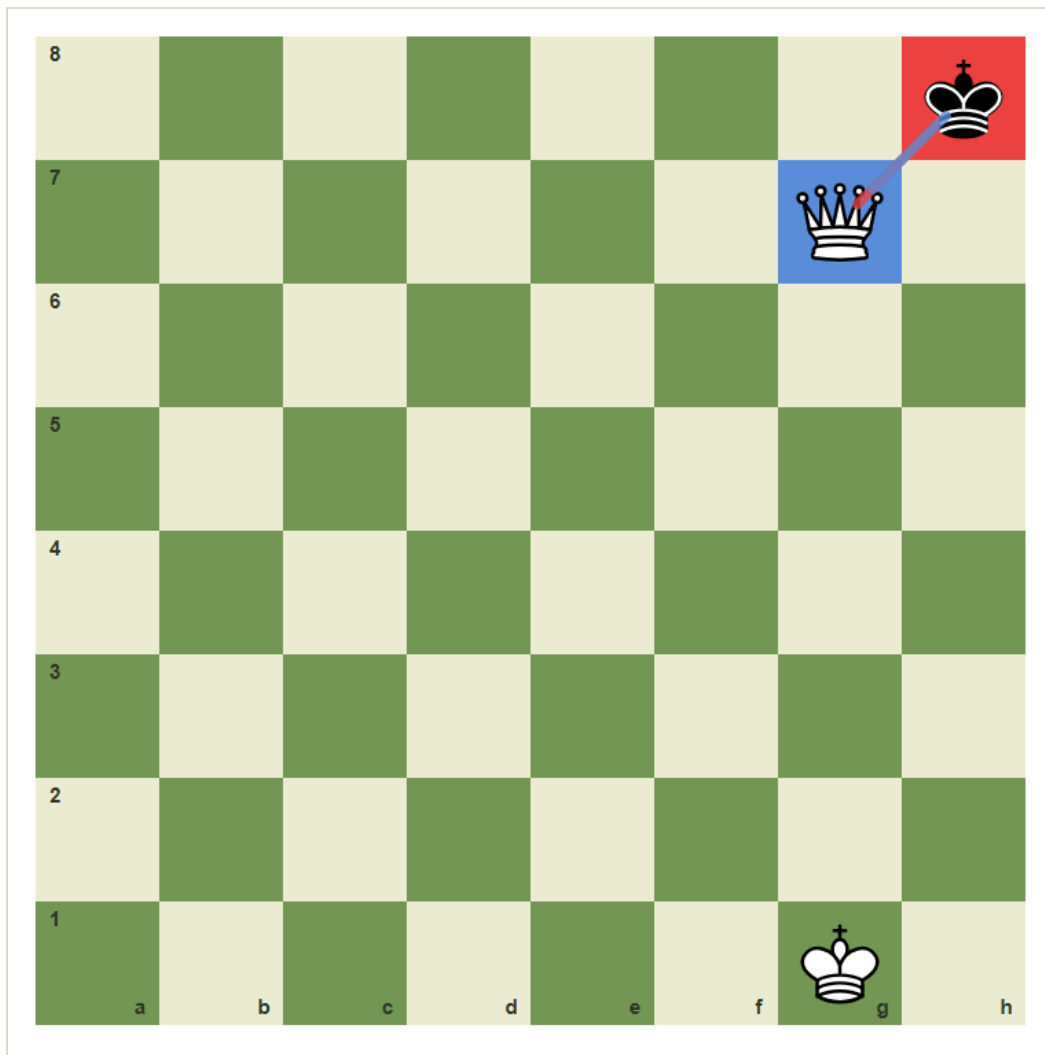
Checkmate means the king is in check and there is no legal escape. If the king is not in check, the position is not checkmate.

Queen-supported checkmate



The queen checks h8, and the king on g6 supports the queen. Black has no escape.

Check but not mate

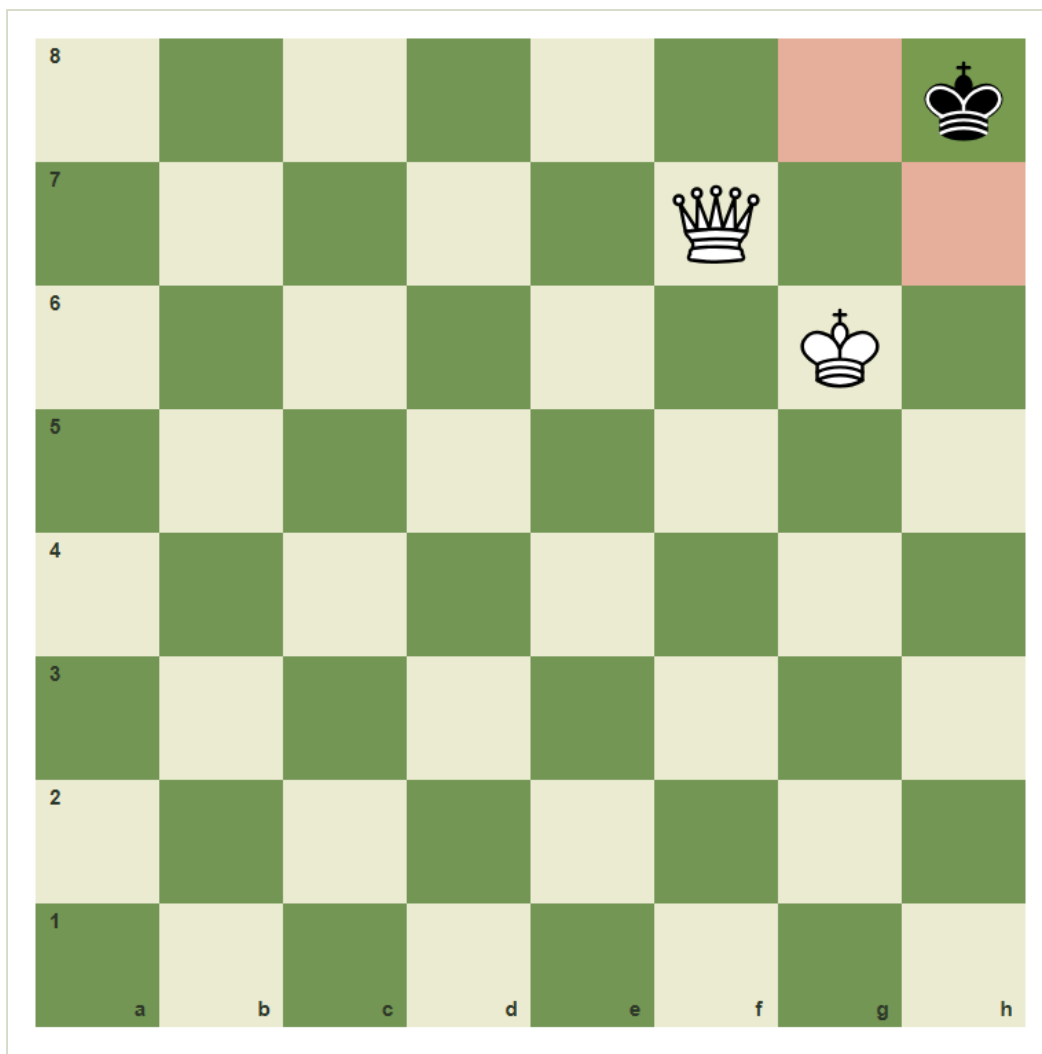


This is check, but the queen is not protected. Black can capture it.

Stalemate Is Not A Win

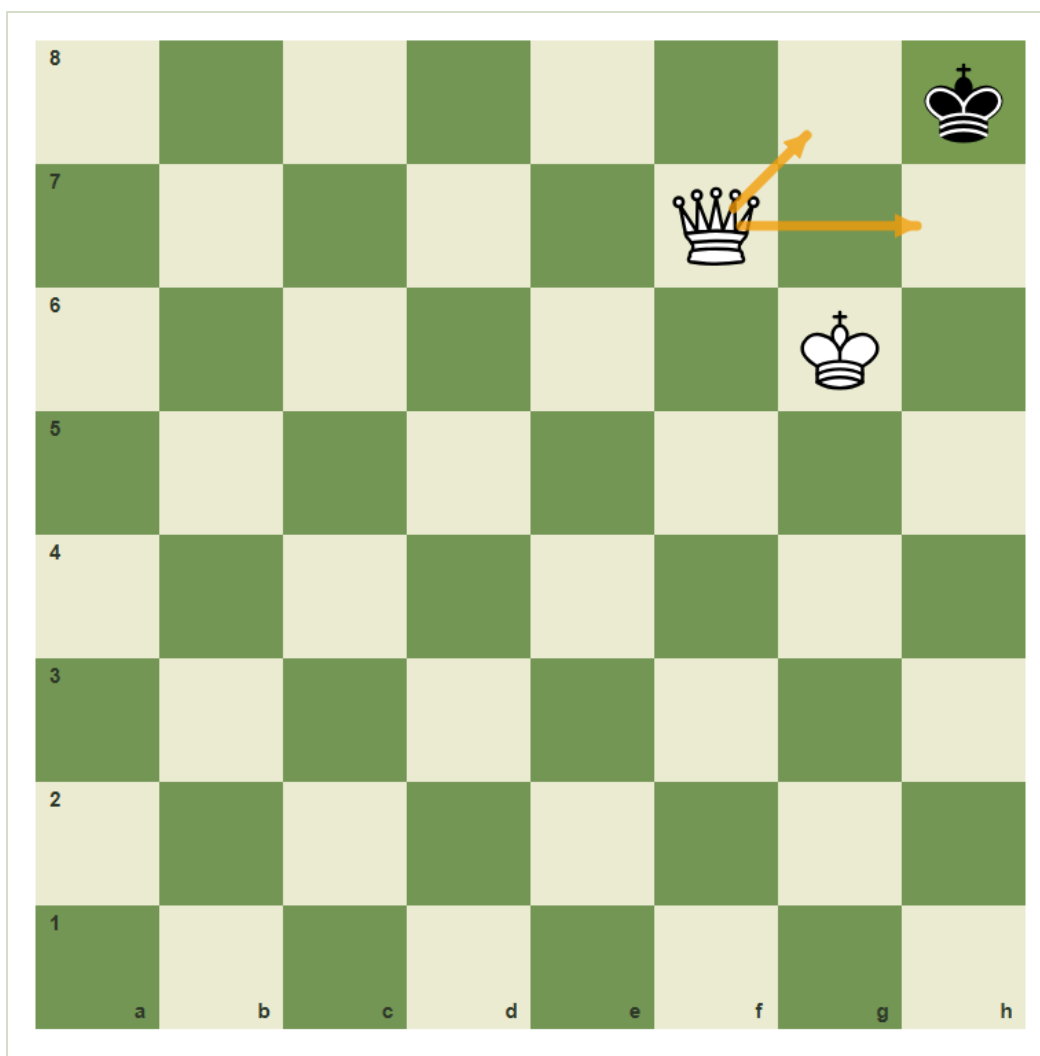
Stalemate happens when the player to move is not in check but has no legal move. Stalemate is a draw. Beginners lose many winning positions by forgetting this difference.

Stalemate pattern



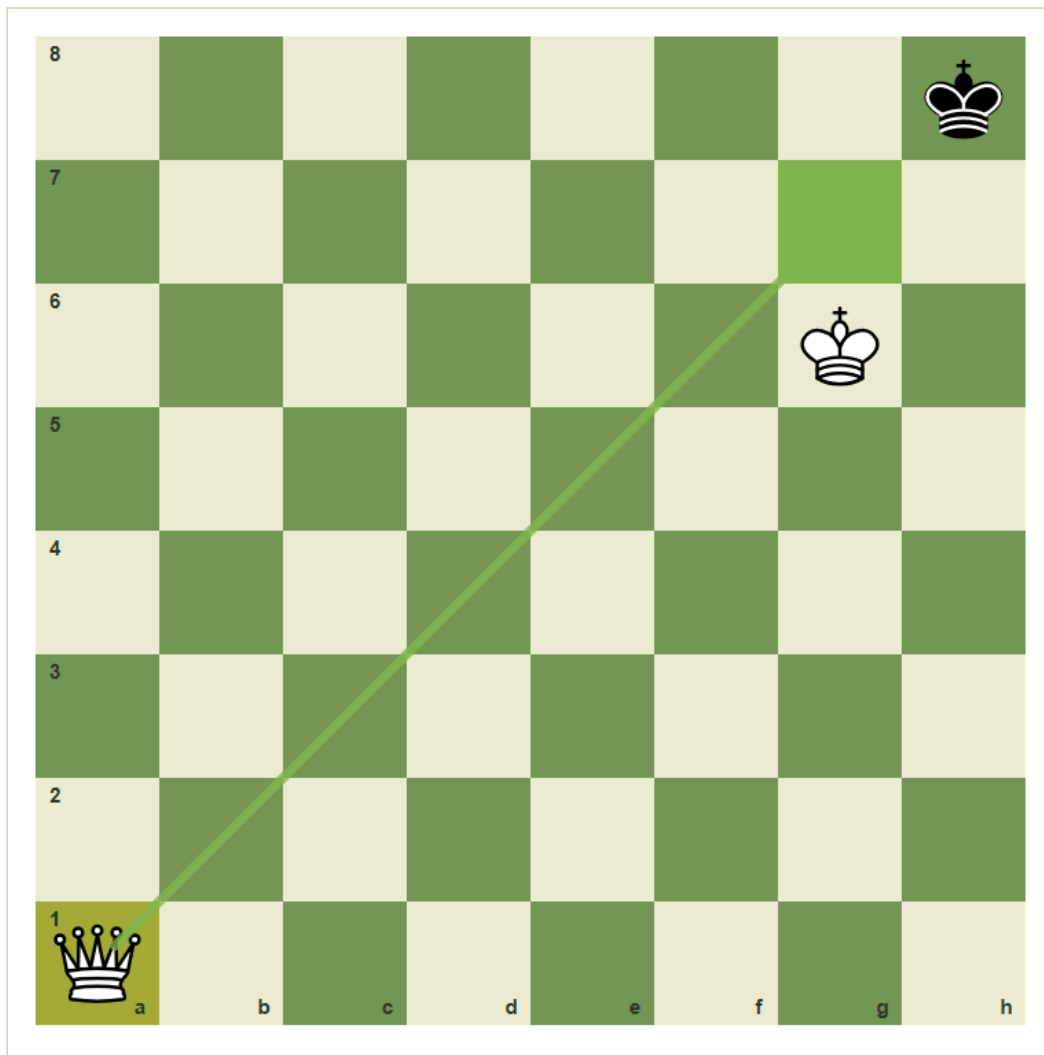
Black is not in check, but every black king move is controlled. This is stalemate, not checkmate.

The missing check



The queen controls escape squares, but she does not attack h8. No check means no checkmate.

Mate move available



White can play Qa1 to g7, giving a protected queen checkmate.

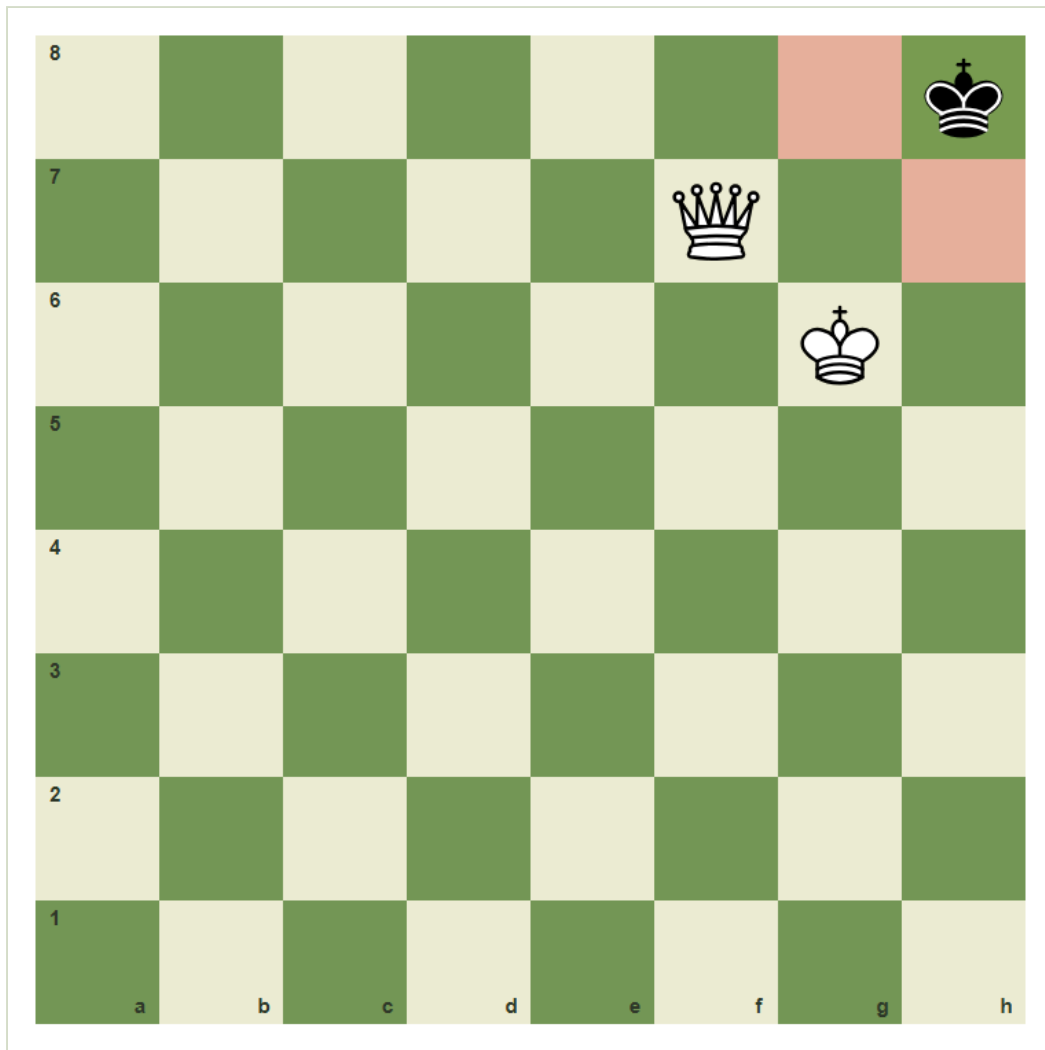
Deliver queen-supported mate

Move the queen from a1 to g7 to give checkmate.

Common Mistake

Common mistake: stalemate instead of mate

This looks winning because the king is trapped, but the black king is not in check. Trapped without check is stalemate, so the game is drawn.



No check on h8 means this is stalemate, not mate.

Chapter Checkpoint

What is checkmate?

Checkmate means:

- a. The king is in check with no legal escape
- b. The king has no legal move but is not checked
- c. The queen was captured

What is stalemate?

Stalemate means:

- a. No legal move and no check
- b. Check with no escape
- c. Both players have queens

Is stalemate a win?

Stalemate is:

- a. A draw
- b. A win for the player with more pieces
- c. A checkmate

Your First Guided Game

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Use the rules together in one short game.

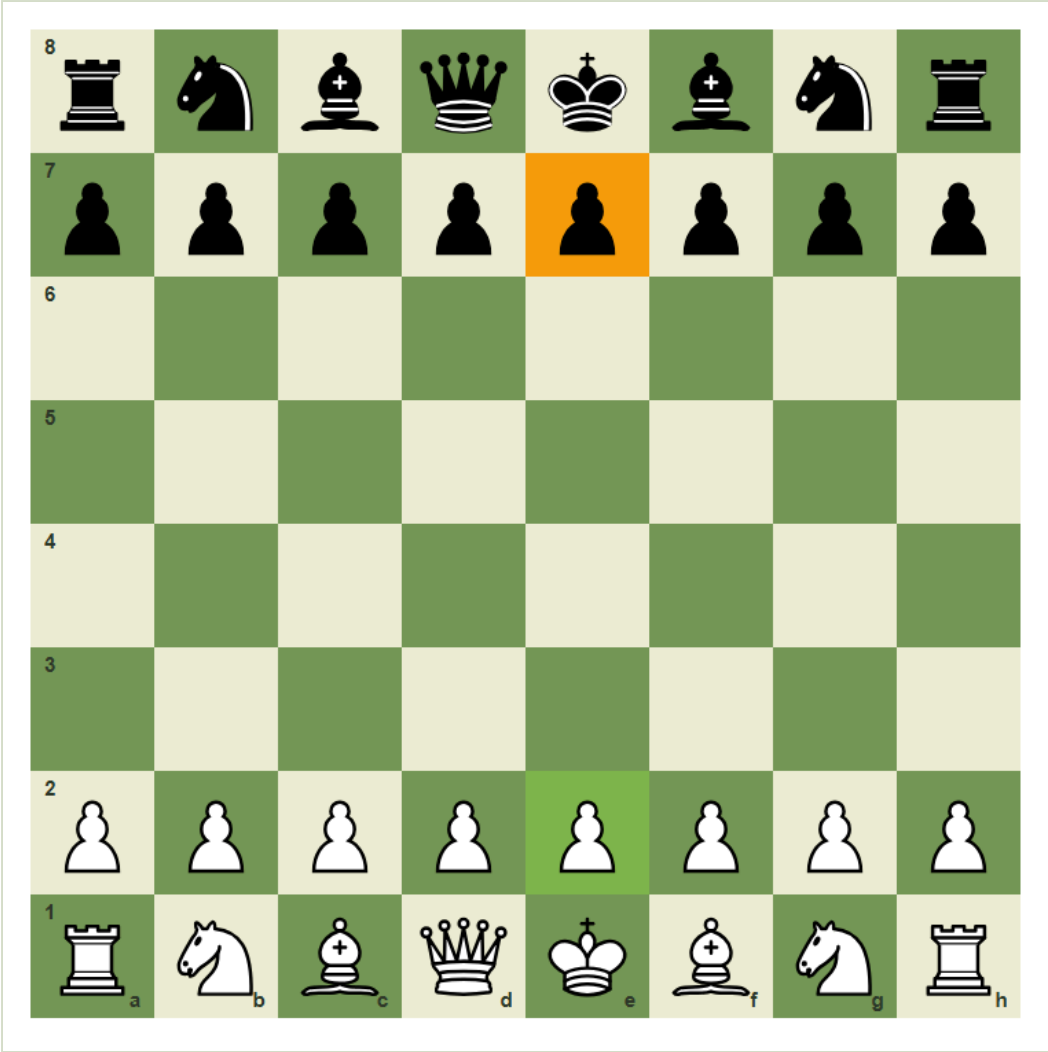
Learning objectives

- Play a legal opening sequence from the starting position.
- See how center control opens queen and bishop lines.
- Recognize a simple mate threat on f7.
- Complete a short guided game ending in checkmate.

A Short Legal Game

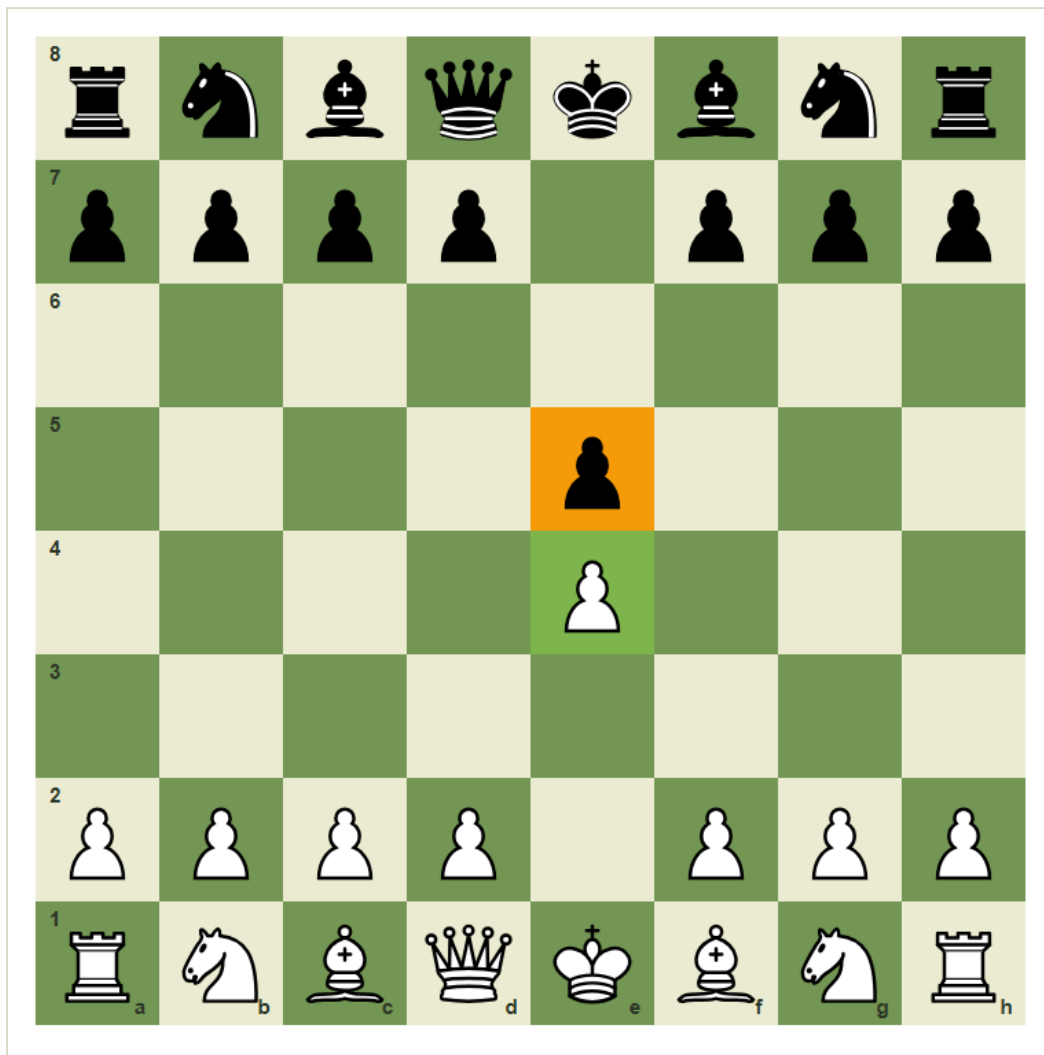
Now we connect the first rules into a real sequence. This short game is not a full opening course. Its purpose is to show how legal moves, piece lines, check, and checkmate fit together.

Start from the normal setup



The game begins from the correct starting position.

Both players claim the center

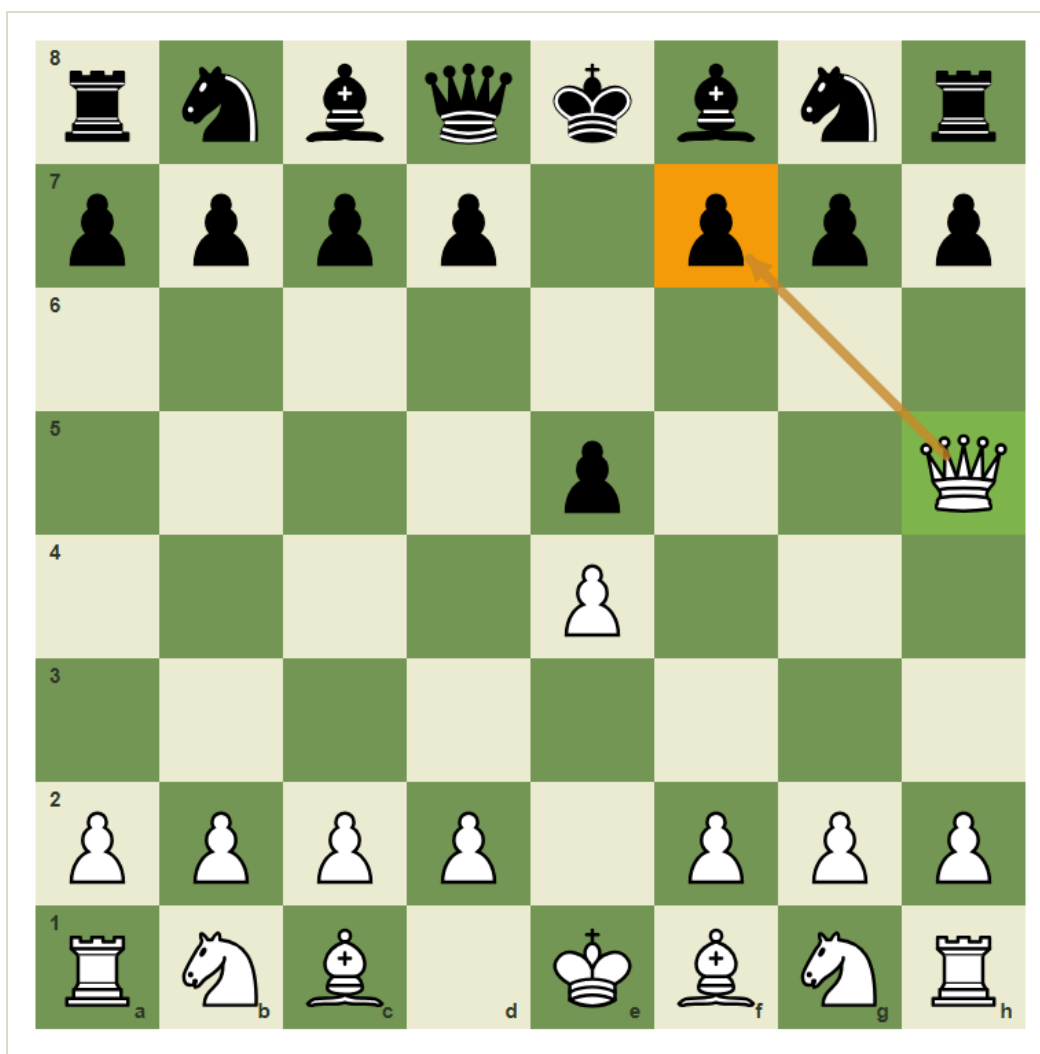


After 1.e4 e5, both center pawns stand in the middle.

Build The Mate Threat

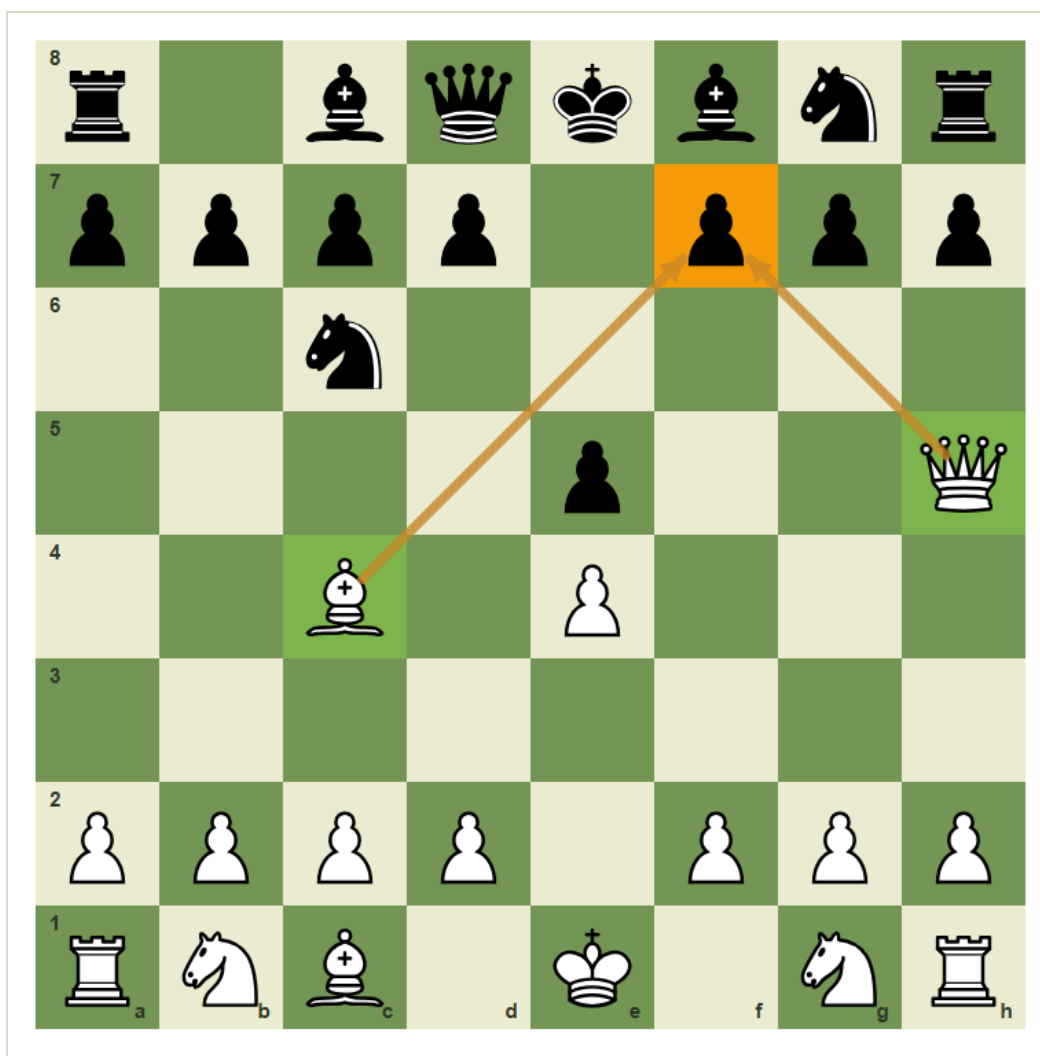
The weak f7 square is protected only by the Black king at the start. The White queen and bishop can team up on it.

Queen eyes f7



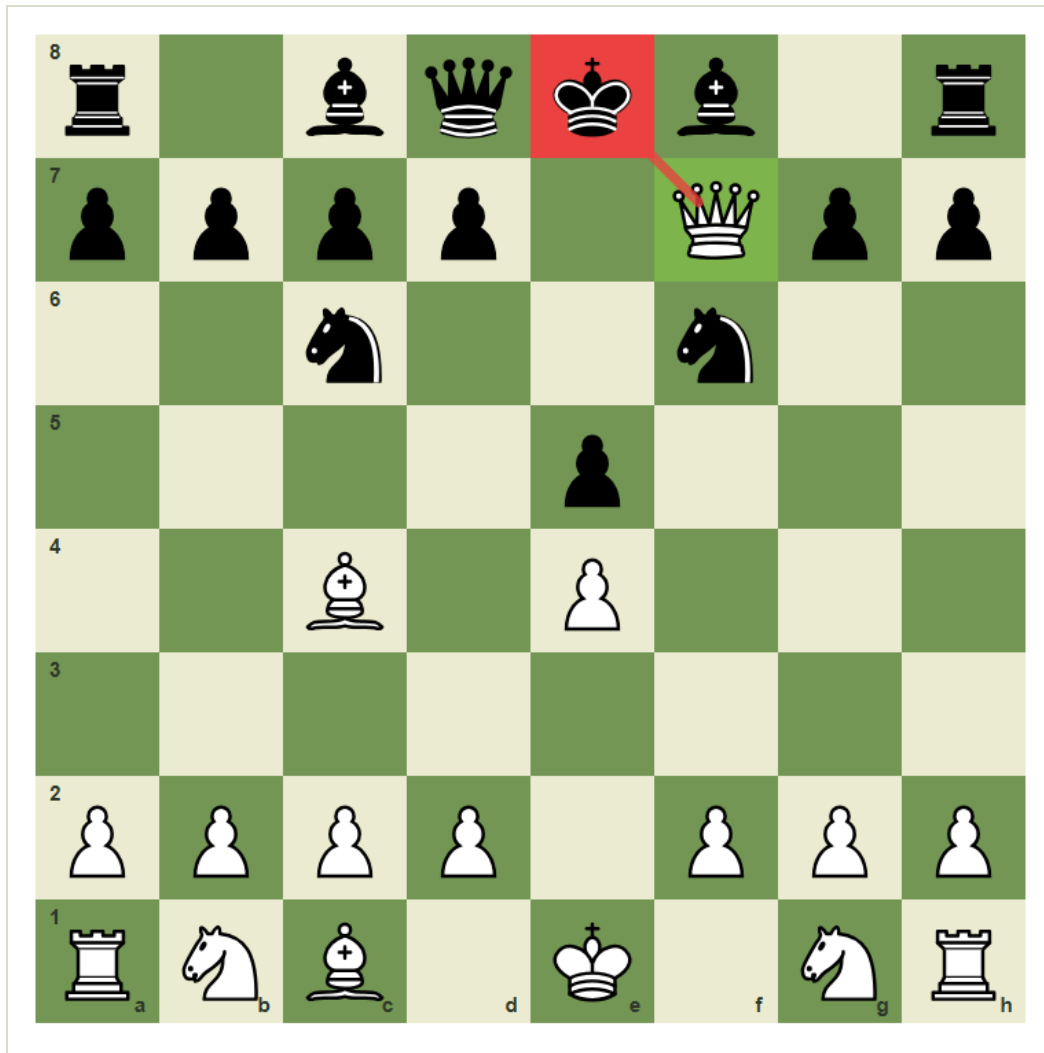
After Qh5, the queen attacks f7.

Bishop joins the attack



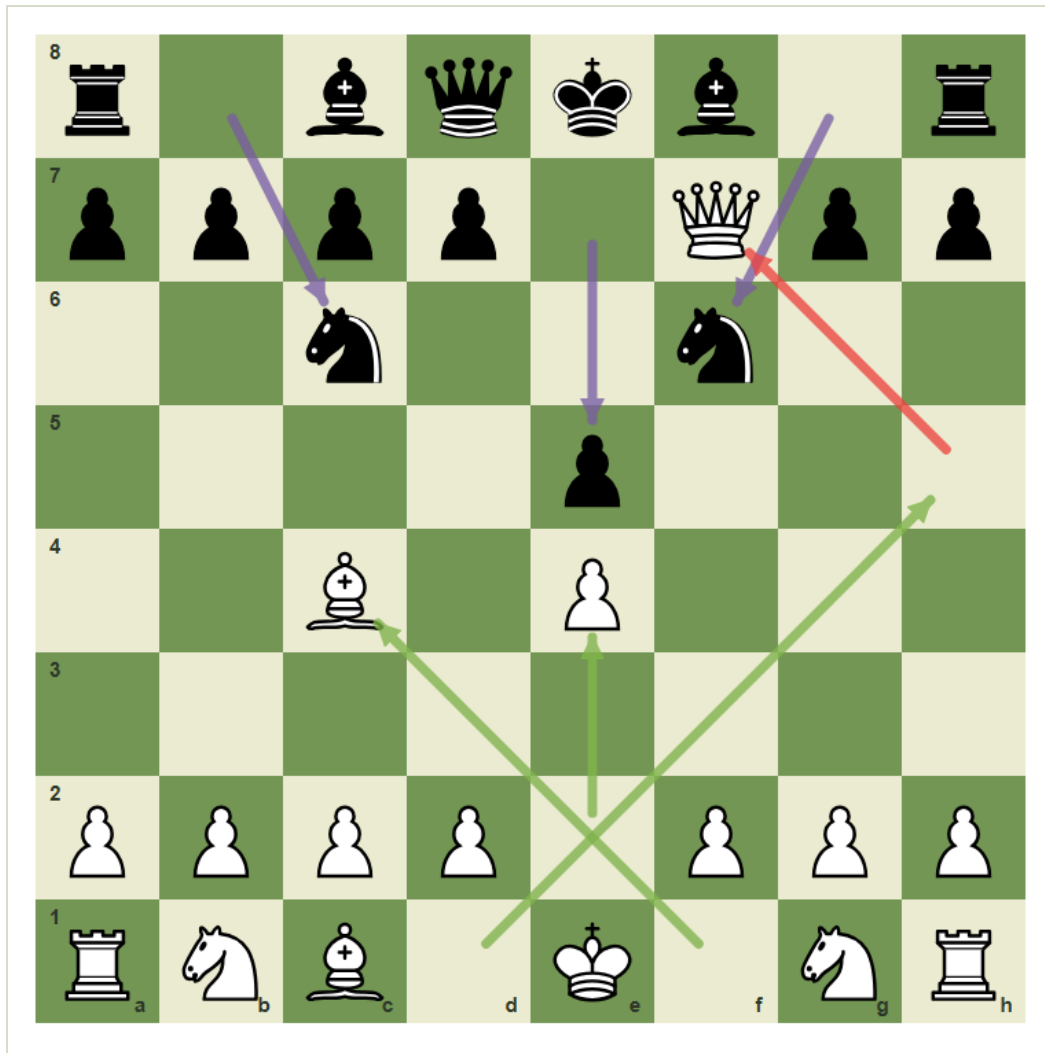
The bishop on c4 and queen on h5 both point at f7.

The final mate on f7



Qxf7 is checkmate in this beginner pattern because the queen is protected and the king has no good escape.

The full guided sequence



The sequence is 1.e4 e5 2.Qh5 Nc6 3.Bc4 Nf6 4.Qxf7#.

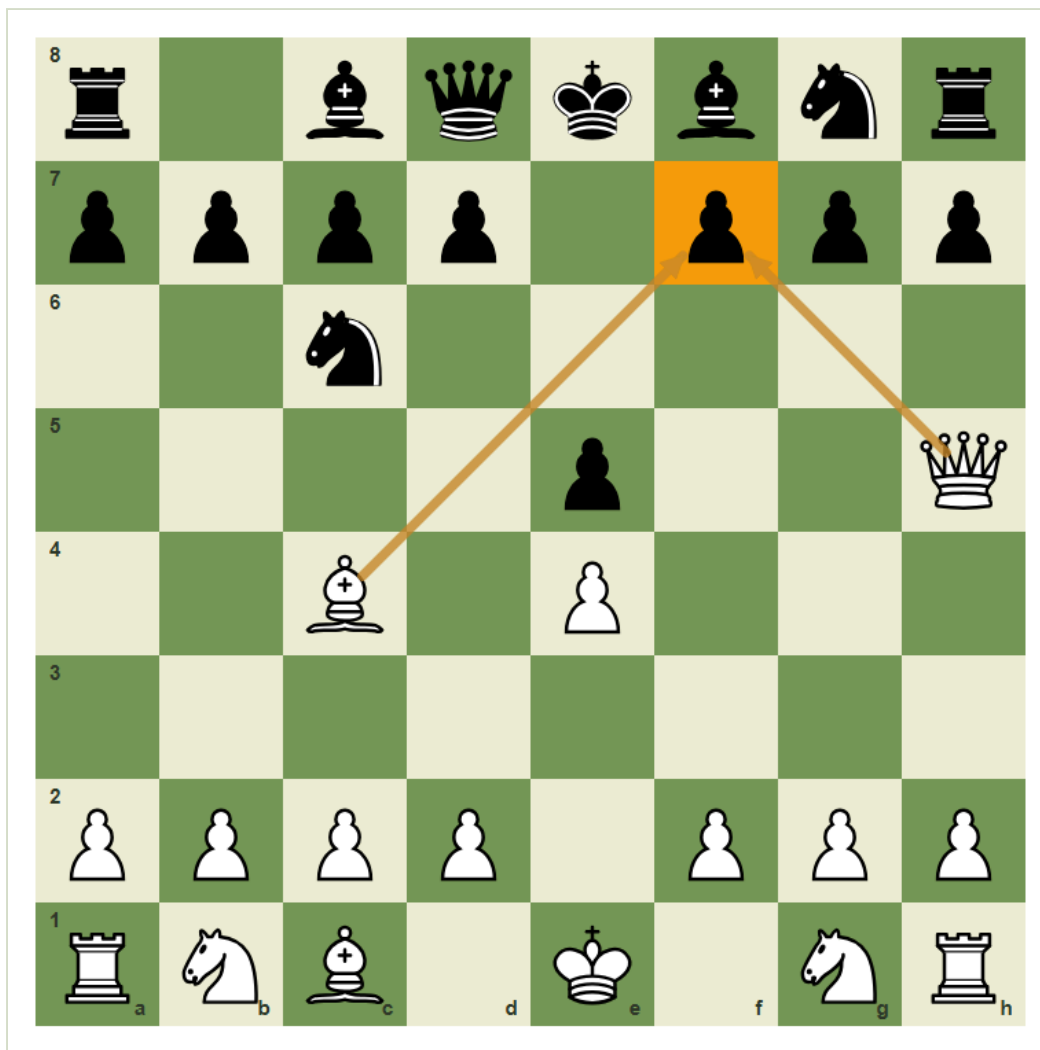
Play the checkmate move

White to move: capture f7 with the queen.

Common Mistake

Common mistake: moving without checking threats

Black must notice the threat on f7. A move that ignores both queen and bishop pressure can allow Qxf7 mate.



Both attacking pieces point to f7. The threat should be checked before moving.

Chapter Checkpoint

What did 1.e4 open?

The move 1.e4 helps open lines for:

- a. The queen and bishop
- b. Only the rook on a1
- c. Only the king

Which square was targeted?

In the guided game, White attacked:

- a. f7
- b. a8
- c. h1

What was the final move?

The final move of the guided game was:

- a. Qxf7#
- b. Nf3
- c. a3